

The Census of Static

****In a diaspora linked only by a slow, corrupted broadcast, to be counted is to exist.****

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Part I

Chapter 01 — The Ghost Ledger

Halversand rode the sea on a thousand joined platforms, and the Counting House stood on the oldest of them, where the timber was dark with a hundred years of salt. Beyond the shutters the water moved without end, and the city moved with it, a slow breathing of planks and rope. Markets floated between the rafts selling lamp-oil and dried fish, and the clerks of the lower offices walked the gangways with their counted ledgers under their arms. Vey Corwin had been born on a smaller raft and had come to the Counting House because she trusted numbers more than the sea did.

The bell that ruled the census floor rang the count in at the second hour and rang it closed at the tenth. Vey liked the bell less than she liked the cool of the place, but she answered it the way the sea answered the moon.

Below her desk the other clerks worked the household rolls, calling names aloud in the flat chant of the floor. Each name answered by a living person was a mark made and a life accounted. In that chant Tarn agreed with itself about who it was. Vey had always found comfort in it, until the quarter the chant had included nineteen names no one on the floor would claim.

She set her ledger on the slanted desk and read the quarter's column for the third time. The number at the bottom said one million, two hundred and four thousand, and nineteen. The number at the bottom was wrong.

Not by much. Nineteen phantom entries sat in the quarter's roll, names with no platform, no ward, no date of birth that matched any archive Vey had ever seen. They appeared every quarter, as regular as the tide schedule that pulled at the

platform beneath the city. Someone was being counted who could not be placed.

Every quarter the Counting House sent its count up the relay to the wider Spill, and every quarter the wider count sent something back, degraded and late. The phantoms arrived with that return. Vey had stopped trusting the return the way she had stopped trusting weather forecasts made on another world.

She had taken to opening the archive of household marks whenever the phantoms returned, matching each impossible mark against the thousands Tarn had filed since the first raft. None of the nineteen matched a Tarn mark. They followed a logic of their own, a consistent ordering of weirs and deep-households that described a place with wards and water and families, none of it on any chart she had ever been given. Whoever had written those marks had counted carefully, the way Mossa had counted lanterns, as if the count itself were a kind of shelter.

She tapped the page with the end of her stylus. The phantoms had no faces in the record, only strings: a given name, a household mark, a ward that did not exist on any map of the floating city. One of them read Ossa, mark of the third weir, Ward Nine. There was no third weir on Halversand and no Ward Nine. Another read Pellin, deep-household, Ward Nine. A third carried only a mark and the same impossible ward. In the old paper ledgers they would have been crossed out by a senior hand. The Counting House had switched to the relay-linked register three years before, and the relay did not cross things out. It appended.

Vey had asked Pell about the phantoms in her first year. Pell Aron supervised the counting floor, and he had answered the way a person describes a roof that leaks in the season it leaks, as if the fact needed no repair. The register cleaned itself overnight, he said, and the extra lines were residue from the quarterly sync with the Spill's broader count.

She had believed him for a while. Then the phantoms had grown a habit. They returned with the same names.

A count was meant to name the living. Vey had learned the craft from a woman named Mossa who kept tallies on the oyster rafts, counting families by the lanterns they hung above the water. Mossa's lanterns swung in rows down the raft-line, and each lit panes meant a household that had come back from the north current that day. One autumn night a single lantern had stayed dark, and Mossa had taken the counting skiff down the line in the rain to find out why. She came back with a name to add to the count and a cold hand to warm, because the sea kept what it took and a census was the only argument against it. Vey had been twelve, and she had watched Mossa write the name as if writing it could pull the lost body back to the raft.

When Vey came to the Counting House she had carried that lesson like a tool. A name left out of the count was a body left in the sea. She had refused, more than once, to close a quarter while a household sat uncounted, and Pell had covered for her more than once.

The register on Tarn had forgotten that part. It counted and moved on.

She opened the drawer where the paper backups lived, the ones the relay could not reach, and pulled the quarter before this one. Same nineteen names. Same impossible ward. The phantoms did not drift. They held.

"Corwin." Pell's voice came from the door. "You're here past the bell again."

"I'm here because the bell rang on a count that doesn't close." She turned the page so he could see the column. "Nineteen. Same as last quarter. Same names."

Pell came in and set his own ledger down. He was older than she was by twenty years and carried the tiredness of a man who had decided most arguments before they started. He read the phantoms without surprise.

"You sync the register to the Spill count," he said. "Residue. I told you."

"The Spill count arrives corrupted. We both know that. If these were residue they would change every time. These are the same people."

"Then they're someone's error, repeated."

"On a ward that isn't on the map?" Vey pointed to the mark. "There is no Ward Nine on Halversand. There never was. So either the map is wrong or the count is pulling names from somewhere the map doesn't reach."

Pell was quiet. He looked at the names the way he looked at weather he meant to walk into anyway.

"Leave it for the overnight clean," he said at last. "It closes the books. That's the work."

"It closes the books by pretending nineteen people aren't in them."

"Some counts are kept by pretending. You'll learn which ones."

He left her with the lantern and the false column.

Alone, she ran the reconciliation by hand, the way the old clerks had before the register learned to clean itself. She totaled the living households, subtracted the dead filed that quarter, and placed the remainder against the phantoms. The arithmetic was stubborn: nineteen people sat in the count with no home in the city. A registry that cleaned itself should have swallowed them. Instead it carried them, quarter after quarter, as if something outside the Counting House insisted they remain.

Vey did not run the overnight clean. She copied the nineteen names into her own small book, the one she kept for things the register would not hold, and she wrote beneath them: not residue.

The next morning she took the names to the relay room.

Tarn Redoubt sat at the edge of the platform where the sea wind never stopped. The relay there was a low iron building with a hum you felt in your teeth, and in that hum lived the Static, the carried voice of a Spill that could no longer meet face to face. Vey had only been inside twice, to file the quarter's count upward to the wider count. The teller on duty was a young woman with ink on her thumb and a

name Vey had heard on the floor but never used.

"Cira," Vey said, reading it off the shift board.

The teller looked up from a coil of cable. "Census-taker. You're far from the counting floor."

"I need to query the Spill count for a set of names." Vey set the list on the console. "Local sync left entries I can't place."

Cira squinted at the page. "These aren't Tarn wards."

"I know. That's why I'm asking the wider count."

"Wide query takes years to come back, and it comes back half-eaten." Cira said it without apology. The Static was slow and it was hungry, and everyone who used it knew. "Send it anyway, you'll wait till the next census cycle for a reply that's missing teeth."

Send it.

Cira told her how the Static treated a message on the long road across the Spill. Each relay hop dropped a little and altered a little; characters arrived swapped, whole packets fell out, and a name could survive as only its first and last letters. That was why a wide query came back missing teeth. It was also why a string that held its place across three logs was not chance. Something was pushing it through on purpose, or something had failed to stop it.

Cira tapped the keys and the relay took the query the way a well takes a stone, without sound. Vey watched the confirmation print on the narrow paper: QUERY FILED. RETURN EXPECTED SY 314. Two years, if the Spill answered at all, and the answer would arrive missing teeth.

She took the slip and went back to the Counting House. Two years was longer than the phantoms had been a secret. She could wait, or she could look closer.

She looked closer.

The register kept a log of every sync, and the sync carried more than the count. It carried the degraded echo of other worlds' transmissions, the ones the relay forwarded on their long way across the Spill. Most of that noise was scrap. Some of it, Vey had started to suspect, was not.

She pulled the last three sync logs and laid them side by side on the desk. In the corrupted margin of a transmission that had started on a world she could not name, a string repeated across all three logs, in the same ragged position each time. Random corruption would not hold a place. A repeating string in the same place meant a repeating transmission, one the relay kept forwarding despite whatever else it did to the message around it. The same string the phantoms spelled, letter by letter, when the register tried to place them.

Vey set the three corrupted copies against one another and filled the gaps the way Mossa had filled a torn net, by what the surrounding mesh demanded. From the first log she kept the open and the close. From the second she took the middle,

where the corruption had bitten elsewhere. From the third she recovered a word that looked like a people's name, spelled in a script the register had tried and failed to place. She could not read it yet. She could see that it was a name, and that it sat at the head of a list, and that the list went on for nineteen entries before it stopped. The phantoms in Tarn's roll were the tail of that same list, dragged across the Spill by a sync that should have dropped them.

The phantoms were not Tarn's error. They were someone else's people, bleeding through the sync because the relay had not fully silenced them.

Vey sat with that for a long time. A census was supposed to describe the living, and the living on Tarn had been counting, every quarter, a set of names the Spill had tried to lose.

She thought of her brother, who had gone out on the north current ten years before and came back only on a casualty list that the Counting House had closed without him. He had been counted out by a mistake no senior would undo, and the mistake had stayed. Vey had learned then what a count could do to a person it decided to drop, and she had not spoken his name in the Counting House since.

The brother had been a strong rower and a poor counter, and he had laughed at her for loving the ledgers. The ledgers had outlasted him, and then they had failed him, and Vey had not forgiven the count for that. She would not let a count fail a stranger the way it had failed him, not while she held the stylus and the small book and the will to write a name where the register left a blank.

She wrote in her small book: the count kept them when nothing else would. And then, because she had been taught to finish what a ledger started, she wrote the date and closed the book and went to find Pell.

He was in the upper office, going over the bell roster. She put the sync log in front of him.

"Read the margin," she said.

He read. His face did the small, private thing faces do when they recognize a thing they hoped not to.

"Where did you get this," he said. It was not a question about the room.

"From the sync. The phantoms aren't residue, Pell. They're a people the wider count dropped and the sync keeps dragging back. Someone up the relay decided they shouldn't be counted."

Pell closed the log. "And someone down here decided you should stop reading margins."

"I'm a census-taker. Reading is the work."

"You read past the work when the work was kept quiet on purpose." He stood and went to the window, where the sea moved under the platform like a thought under a house. "There are counts that hold the Spill together by leaving things out. You start putting them back in, you start a thing no one on Tarn can close."

"Then it should have been left out where I could see it, not hidden in a margin."

Pell turned back. For a moment he looked like he might say more, the way a person stands at the top of a stair they have decided not to walk down. His hand rested on the sync log as if he had known what it held before she opened it. Then he only said, "Run the overnight clean, Corwin. Please."

She did not answer. She took the log and her small book and left him with the sea.

In the relay room, Cira was still on shift. Vey stopped at the console and asked, without explaining why, how often a sync carried a string the local register could not place.

"Happens," Cira said. "The mesh forwards everything. Most of it's garbage by the time it reaches us. Some of it's a ward that doesn't exist here because it exists somewhere else and the relay's forgetting where." She tapped a dial and brought a flat green line up on a side screen. "See that? That's a frequency the console won't tune to anymore. One day it sang, next day this. Quarantine, they call it. Not my call. Comes from the Ledger-House."

"Quiet," Vey said. "Not lost."

"Quiet's worse," Cira said. "Lost means it's still trying to reach you. Quiet means someone decided it shouldn't."

Vey watched the flat green line until Cira cleared it. A frequency that had sung and now did not sang still, in a way, in the absence it left. She thought of the nineteen names and the quiet frequency and understood, with a calm that surprised her, that she was already on the other side of Pell's warning. The count had kept these people. She meant to keep them louder.

Vey thanked her and walked back through the wind to the Counting House. The nineteen names waited in her small book. The register would erase them by morning if she let it run the clean.

She thought about the oyster rafts and the lantern count. Her teacher had taught that a missing lantern meant a walk down the raft-line, not a stroke of ink. The Spill had stopped walking. Tarn, without meaning to, had kept a few of the lanterns lit.

The rafts were long gone from Vey's life, but the lesson had not gone with them. She had chosen the Counting House over the sea because the count was a raft that never sank. Now the count itself had sprung a leak, and the leak was full of names. She meant to bail it, one household at a time, until the Spill remembered what it had tried to drown.

That night Vey did not run the clean. She sat in the Counting House with the lantern and the nineteen names and the echo of a people the Spill had tried to lose. She copied the names a second time, slower, so the count in her hand could not be appended over or cleaned away. Then she wrote one line at the bottom, the first decision of a longer argument:

I will find out who they are. The count keeps them, and I am the count.

She wondered who the nineteen were, on whatever ward the map refused to name. They were being counted by a world that did not know them and a relay that had been told to forget them, counted against the will of everyone who touched the number. That, Vey thought, was the strangest census of all: a people kept in the record by the very hand that meant to erase them. She had spent her life trusting the count to name the living. Now the count was naming the erased, and the only honest thing left was to read what it had written.

Outside, the tide pulled at the platform, and the relay at the edge of the city hummed its slow, hungry song into the dark. Somewhere in that hum, a frequency was quiet that should have been singing, and a handful of names on a water-world were the only proof it had ever sung at all.

Chapter 02 — What the Relay Keeps

The Counting House kept two clocks, and only one of them told the truth. The brass bell above the census floor measured the day, ringing the count in at the second hour and out at the tenth. The other clock lived in the relay room at the edge of Halversand, where the sea wind never stopped, and it measured something slower. Vey Corwin had learned to trust the second one more.

She had carried the nineteen names in her small book for three days. The overnight clean had run each night and had swallowed them each time, and each morning she had copied them back before the floor woke. A count that cleaned itself was a count that forgot on command, and Vey had stopped trusting anything that forgot on command.

The phantoms had begun as a puzzle in her first year at the House. They had become, by the third day, a question she could not put down. Who were the nineteen? What ward held a third weir and a Ward Nine that no chart of Halversand had ever carried? The register appended; it did not invent. Something outside the city was feeding those names into the sync, and the sync was dragging them across the Spill despite the long road and the lossy hops.

Vey decided to ask the wider count directly.

The relay console on the census floor was a narrow thing, bolted to the wall beside the senior clerks' benches, used mostly to push Tarn's quarterly total up toward the Authorized Census. It could also file a query, a directed question sent out along the mesh to whatever world or station held the matching record. Cira at Tarn Redoubt had told her, two years and a world of distance ago in conversation, that a wide query came back half-eaten and years late. Vey had filed the brother's correction request the same way and had waited two years for a reply that never arrived clean.

She set the nineteen names on the console and keyed the query herself. The

machine asked for a target. She gave it the impossible ward and the deep-household marks and let the relay decide where the string belonged. The keys clicked under her fingers the way the tally beads had clicked in Mossa's hands, and the console took the question the way a well takes a stone. A directed query cost the House nothing but bandwidth and patience, and Tarn had a little of the first and no use for the second while the phantoms kept arriving.

The console asked whether she wanted the reply held for her hand alone or filed to the floor's open record. Vey chose her hand alone. Whatever the wider count said about the nineteen, she did not want it cleaned before she read it. The machine accepted the choice without comment, the way relay equipment accepted everything, and began the long work of pushing her question out across the mesh.

A line of narrow paper printed: QUERY FILED. RETURN EXPECTED SY 314.

Two years, if the Spill answered at all. Vey tore the slip free and read the date twice. SY 312 now; the answer would land in SY 314, and by then the phantoms would have appeared eight more times in eight more quarters. She could wait. She had never been good at waiting, and the sync logs in the archive drawer were not going anywhere.

She pulled the last three sync logs and laid them across her slanted desk.

The sync was not only Tarn's count coming home. It was the echo of every world's transmissions, forwarded by the relay on the long road across the Spill, degraded and re-forwarded until they reached Halversand as noise with a shape. Most of that shape was scrap. Some of it, Vey had come to suspect, was a message the relay had failed to fully silence.

In the corrupted margin of a transmission that had started on a world she could not name, a string repeated across all three logs. It sat in the same ragged position each time, a knot of characters that survived the corruption where everything around it fell apart. Random degradation would not hold a place. A repeating string in the same place meant a repeating transmission, one the mesh kept forwarding despite whatever else it did to the message around it.

Vey set the three corrupted copies against one another and filled the gaps the way Mossa had filled a torn net, by what the surrounding mesh demanded. From the first log she kept the open and the close. From the second she took the middle, where the corruption had bitten elsewhere. From the third she recovered a fragment that looked like a people's name, spelled in a script the register had tried and failed to place.

The fragment was not Tarn.

Halversand's wards ran in a clean numeric order, and the register knew every one of them by heart. The fragment carried a different order, a different numbering, a different sense of how a household sat in the water. Whoever had written it had counted carefully, the way Mossa had counted lanterns, as if the count itself were a kind of shelter. The nineteen phantom names in Tarn's roll were

the tail of that same list, dragged across the Spill by a sync that should have dropped them.

Vey ran her stylus down the column of recovered characters and measured the fragment against the phantoms she already knew. The spacing matched. The household marks matched. The repeating string that the corruption could not eat sat at the head of both, as if whatever voice had spoken it meant it to arrive first, before the count, before the names, before anything the relay could still manage to lose. She had seen corrupted transmissions before; none of them had ever held a place like that. Corruption scattered. This held.

She copied the fragment into her small book beneath the names. She wrote: not residue, not Tarn. Then she wrote the date, because her teacher had taught that a count unanswered was a count unfinished, and she meant to finish this one.

The fragment repeated a single string that the corruption had not been able to eat. Vey read it aloud once, under her breath, to fix its shape in her ear. The sound of it was wrong for Tarn — too round, too full of water, as if the name had been spoken into a deep and come back changed. She wrote it down a second time and closed the book on it.

Cira had explained once how the Static treated a message on the long road across the Spill. Each relay hop dropped a little and altered a little; characters arrived swapped, whole packets fell out, and a name could survive as only its first and last letters. That was why a wide reply came back missing teeth. It was also why a string that held its place across three logs was not chance. Something was pushing it through on purpose, or something had failed to stop it, and either way the failure had left Vey a word she could not yet read. She would learn to read it. The count had given her time, and she meant to spend it.

A count was meant to name the living. Vey had learned the craft from a woman who kept tallies on the oyster rafts, counting families by the lanterns they hung above the water. Each lit pane meant a household that had come back from the north current that day. One autumn night a single lantern had stayed dark, and Mossa had taken the counting skiff down the raft-line in the rain to find out why. She came back with a name to add to the count and a cold hand to warm, because the sea kept what it took and a census was the only argument against it.

When Vey came to the Counting House she had carried that lesson like a tool. A name left out of the count was a body left in the sea, and she had refused more than once to close a quarter while a household sat uncounted. The register on Tarn had forgotten that part. It counted and moved on, and the moved-on was where the phantoms lived.

She had learned that lesson the hard way, on a casualty list that had closed without her brother and never been reopened. The phantoms on her desk would not get the same quiet erasure.

A voice came from the door behind her.

"Corwin. You're bent over those logs like they owe you money."

Pell Aron leaned in the frame, a ledger under one arm and the weariness of a man who had decided most arguments before they started. He supervised the counting floor and had for longer than Vey had been alive on Halversand, and in the twenty years above her he had learned to read a clerk's posture the way other people read weather.

"I'm bent over them because they keep telling me a ward that isn't on the map," Vey said.

Pell came in and set his ledger on the corner of her desk. He was wary in the specific way of a person who has seen a small problem become a large one, and who suspects this is that kind of small problem. He did not ask which logs. He looked at the open page the way he looked at weather he meant to walk into anyway.

"You filed a wide query," he said. It was not a question.

"I did. The phantoms aren't residue, Pell. They're a people the wider count dropped and the sync keeps dragging back. This fragment —" she tapped the page — "comes from a world that isn't Tarn and a ward the map refuses to name. Someone up the relay decided they shouldn't be counted."

Pell was quiet for a moment that stretched the way silence stretches on a platform when the wind drops. He read the fragment without surprise, and his face did the small private thing faces do when they recognize a thing they hoped not to. His thumb found the edge of the page the way a person finds the edge of a table they mean not to lean on, and he did not lean.

"You read the sync again," he said. It was not quite a question, and not quite a scold. "I told you in your first year the extra lines were residue. You've been at the margins ever since."

"I read the margins because the count wouldn't close," Vey said. "Residue changes every quarter. These hold."

"Holding isn't the same as true." Pell's voice was low, the wary tone of a supervisor who had covered for a clerk more than once and had begun to wonder where the covering would end. "Some things hold because someone tied them in place. You don't always get to see the knot."

"Then someone down here decided you should stop reading margins," he said at last.

"Then I'll be the one who keeps reading them," Vey said.

Pell stood and went to the window, where the wind dragged at the platform the way a thought drags at a house. "You've read past the count into why someone kept the count quiet," he said. "Some tallies hold the Spill together by what they leave unnumbered. You start filling those gaps and you start something no office on Tarn can close."

His tone was wary, not unkind. Vey had seen Pell cover for her more than once when she refused to close a quarter on an uncounted household, and she had learned to read the difference in him between warning and scolding. This was a warning, and underneath it something like protection.

"Then it should have been left out where I could see it," she said, "not hidden in a margin the register tries to clean away."

Pell turned back. For a moment he looked like he might say more, the way a person stands at the top of a stair they have decided not to walk down. His hand rested on the sync log as if he had known what it held before she opened it.

"Run the overnight clean, Corwin. Please."

She did not answer. She took the log and her small book and left him with the sea and the bell and the two clocks that did not agree.

In the relay room at the edge of the city the wind came straight off the water and did not care who it found there. The iron building hummed with the Static, the carried voice of a Spill that could no longer meet face to face, and that hum lived in Vey's teeth the way a tune lives in a jaw. She had only been inside the Redoubt twice before, to file the quarter's count upward, and the place still felt like standing inside a held breath.

Cira was on shift, ink on her thumb, a coil of cable half-unspooled across the console. She looked up without surprise. The tellers at Tarn Redoubt had stopped being surprised by Vey some quarters back.

"Census-taker. You file a query this morning?"

"I did."

"Wide one, by the print you left. You'll wait till SY three-fourteen for a reply that's missing teeth." Cira said it without apology. The Static was slow and it was hungry, and everyone who used it knew. "Send it anyway. The mesh forwards everything, even the parts someone up the line wanted quiet."

"Forwarding isn't keeping," Vey said.

"Forwarding's worse. Keeping means someone chose to remember. Forwarding means the noise got out on its own and nobody managed to stop it." Cira tapped a dial and brought a flat green line up on a side screen. "See that? A frequency the console won't tune to anymore. One day it sang, next day this. Quarantine, they call it. Not my call. Comes from the Ledger-House."

"Quiet," Vey said. "Not lost."

"Quiet's worse. Lost means it's still trying to reach you. Quiet means someone decided it shouldn't." Cira cleared the line and went back to her cable. "Your fragment's like that. It shouldn't have made it this far. Something's pushing it through, or something failed to stop it. Either way, it's not Tarn's noise."

Vey watched the blank screen a moment longer. A frequency that had sung and now did not sang still, in a way, in the absence it left. She thought of the nineteen

names and the quiet frequency and understood, with a calm that surprised her, that she was already on the other side of Pell's warning.

The phantoms were not Tarn's error. They were someone else's people, bleeding through the sync because the relay had not fully silenced them, counted against the will of everyone who touched the number. That, Vey thought, was the strangest census of all: a people kept in the record by the very hand that meant to erase them.

She walked back through the wind to the Counting House. The nineteen names waited in her small book, and the fragment waited beneath them, and the register would erase both by morning if she let it run the clean. The query she had filed would not answer until SY 314, two years off, and the answer would arrive missing teeth, as every wide reply did. Vey was not waiting for it. The sync had already answered her in the only language it still spoke: a fragment that held its place, and a people the Spill had tried and failed to lose.

She thought of the relay at the city's edge, still humming its slow hungry song, and of the frequency Cira had shown her gone quiet by order from the Ledger-House. A people the Spill had tried to lose was still arriving, quarter after quarter, because the sync had not finished forgetting them. The query she had filed would travel that same road, and something on the far side might finally answer it.

She would not run the clean. Let the register try; the names in her small book were copied now, safe from its overnight appetite. At the bottom of the page she wrote the first decision of a longer argument:

The query is sent into the Static. The ward the map refuses will be found. I am the clerk who would not let it be cleaned away.

A query sent into the Static was a kind of prayer, Vey had decided, in that it asked a question of something vast and slow and received an answer shaped more by the distance than by the truth. She had learned to read the corruption as a language of its own. A dropped packet told you where the relay had strained. A swapped character told you which hop had grown old. The repeating string slipped past that explanation, because noise did not repeat itself with such patience. Something on the far side was sending the same word, again and again, as if it feared the Static would forget it between hops. Vey found that fear moving, and then found it dangerous, because a thing the relay was told to forget did not usually get to keep shouting. The nineteen names on her roll were the echo of that shout, arriving one quarter late and one ward short, and she had decided to answer it. Pell could call it residue all he liked. Residue did not write itself in a foreign hand, or count its households by weirs, or wait through the dark for someone on a water-world to notice. She would be that someone. The count had kept the names this long against the will of the wider census; she meant to keep them louder, and to find the ward the map refused to draw.

She wondered who the nineteen were, on whatever ward the map refused to

name, and what the repeating string truly said when the corruption let it stand whole. They were being counted by a world that did not know them and a relay that had been told to forget them, counted against the will of everyone who touched the number. Outside, the tide pulled at the platform, and the relay at the edge of the city hummed its slow, hungry song into the dark. Somewhere in that hum, a frequency was quiet that should have been singing, and a fragment of a name on a water-world was the only proof it had ever sung at all.

Chapter 03 — The Teller's Apprentice

The Redoubt kept its own weather. Cira Vell felt it in the soles of her boots before she felt it in the air: the iron floor carried a vibration that the sea outside only suggested. She had worked the relay console for eleven months and still checked that hum first thing, the way her father had checked the tide gauge on the raft where she grew up. A steady hum meant the mesh was forwarding. A flat one meant a block.

Morning light came sideways through the louvers and striped the cable racks. Cira pulled the night's raw log from the spool and settled at the comparison desk, where the curated copy from the Ledger-House sat in its own tray. The two were supposed to be the same record, cleaned. The Redoubt held the raw. The Concordance held the curated. Her job, on paper, was to confirm they agreed.

She unspooled the raw first. The night had been quiet on the local bands, the usual Tarn-to-Tarn chatter of platform repairs and fishing quotas, all of it clean and fast because it never left the world. The interesting traffic lived in the far margin, the degraded echo of transmissions that had crossed half the Spill before a relay hop dropped them onto Tarn's receivers. That was the stratum the curators at the Ledger-House read, and the stratum they edited.

Cira had learned to read both at once. She set the curated sheet beside the raw and ran her finger down the timestamps. For the first three hundred lines they matched. The local bands were identical because no one had reason to touch them. The divergence began at the long-range margin, where the curated sheet had done something the raw had not.

There. Line three hundred and twelve. The raw carried a packet tagged from a world Cira could not name, its header half-corrupted, its payload a string of characters that held a repeating shape through the noise. The curated sheet showed that line replaced by a single mark of the house's own, a tidy glyph meaning **resolved by correction**. Cira had seen that glyph a hundred times. It meant the Ledger-House had decided the line carried nothing worth keeping.

She frowned and scrolled back. The same repeating string appeared in the raw at lines two hundred and four, four hundred and nine, and five hundred and eleven, each time in the same ragged band of the margin, each time half-eaten by corruption but holding its place. A string that survived four separate hops with its

position intact was not the work of entropy. Entropy scattered. This string refused to scatter.

Cira pulled the curated sheet for those three lines. Each had been marked *resolved by correction*. Four erasures, four clean glyphs, one repeating signal gone. The pattern was too regular to be accident. She had been taught that the Static degraded everything it carried, that lost packets were the price of distance, that the curated census kept the honest remainder after the noise was swept away. The remainder in front of her looked less like swept noise and more like a chosen silence.

She leaned back and tapped the desk with her stylus. The relay forwarded everything it received. That rule governed the mesh, older than the Concordance that now ran it. A packet that arrived at Tarn had been forwarded by every beacon between its origin and the Redoubt, each hop dropping a little and altering a little. The raw log displayed the mesh doing its job: carrying, degrading, but carrying still. The curated sheet showed a hand reaching into the carried stream and taking specific lines out.

Cira did not yet know what the repeating string said. She knew only that four copies of it had reached Tarn and four copies had been removed before the count went up the chain. That was not entropy. Entropy did not pick.

She opened the correction protocol next, the house's own manual for how a curated sheet got built from a raw spool. Every Teller learned the shape of it in the first week: the console hashed each raw line, compared the hash to a registry of known-good patterns, and passed the line up if it matched. Lines that failed the match fell to a second pass, where a curator at the Ledger-House read the degraded text by eye and decided whether the loss left anything worth counting. The protocol called this second pass *reconciliation*. Cira had always pictured reconciliation as a person squinting at noise and rescuing the signal from it.

The night's raw let her test that picture. She pulled the protocol's rule for a failed hash and read it against the four erased lines. A failed hash should have sent each line to reconciliation, where a curator would have seen the repeating string and judged it. Instead the curated sheet carried the house glyph for *resolved by correction* on all four, a glyph the protocol reserved for lines the console itself discarded as empty. The lines were not empty. They carried the repeating string, half-eaten but present. The console had not discarded them for being empty. Something had marked them for removal before reconciliation ever saw them.

Cira checked the protocol's flow chart a second time to be sure she read it right. The chart showed two paths out of a failed hash: up to reconciliation, or down to the discard pile. The discard pile required a flag the console set automatically when a line held no recoverable characters. The four lines held recoverable characters. The flag should not have been set. Yet the curated sheet showed the flag set, the line discarded, the glyph printed, the count closed. The only way that happened was if the flag had been raised by hand, after the fact, on lines someone

had already decided to lose.

A hand-raised discard marked the work of a person. Entropy never raised a flag. A storm at the relay bent a signal and broke it; it did not walk into the record afterward and stamp the broken line with a tidy mark of correction. The printed stamp convinced her more than the gap had. A natural loss left a gap. A curated loss left a glyph, and the glyph said the loss had been accounted for, which meant a person had accounted for it.

She turned to the checksum the console kept on each curated sheet. The house signed every sheet it pushed down with a seal-hash, so a station could prove the copy had not been altered in transit. Cira pulled the seal-hash for the night's sheet and compared it to the raw spool's own hash, taken before the clean. The two should have described the same record after correction. They described different records. The curated sheet's seal covered a text that no longer contained the four lines. The raw spool's hash covered a text that did. Between the two sat the erasure, and the erasure carried the house's own signature, not the relay's.

That distinction mattered more than the missing lines themselves. A relay that forgot left no signature; the forget lived in the gap and the gap spoke for itself. A house that removed left a seal, because the removal had to be authorized, logged, and pushed down as if it were the truth the station should keep. The Static presented itself as a forgetful medium. The seal-hash proved the forgetting had an office.

Cira wrote none of this in the station log. She wrote it on the back of the cable-note paper, in the same plain hand she used for measurements, because the station log would be the first thing the morning clean touched. The raw spool would overwrite. The curated sheet would arrive and assert itself as the record. The only durable copy of what she had just learned would be the one she carried out of the room.

She set the protocol aside and looked at the four lines again, the repeating string ragged in its band. The protocol had given her the how: a hand-raised discard flag, a seal-hash that covered a smaller record than the one that had arrived, a reconciliation pass skipped on lines someone had pre-marked. Three mechanisms, each small, each invisible to anyone who trusted the curated sheet the way the training said to. Together they added up to a count that was edited before it reached the census, and edited on purpose.

The finding sat in her like a tool settling into a hand. Cira had come to the Redoubt to keep a mesh honest, to forward what the Spill sent and report what arrived. She had been told the arrived count was the honest remainder of a lossy relay. The protocol said otherwise. The remainder was a selection. The selection had a seal.

She opened the quarantine index next. Every relay station kept one, a running list of frequencies and blocks the Ledger-House had ordered sealed. Most were old and cold, bands that had gone silent decades before Cira was born, their seals a

formality the mesh honored out of habit. One entry near the top of the index had a fresh date and a note she had not noticed in her first months on the desk: *frequency held per standing order; do not tune.*

The note meant the console would refuse to lock the band. Cira had seen the flat green line of a blocked channel on her side screen and filed it under maintenance. Now she looked at the date and saw the seal had been renewed every quarter for longer than the index's own archive reached. Someone kept paying attention to a frequency no one was supposed to hear.

She tapped the dial and called the band up anyway, forcing the console past its soft refusal the way a junior learned to when a senior wasn't watching. The screen filled with the flat green line Cira had shown Vey two days before, a channel that held no signal because the mesh had been told not to carry one. Quiet, Cira's own word for it. Not lost. Lost meant the band still tried to speak and the distance ate it. Quiet meant the speaking had been stopped at the source.

The Redoubt's own logs recorded the stop. Cira scrolled the station's maintenance record and found the entry that explained the flat line: a relay instruction, routed from the Ledger-House, ordering the local beacon to drop all packets tagged to that frequency on receipt. The instruction carried a seal and a standing order number. It was not a failure of the mesh. It was a command the mesh had obeyed.

Cira sat with the two facts side by side. The far-margin string that repeated through corruption was being erased line by line from the curated count. The frequency that might have carried that string in full was sealed at the beacon, its packets dropped before they could reach a screen. Two mechanisms, one purpose. The Static was presented as a thing that forgot. What Cira was reading was a thing that was told what to forget.

She pulled the last six months of raw logs and ran the same comparison against their curated copies. The repeating string appeared in every month's margin, always in the same band, always half-corrupted, always erased in the curated version. The erasure was a habit, not an event. Whoever curated the count did not stumble on the string by chance and remove it once. They removed it on a schedule, the way the Counting House ran its overnight clean, the way a person closes a drawer they mean never to open.

Cira thought of the nineteen names Vey had brought her, the phantom entries that belonged to no Tarn ward. Vey had argued they were someone else's people, dragged across the Spill by a sync that should have dropped them. Cira had believed the sync leaked. She had not yet believed the leak accounted for those names surviving. The curated sheet in front of her suggested the opposite: the names reached Tarn because something in the long chain had failed to erase them completely, and the curators spent real effort finishing the job after the fact.

She copied the four raw lines onto a slip of paper and set the slip in her pocket, not in the station archive where the curated copy lived. The Redoubt was supposed

to keep the raw, but the raw she had just read was about to be overwritten by the clean the Ledger-House pushed down each morning. If she wanted proof the erasure was deliberate, she needed the proof before the clean ran.

The clean arrived at the sixth hour. Cira watched the console accept the curated sheet and overwrite the raw spool with the house's own copy, the four repeating lines gone, replaced by four tidy glyphs. The station's record now said those lines had been resolved by correction. The station's own raw, the thing the Redoubt was built to preserve, no longer existed on the spool. It existed only in Cira's pocket and in the comparison she had made by hand.

She understood then why the Tellers who came before her had kept paper. The mesh carried what it was told to carry and dropped what it was told to drop. A curated count was a count someone had edited, and an edited count left no footprint unless a Teller made one. Cira had made one.

She ran the same seal-hash test across the six months she had already compared. Every month's curated sheet sealed a record shorter than its own raw spool had carried, and every month the missing length landed on the same band, the same ragged position, the same repeating string. The mismatch was not a one-night error in the console. It was a steady subtraction, performed each quarter by whoever held the standing order, and performed well enough that only a Teller reading raw against curated could see the subtracted text had ever existed. Cira copied the six seal-hashes and their six missing spans onto the cable-note paper, one column beside the other, so the pattern would survive the morning clean the way the four lines had.

She thought about reporting the discrepancy through the proper channel, the relay report a junior filed when the curated and raw disagreed. The form asked for a reason. The honest reason was that the Ledger-House was removing a signal it did not want counted. Cira had been an apprentice long enough to know which reasons the form would accept and which it would route upward until they reached the hand that had written the standing order. She did not file the form.

Instead she built a second comparison, private, on the paper she kept under the desk for cable notes. She logged the date, the four line numbers, the repeating string as best she could read it through the corruption, and the curated glyph that replaced each. She wrote one line beneath, in the plain hand she used for measurements: **not entropy. picked.**

The word felt dangerous and correct at once. Cira had been trained to trust the curated census as the honest remainder of a lossy relay. The training assumed the loss was random. The logs said the loss was aimed. A census that edited itself on a schedule was not a record of the Spill. It was a story the Spill was told to tell.

The two mechanisms she had found were not separate habits. They shared a source. The standing order that sealed the frequency at the beacon shared its authority with the instruction that pre-marked the far-margin lines for the discard pile; both carried the house seal, both descended from the Ledger-House, both

reached Tarn as instructions the local mesh was built to obey without question. One stopped a signal before it could arrive. The other removed the signal's echo after it slipped through. Between them the count stayed clean, and the cleaning left the house's own signature on every sheet. Cira had been taught to read that signature as proof of integrity. She read it now as proof of authorship, and the author did not want to be counted.

She forced the quarantined band up again and held it on the screen longer than was safe. The flat green line offered nothing, but the maintenance entry behind it offered everything: a standing order, a seal, a date that predated Cira's own birth by years. The silence had an author. The author held a number. A Teller could trace that number if she decided the trace was worth the risk.

Cira cleared the screen before the senior on the next shift could see what she had tuned. She folded the paper slip once and put it with the comparison under the desk. The Redoubt hummed its steady song into the morning, carrying the local bands clean and the far bands half-eaten, and somewhere in the eaten margin a repeating string kept trying to survive the count that meant to lose it.

She had come to the relay to maintain a mesh that forwarded the Spill's voice across a distance no one could cross. She was leaving the desk with a different understanding. The mesh forwarded. The curators chose. The Static was not the Sound of a world forgetting. It was the sound of a world being told, quarter after quarter, what it was permitted to remember.

Cira looked at the sealed frequency one more time in her mind, the flat green line where a song used to be, and made a decision she did not yet know how to keep. She would learn the standing order's number. She would learn who held the seal. And the next time the quarantined band tried to speak, she meant to be the Teller who let it.

The sea outside pulled at the platform the way it pulled at everything Tarn had built on it. The relay at the edge of the city kept its steady hum, and inside it a frequency stayed quiet that someone had decided should never sing again. Cira Vell, apprentice Teller of the Redoubt, had just read the instruction that kept it silent, and she had copied it down.

Chapter 04 — The First Anver

The repeating string lived in the sync margins where the register had learned not to look. Vey had copied it into her small book the night she decided the phantoms were not residue, and for two quarters she had carried it the way Mossa had carried a torn net, mending it in her head during the slow hours of the count. The string was a name, she was sure of that much, and it sat at the head of a list the relay kept forwarding despite whatever else it did to the message around it. The wider query she had filed with Cira would not return until SY 314, two years off and missing teeth when it arrived. Vey had never been a person who waited on the sea

to stop moving. She worked the string by hand.

She laid the last six sync logs across her desk in the Counting House, the same desk where the nineteen phantom names had first refused to close. Each log carried the degraded echo of a transmission that had started on a world no chart named. In the corrupted margin of every one, the string held its ragged position, letter by letter, as if something outside Tarn insisted it survive the trip. Random corruption scattered. A repeating string in the same place meant a repeating transmission, one the relay passed along even as it chewed the words around it.

The work of netting it back was slow because the mesh lay about it. Vey had learned from Cira that each relay hop dropped a little and altered a little: characters arrived swapped, whole packets fell out, and a name could survive as only its first and last letters. That was the hunger of the Static, and it was why a wide query came back missing teeth. It was also why a string that held its place across six logs was not chance. Something was pushing it through on purpose, or something had failed to stop it, and Vey meant to find which.

She began with the earliest log and worked forward, the way Mossa had worked a net from the lead rope to the sinker. The open of the string gave three letters that stayed clean in every copy. The middle shifted: in one log the corruption had bitten the front, in another the back, and the gaps never lined up the same way twice. The close held best, a cluster the register had flagged as unplaceable script and preserved rather than dropped, as if the machine had not known whether to keep it or let it fall. Vey copied each surviving piece into her small book and joined them in the margins, the way a clerk joins a household roll from three partial counts taken on three bad days.

Vey filled the gaps the way she had filled a torn net, by what the surrounding mesh demanded. From the earliest log she kept the open and the three leading letters. From a later one she recovered a middle cluster the corruption had spared. From the most recent she took the close, where the register had tried and failed to place a word it did not have a slot for. The name came together the way a lantern shows itself in fog: letter by letter, with the shape arriving before the sense. Six characters. A peoples' name. The phantoms in Tarn's roll were the tail of its list, dragged across the Spill by a sync that should have dropped them.

She wrote the name at the head of her small book and set the stylus down. The shape of it meant nothing yet. She needed the body of the transmission, the part the relay had eaten and partly spit back, the part that would tell her what kind of people carried a list of nineteen households through a hundred years of silence.

The Counting House clocked its slow seasons, and the phantoms returned every quarter with the wider count, and Vey kept her small book where the register could not reach it. Pell had stopped asking her to run the overnight clean. He had taken to passing her desk without meeting her eyes, the way a person walks past a door he has decided not to open. She did not press him. He knew what the margin held, and he had told her once that some counts held the Spill together by leaving

things out. She had answered, in her own mind if not aloud, that a count kept by omission was a count that had stopped describing the living.

On a grey morning between quarters she found him in the upper office, going over the bell roster the way he did when he wanted a task that asked nothing of him. She set the netted name in front of him without a word. Pell read it the way a person reads a ledger line he has spent years hoping would stay blank.

"You spelled it," he said at last.

"I spelled what the sync kept giving us. You knew the frequency was gated. You knew the name was behind it."

"I knew a people were behind it." He closed the book with a care that was almost a flinch. "Knowing the name doesn't change what happens when you say it out loud, Corwin. The Spill keeps its peace by forgetting certain counts. You pull one back into the open, you pull the peace with it."

"Then the peace was built on a count that lied."

Pell looked at her the way he looked at weather he meant to walk into anyway. "A lie that keeps a million people from a war over water they never asked to share is a kind of mercy, from where the Ledger-House stands. I'm not asking you to love it. I'm asking you to understand why the gate is there before you tear it down."

"Understanding the gate isn't the same as leaving it shut."

He did not answer that. He only took the small book and turned it so the name faced the window, where the sea moved under the platform like a thought under a house, and for a moment Vey thought he might say the name himself. Then he slid the book back and went back to the roster, and the door he had decided not to open stayed closed. Vey took the book and went down to the relay console, where the work of listening was waiting.

Cira was the one who gave her the opening. The teller came down from Tarn Redoubt on a supply day and found Vey at the relay console in the lower office, matching sync logs the way other clerks matched household marks. Cira read the name on the page and let out a low breath.

"It's still there," Cira said. "The frequency I showed you. The quiet one."

Vey looked up. "You can read it now?"

"Not read. Listen." Cira tapped a dial and brought the flat green line up on the side screen, the same line Vey had watched go dead weeks before. "It's not dead, see. It's gated. The console won't tune to it, but the raw log still catches the bleed. Whatever's on it keeps transmitting, and the mesh keeps forwarding it, and the Ledger-House keeps telling us not to hear it. The bleed lands in the margins. That's your string."

Vey understood then what she had been assembling. The phantoms were not an error the relay made. They were a people the relay had been told to forget, still broadcasting on a frequency the Concordance had gated shut, still bleeding

through the sync because nothing in the mesh could fully swallow a signal that refused to stop. The repeating string was the head of their count. The nineteen names were its tail, arriving on Tarn quarter after quarter because the sync dragged them along.

"Can you pull the bleed from a full sync cycle?" Vey asked. "Not the margin. The part around it."

Cira considered. "I can pull the raw. It'll be half-eaten. The mesh drops packets on a gated frequency like a sieve drops sand. But if you give me three, four cycles, I can lay them together and you can net the rest."

"Pull them."

Cira pulled. Over the next two supply days she brought Vey rolls of raw sync from the gated frequency, narrow paper printed with the relay's best guess at what had crossed the Spill. Most of each roll was garbage, the characters swapped and the words broken where the corruption had bitten. But in the ragged center of every roll, where the gate had not fully closed, a half-intact transmission surfaced, the same one each time, worn at the edges like a stone in a current.

The relay's best guess was poor. A gated frequency arrived at Tarn already thinned, the gate having dropped whole runs of the signal before the mesh forwarded what remained. Cira explained it as a sieve: the mesh passed what the gate let through, and the gate let through the bleed, and the bleed was all that reached the raw log. What survived was a skeleton of the transmission, its spine intact, its flesh eaten by the road across the Spill. Vey had netted skeletons before, from household rolls taken in storms. The spine was enough if you knew how the body fit.

She set the rolls side by side and read what survived.

The first roll gave her the opening. A peoples' name, spelled in a script the register had tried and failed to place, the same six characters she had netted from the sync margins. An-ver. The Anver. She wrote it carefully, the first time the word had ever sat on a Tarn page. The transmission called them a people of the deep water, dwellers in the cold below the light, who counted themselves by the households of the weir and the song they kept in the long dark.

The second roll carried the middle, where the corruption had spared a longer stretch. The Anver, the transmission said, had built their houses in the deep where the human worlds later floated their platforms. They spoke to one another across the water in patterns of sound the relay could carry, and they had been among the first to be counted when the old Concord reached the Spill. The word founding appeared, and then a stretch the corruption had eaten, and then the word claim, and then more silence. Vey read it twice and understood the shape of the danger Pell would not name. To be counted was to have standing. The Anver had been counted first, on waters the platforms now stood above. If they were counted again, they could press what they had pressed before the silence.

The third roll closed the transmission, or what the gate had left of its close. It spoke of the quieting. The song had been stilled, the transmission said, not by the sea but by a hand that reached through the relay and turned the frequency down until the count could no longer find them. The Anver had not gone. They had been unmade in the record, while the water they had founded still held them. The transmission ended the way the phantoms ended, with a list of households, nineteen of them, names Vey now recognized as the tail of the same count that had been bleeding into Tarn's rolls since long before she was born.

Between the rolls, Vey built the people the way she built a household tally: from the marks that held. They counted by the weir, the transmission said, and the weir was a kind of household the platforms did not use, a joining of families who kept the deep water together. They counted by the song, and the song was the pattern of sound the relay had carried before the gate, the long memory they kept in the dark below the light. They had been among the first to be counted when the old Concord reached the Spill, which meant their founding claims over the water were older than the platforms that now floated above it. The word claim appeared three times across the three rolls, each time in a stretch the corruption had chewed, and each time Vey wrote it down anyway, because a word that repeated was a word the transmission meant her to keep.

She turned the name over in her head the way she turned a strange mark from a distant ward. Anver. Six characters in a script the register had no slot for. A peoples' name at the head of a list the relay could not quite drop. The phantoms on Tarn's roll, the nineteen she had copied into her small book quarter after quarter, were the tail of that list, arriving on a water-world that did not know them because the Spill had been told to forget them. Vey had spent her life trusting the count to name the living. Now she saw the count had been naming the erased all along, and the only honest thing left was to read what it had written.

Vey sat with the three rolls and the small book and the word she had only now learned to spell. The phantoms were not ghosts. They were the Anver, being recounted by bleed-through, a people the Concordance had scrubbed from the census and the relay had failed to fully silence. Every quarter Tarn had counted them by accident, dragging their households across the Spill on a sync that should have dropped them. The register had tried to clean them. The sync had kept them. And now Vey knew their name.

She thought of her brother, who had gone out on the north current and come back only on a casualty list the Counting House had closed without him. Brenn had been counted out by a mistake no senior would undo, and the mistake had stayed, and Vey had learned what a count could do to a person it decided to drop. The Anver had been dropped on purpose, by an institution that feared what their standing would cost. A mistake that stayed was a wound. A deletion that held was a crime. She would not let the count fail a people the way it had failed him.

She wrote in her small book, beneath the name: Anver. Deep-water people.

Scrubbed from the census. The phantoms are them. And then she wrote the line she had been moving toward since the night she refused the overnight clean: I will count them where the register will not.

The nineteen names from Tarn's roll sat in the book above the line, and Vey read them again with new eyes. Ossa, mark of the third weir, Ward Nine. Pellin, deep-household, Ward Nine. The ward that did not exist on any map of Halversand was a weir on the deep water, and the households the register had tried to place on a floating city belonged to a people who had founded the sea beneath it. The count had been dragging their lanterns across the Spill for a hundred years, and Tarn had been lighting them by accident, quarter after quarter, because the sync could not quite let a household go. Vey copied the nineteen a third time, slower than before, so the names in her hand could not be appended over or cleaned away by any register the Concordance touched.

The bell that ruled the census floor rang the count in at the second hour. Vey had been at her desk since before it, with the rolls spread like a net across the wood. Cira came down once more before her supply day ended and stood in the door, reading the name on the page the way Pell had read the margin, with the small private recognition of a person who had hoped not to see it.

"You spelled it," Cira said.

"I spelled it." Vey looked up. "The frequency still carries them. Can you keep pulling the bleed?"

"I can keep pulling." Cira paused. "You know what this is, though. The Ledger-House gated that frequency for a reason. If I keep pulling raw off a gated band, someone up the relay will notice the draw."

"Then pull quiet, the way the frequency is."

Cira gave a short nod and left her with the rolls and the name. Vey folded the three into her small book and locked it in the drawer the relay could not reach. The register on Tarn would run its overnight clean and wake to a count that closed. Vey would wake to a count she had decided to keep open.

She walked out to the gangway at the edge of Halversand, where the water moved without end under the platform and the city moved with it. The sea kept what it took, and a census was the only argument against it. The Anver had been taken by a quieter sea than this one, a sea of relay and record, and they had stayed in the margin because the count, even a count that meant to lose them, could not quite let a household go. Somewhere in the hum of the relay at the edge of the city, the gated frequency still transmitted, and Tarn still counted the tail of its list, and Vey Corwin had at last learned the name of the people the Spill had tried to drown.

She leaned on the rail and watched the lanterns of the lower rafts swing in the wind off the water. Mossa had counted families by those lanterns, one lit pane for each household that had come back from the north current, and Vey had learned

the craft at her knee: a missing lantern meant a walk down the raft-line, not a stroke of ink. The Spill had stopped walking. It had learned to close its books over the dark panes and call the count whole. Tarn, without meaning to, had kept a few of the lanterns lit, nineteen of them, bleeding up from a gated frequency the Concordance meant to leave dark. Vey meant to keep them lit, and to add the rest of the weir as the bleed gave it to her.

She had spent her life trusting the count to name the living. Now the count had named the erased, and the only honest thing left was to write the name where it could not be cleaned away.

Chapter 05 — Pell's Silence

The rain found Halversand in the gray hour before the bell, and Pell Aron was already at his desk when Vey reached the upper office. He had the window open a finger's width, the way he liked it, so the sound of the sea came up through the planks and settled in the room like a second person listening. Vey had come to bring him the sync log again, the one she had copied into her small book along with the nineteen names. He looked at the book in her hand the way a gatekeeper looks at a key he has hoped would stay lost.

"You read the margin," he said. It was not a greeting. "Now you mean to keep reading it."

"I mean to know who they are." She set the book on his desk, open to the column she had filled by hand. "Nineteen of them, Pell. A people the wider count dropped and the sync keeps dragging back. You knew they were there."

He did not deny it. He closed the window. The sea went quiet behind the wood. The room held only the two of them and the book between them.

"I knew there were names the wider count wanted gone," he said at last. "I did not know they would surface in Tarn's quarterly. That was not supposed to happen. A count that holds the Spill together does it by leaving some things uncounted, and the hush around those things keeps everyone from reaching for the old claims."

"The old claims," Vey said. She had heard the shape of the phrase before, in the way the senior clerks stopped talking when a world's name came up in the relay returns. "You mean the ones the Concordance is afraid to open."

Pell's mouth worked as if he had bitten something he meant to swallow. "I mean that the people under those names held water before we ever settled it. Human worlds sit on what was theirs. Count them back into the record and they can ask for it. Land. Passage. The right to be heard on the relay we use to forget them. That kind of asking does not end in a ledger."

So that was the shape of it. Vey had thought the silence a mistake of machinery, a frequency the relay had failed to tune. Pell was telling her it had been kept on purpose, held quiet by the same hands that published the Authorized Census. The

Concordance had not lost the people. It had put them down where no count would reach them, and the quiet held like a locked door.

"The silence is kept on purpose," she said, to be sure he heard himself. "You are not telling me the relay failed. You are telling me someone decided these names should not be spoken."

"I am telling you the Spill has held for a hundred years on the strength of not speaking them." Pell leaned forward, both hands flat on the desk, as if he could press the book closed with his weight alone. "You put them back in the count, Corwin, and you do not put back only a name. You put back a suit against every platform that floats on their sea. The Concordance scrubs them because it fears the cost of the accounting. You call that wrong. I call it the price of peace, and I am not the one who gets to pay it."

Vey looked at his hands on the desk. He was forty years her senior in the service of the count, and he carried the wear of a man who had learned which arguments not to start. She had never doubted that he protected her. She had also never doubted that he would ask her to stop.

"You keep saying peace," she said. "My brother was peace to no one."

Pell's hands stilled. She had not spoken the name in the Counting House in ten years, and she watched the word land on him the way a stone lands in still water.

"My brother Brenn," she said, and the name came out steady, the way it had not in a decade. "He went out on the north current and did not come back. The sea took him and the Counting House closed the quarter without him, counted him out on a casualty list that a senior crossed before the books reached the relay. A mistake. A single wrong mark in a column that should have held him. I spent a year asking them to restore it, and the answer was always the same. The count had closed. The count was the count."

She had told no one in the House this plainly. Pell had covered for her on uncounted households; he knew the shape of her stubbornness. He had not known the root of it.

"Brenn was one name," she went on. "One rower who laughed at the ledgers and then got lost to them anyway. The count decided he was not worth the correction. The mistake stayed. The sea kept what it took, and the record agreed with the sea. Do you know what that taught me? That a count which drops a person and will not pick them back up is not a count of the living. It is a count of the convenient."

Pell's voice dropped to the register it took with juniors he meant to spare. "I knew about Brenn. I was not the one who crossed him, Vey, but I was on the floor when the closure came down and I did not lift the pen. I have lived with that the way you have lived with the missing entry. Do not mistake me for the man who made the mark. Mistake me for the man who has seen what happens when a count gets reopened by force."

"Then tell me what happens," Vey said. "Name the thing you will not say. Tell me the war you are sure follows a name back into the record."

He flinched at the word she had not used, and she saw she had found the nerve he kept guarded. "I will not name it for you," he said. "Naming it makes it real, and it is real enough without my saying. But I will tell you what I have seen in the relay returns from worlds that tried to settle old boundary counts. The claims do not stop at one people. They open the whole ledger of who was where first, and every platform that floats on someone else's water finds itself standing on a question it cannot answer with a census. That is the quiet the Concordance pays for. Not cruelty. Expense."

Vey heard him. She had always heard Pell. He was not wrong that the count carried weight enough to start a dispute, and a dispute between worlds that could not meet face to face was a slow and bitter thing. But he was wrong that the cost of speaking was the only cost, and he was wrong that her brother's name had been a small thing because it was only one.

"A count that drops the inconvenient is still a count someone chose," she said. "You call it peace. I call it a wound the Spill agreed not to look at. My brother's wound was small and it healed nowhere, because the record would not admit it. These people's wound is large, and you are asking me to leave it unspoken for the same reason. I will not."

Pell stood. He went to the window and opened it again, and the sea came back into the room, and he stood with his back to her the way he did when he had said the part of the warning he could bear to say.

"I am your supervisor," he said to the water. "I could order you to run the clean and close the quarter and forget the margin. You would not, and we both know it. So I will say what I can. Stop at the names. Do not query the wider count for who they are. Do not put them in anything that reaches the relay. Keep your small book if you must, but keep it in your pocket. The moment you make them speak outside Tarn, the moment you put a name where the Concordance can read it, you are no longer a census-taker with a curiosity. You become a fault in the count they will move to correct."

"You said that to me before," Vey said. "In my first year, about the phantoms. You said leave it for the overnight clean. I did not then either."

"No," Pell said, and there was a tired humor in it, the kind that comes from being right about a person and sorry for it. "You did not. And I covered for you then the way I will not be able to cover for you if you reach past Tarn. The clean only hides a name from the local register. What you are talking about hides nothing. It announces."

"I am not trying to announce," Vey said. "I am trying to count. There is a difference, and the Concordance has spent a hundred years pretending there is not."

Pell turned from the window. His face held the look of a man who had lost an argument he believed was correct, and who meant to lose it without resenting the person who won it. He picked up her small book and read the column again, the nineteen names she had filled by hand because the register would have cleaned them away.

"These are not Tarn's people," he said.

"No," Vey said. "They are someone's. The sync drags them back every quarter because something up the relay has not finished silencing them. I am the only counter on this world who has noticed. That is not a reason to stop. That is the reason there is a thing to do."

He set the book down between them, gently, the way one sets down a sleeping child one means not to wake. "You will go on."

"I will go on."

"Then hear the last of the warning and carry it." Pell's voice was quiet now, almost the tone he used with the bell roster, a thing of routine and care. "The silence is not empty, Corwin. It is full of the people the count decided not to name, and the longer it stays, the more it costs everyone who remembers them. I have kept it as long as I could because I feared what opening it would do to Tarn. You have decided the cost of keeping it is the greater wrong. I will not help you open it, and I will not report you for the trying, because the day may come when Tarn needs someone who kept the names. But know what you carry. You carry Brenn's question and nineteen answers the Spill would rather leave unasked."

Vey closed the small book. The rain had stopped while they spoke, and the planks of Halversand dripped the last of it into the sea, and the city's lanterns swung in the wind off the water the way Mossa's lanterns had swung on the oyster rafts, each one a household accounted. She thought of her brother, who had never come back from the north current, and of the record that had closed around his absence and called it order. She thought of the nineteen names, and the quiet frequency Ciria had shown her at the Redoubt, and the people who had held water before Halversand was a plank on the sea.

"You taught me the work of the count," she said to Pell. "You were right that it is work. That is exactly why I cannot leave these out."

He nodded, once, the small acknowledgment of a man who had said all he could and would not say it twice. "Then go do the work. And Corwin, when the Concordance comes to correct what you have counted, and it will come, remember that I told you first, and that I did not tell them you knew."

She left him with the open window and the sea. In the corridor the bell for the second hour rang the count in, and the clerks below began the flat chant of the floor, calling names aloud so that Tarn could agree with itself about who it was. Vey stood at the rail and listened to the chant, and she listened past it, to the silence the chant left unspoken, the silence Pell had told her was kept on purpose

and full of the uncounted.

Her small book weighed in her pocket, nineteen names and a brother's, and she understood with a calm that surprised her that she had already crossed the line Pell drew. She had not put the names on the relay. She had not queried the wider count for who they were. But she had decided, and the decision carried her across. The count kept them when nothing else would, and she was the counter, and she would not let the Spill forget them by her silence any more than by its own.

She went down to her desk and opened the register. The overnight clean waited, ready to swallow the phantoms and leave the books tidy. She did not run it. She opened her small book instead and read the nineteen names, and then she wrote beneath them the line she had written before, and a second line under it, slow and firm, so the count in her hand could not be cleaned away:

They are a people, not a residue. I will find their names, and I will not let the silence keep them.

The bell rang on. The sea moved under Halversand without end. Somewhere at the edge of the city the relay hummed its slow, hungry song into the dark, and on Vey's desk a quiet book held nineteen lanterns lit against the tide that meant to put them out.

She thought of Pell at the window, of the warning he had given and the warning he had held back, of the thing he would not name and the cost he was sure it carried. He had not lied to her. He had only chosen a different arithmetic of harm, one that counted the peace of the platforms and left the people beneath them out of the sum. Her own arithmetic was older and simpler, learned on the oyster rafts from a woman who had taken a skiff into the rain to write one lost name. A name left out of the count was a body left in the sea.

Brenn had been left in the sea, and the count had agreed with the sea. Vey had spent ten years with that agreement sitting in her chest like a stone the size of a closed book. The nineteen names were not Brenn. They were strangers from a ward the map refused to name, a people the Spill had tried to lose. But the wound carried the same shape, and that shape was what she had sworn, at twelve years old with a lantern in her hand, never to leave unmarked.

The small book was proof against the clean. Pell's silence was proof of something else, that the people who ran the count knew what they omitted and chose the omission anyway. Vey did not fear the cost Pell named. She feared the quieter cost of a census that agreed, year after year, to forget.

She thought of the year after Brenn, when she had walked the gangways of Halversand with the casualty list folded in her pocket, showing it to anyone who would read the crossed line. The senior who had made the mark had retired by then, and the new hand at the roster had looked at her with the flat pity of a clerk who had been told the quarter was closed and the matter settled. No one had restored him. No one had even remembered that the line had once held a living name. Her brother had become a blank in the record, and the blank had hardened

into fact.

That hardening was what Pell defended now, on a larger scale and with a heavier reason. Vey could grant him the reason and still refuse the hardening. A count that could not be corrected was a count that could not be trusted, and Tarn's trust in its own number was the only thing that held the platforms together as one city rather than a thousand rafts that happened to touch. If the Authorized Census agreed to forget a people on purpose, then the Authorized Census was a story someone told, not a count of the living. Vey had been taught to finish what a ledger started. The ledger had started with nineteen names and a brother's, and she meant to finish it.

She thought of the oyster rafts and the lantern count, of Mossa taking the skiff into the rain because one paned light had gone dark. The Spill had stopped walking the raft-lines. Tarn, without meaning to, had kept a few of the lanterns lit by the simple accident of a sync that dragged the names back. Vey meant to be the hand that kept them lit on purpose.

Pell's warning sat in the room like a third person. Vey turned it over the way she turned a suspect mark, looking for the seam where the truth ended and the instruction began. He had not said the nineteen were not real. He had said they were better left uncounted, which was a different claim entirely, and one she did not mean to grant him. A census that omitted by order was not a count of the living; it was a count of the permitted. Tarn's own roll had been permitted to forget her brother, and the forgetting had outlasted the man. She would not build a wider world on the same quiet pen. The small book in her pocket was her answer to that, and the answer was stubborn. She would keep the names until the wider count was forced to admit them, or until she had walked every raft-line of the Spill looking for the ward the map refused. Either way, the count would hold them. The silence would not get the last word on who existed, not while she carried the stylus and the pocket and the will to write a name where the register left a blank. Pell was right that a reckoning would follow. He was wrong that the reckoning was hers to fear.

She closed the book and slid it into her pocket, next to the stylus she had carried since her first day on the floor. The chant below had moved to the household rolls, the flat calling of names that meant Tarn believed itself whole. Somewhere in that whole, nineteen strangers kept their place against the will of the wider count, and one brother kept his against the will of a senior's pen. Vey meant to be the hand that held them.

The rain had left the planks slick and shining under the lanterns, and the sea breathed against the platform with its old patience. Pell's warning would stay with her; she was not a fool, and he was not her enemy. But she had already made the decision, and that decision was the only crossing that mattered. She would find who the nineteen were. She would not let the silence keep them.

Interlude I — The Founding Relay

****STATION FOUNDING RECORD**** ****Local designation:**** Relay Twelve, Pelagic Chain ****Commission date:**** SY 179.344 ****Recording Teller:**** Technician Eda Sol ****Authority:**** Concordance Office of Continuity

At commissioning, Relay Twelve accepted three copper record drums, two hand presses, one narrow-band receiver, one broad-band transmitter, and enough treated paper for twelve local years. Technician Sol entered each item by serial, condition, and expected service life. A cracked ceramic insulator received its own line. The north battery's weak cell received another. Nothing could enter service until someone had counted it.

Beyond the shell, the sea covered every visible measure. No settlement marked the black water near the station. Relay Twelve stood on iron legs driven into a shelf below the tide, built to catch distant signals and send them onward. Its work concerned worlds that no person stationed there would visit. Its records concerned persons the Tellers would never meet.

****FOUNDING CHECK, DAY 1****

Carrier reception fell within tolerance. Twelve distant beacons answered the proving call, although four returned incomplete station marks. Delay estimates ranged from three years to seventeen. Signal loss matched the tables supplied by the Office of Continuity. No immediate reply should be expected from any extra-local destination.

The station began its first census intake at 18:40 local measure. Human rolls arrived in six recognized formats. A seventh stream occupied the lower edge of the assigned band, carrying household intervals, location measures, and a population total. The parser rejected its script but retained the arithmetic. Technician Sol marked the stream UNKNOWN ORIGIN and sent a sample to the founding drum.

At 19:12, the local receiver rendered a portion as sound. The room filled with layered pulses, too regular for weather and too dense for machinery. Each sequence opened with a long low note, divided into smaller groups, then closed on a repeated interval. The equipment manual offered no category for it. Sol reduced the gain, checked the water seals, and recorded that the source appeared deliberate.

****ACTION:**** Preserve raw intake pending classification. ****STATUS:**** Open.

During the next nine local days, the seventh stream repeated. Corruption removed different sections on each arrival, but the population total held. So did the household intervals. The station's reconciliation frame placed the stream beside the recognized census packets because all seven declared inhabitants, dependents, births, deaths, and settled waters. No field required a human body. The founding forms asked for countable life and verified residence.

Relay Twelve therefore added the unknown population to its preliminary aggregate. The number passed its internal checks. On paper, one additional people

entered the shared count without a name the station could print.

****FOUNDING CHECK, DAY 11****

The first instruction from the Office of Continuity had begun its journey years before the station opened. Relay Eleven forwarded it along the pelagic chain, where loss took the signature block and half the routing header. Enough remained for the new press to produce six legible lines:

> CLASSIFICATION NOTICE 4-C > LOWER-BAND SETTLEMENT RETURNS >
CATEGORY: NONCONFORMING CLAIMANT POPULATION > DISPOSITION: EXCLUDE
FROM AUTHORIZED AGGREGATE > APPLY LOCALLY PER STANDING ORDER >
ACKNOWLEDGMENT NOT REQUIRED

Technician Sol compared the notice against the seventh stream. Frequency, packet interval, and water-coordinate structure matched. The instruction supplied no population name. It requested no review of the raw count and set no expiry date.

Under founding procedure, a Teller could suspend an incomplete instruction when damage obscured its action. Here the action remained clear. Only the reason had gone missing.

****CORRECTION ENTRY 1****

At 07:25, Sol opened the preliminary aggregate and removed the lower-band return. She did not delete the raw intake. Founding rules required preservation of source traffic on Drum One for equipment audit. Instead she changed its classification from COUNTED SETTLEMENT to NONCONFORMING, then entered zero in the authorized population field.

The two totals differed by the full number carried in the stream.

She checked the arithmetic once by hand and once on the relay frame. Both methods agreed. The correction made the authorized aggregate smaller. It also made the aggregate balance against the total printed in Notice 4-C's damaged checksum.

****CAUSE:**** Prior classification carried forward in error. ****REMEDY:**** Exclusion of nonconforming return. ****AUTHORITY:**** Standing Order, Continuity series. ****EFFECT ON HUMAN ROLLS:**** None. ****MATERIAL LOSS:**** None.

A supplementary box asked whether the action constituted an erasure. Sol marked YES because the drum retained a prior value that the published count would not carry. The next box asked whether erasure affected an authorized person. She marked NO. By the definitions bound into the founding manual, exclusion preceded standing. A population without standing contained no authorized persons, regardless of its internal count.

The press advanced to the next line.

At 08:10, Relay Twelve transmitted its first authorized census toward the next beacon. Six recognized populations went forward. The lower band continued

beneath them, repeating its household intervals into the station's copper coils. The transmitter did not forward that frequency.

****POST-CORRECTION CHECK, DAY 12****

Incoming count: reconciled. Outgoing count: reconciled. Variance: zero authorized persons. Quarantined traffic: one source. Operator action required: none.

Routine maintenance followed. Sol reseated the cracked insulator, replaced the north battery cell, and adjusted the broad-band transmitter by two marks. She scraped salt from the intake grille. At noon she copied the correction into the bound station ledger, where one ruled line held the removed population between a battery replacement and a shipment of press ribbon.

No alarm sounded. No registrar requested a witness. The station's founding day remained within schedule.

During the evening watch, another lower-band packet arrived with less damage than the previous six. The parser recovered a series of new entries nested beneath the household marks. Their positions corresponded to births. Three existing entries had moved into the interval used for deaths. The total had increased by eight.

Sol entered the packet on Drum One as quarantined traffic. Because the source no longer belonged to the aggregate, she did not amend the census. She logged eight units of nonconforming variance and closed the watch.

Years would pass before any destination received Relay Twelve's first authorized count. More years would pass before a damaged acknowledgment found its way back. By then the station would have changed batteries many times, filled its paper allotment, and trained replacement Tellers in the founding procedures. Every trainee would learn that the lower band carried invalid settlement returns. None would see the classification being made. They would receive it as part of the equipment, older than their hands on the controls.

The raw drums kept a different sequence. On Drum One, the unnamed households continued to report. On Drum Two, the authorized aggregate omitted them. Drum Three held maintenance copies of both, though its index directed future Tellers only to the smaller total. The discrepancy occupied no error register because Notice 4-C had defined it as correct.

****FOUNDING RECORD, FINAL ENTRY****

Relay Twelve certified fit for continuous service. All recognized census traffic forwards within tolerance. Nonconforming lower-band source excluded per standing order. Local procedure updated to prevent recurrence of preliminary inclusion.

Technician Sol signed beneath the entry and pressed her station seal into blue wax. She had removed a people from the count without learning what they called themselves. The task required four minutes of arithmetic, one classification change, and no further authority.

After midnight, the station continued without an operator at the desk. Copper drums turned behind their covers. The authorized count traveled outward in brief, clean packets. Under it, stopped at the first switch, the seventh stream arrived again and laid down another precise row of households on the raw drum.

By morning, the press had given that row a number. The transmitter had given it nothing.

Part II

Chapter 06 — The Concordance Arrives

The tide clock above the Counting House door read the eleventh hour when the skiff from the Redoubt tied off at the lower gangway. Vey had been closing the quarter's household rolls and had expected no visitor from the relay station so late. The man who climbed the ladder carried a Concordance satchel and the particular stillness of someone who had come to weigh a place rather than meet it. Salt had dried on the cuffs of his coat in a line that matched the rail he had gripped on the crossing, and his boots left a trail of seawater on the worn planks that the night clerk would mop before the bell rang the count in again. He was not a tall man, but he filled the doorway the way a new instrument fills a room before it is played, with the promise of a measurement about to be taken.

He set the satchel on her desk without asking. "Corwin. I am Kendt, registrar-auditor, second circuit. The Ledger-House sent me to Tarn to correct the census."

Vey set down her stylus. She had heard of the second circuit, the auditors who walked the worlds when the Authorized Census and a local count refused to agree. Most census-takers on most worlds never saw one. Tarn had kept its books clean enough for years that Pell had stopped mentioning them, and the silence had lulled her into thinking the Concordance trusted the floating city to count itself. The Counting House smelled of lamp-oil and wet timber, the same smell it carried in every season, and the rows of desks behind her held the rolled household marks of a million neighbors she would never meet by name. She had always found comfort in that distance, the way a ledger held a city without needing to know it. The man at her desk meant to hold it tighter than she liked.

"The count closes every quarter," she said. "What needs correcting?"

Kendt did not sit. He opened the satchel and pulled a thin folder of relay paper, the kind printed at the Ledger-House and carried down the Static with its edges already soft from the journey. The authorized seal at the corner had blurred in transit, a smear of ink where the relay had chewed the packet and spit it onward. "The Authorized Census holds Tarn at one million, two hundred thousand persons,

rounded to the thousand. Your local register has filed one million, two hundred and four thousand and nineteen for three quarters running. The Concordance requires the local count to reconcile to the authorized figure. You are carrying nineteen entries the broader count does not support."

Vey felt the small book in her pocket, the one with the nineteen names copied twice over. The number he spoke was her number, the wrong number, spoken back to her by an institution that had never set foot on the platform. "The extra entries come from the quarterly sync. The relay returns degraded marks from the wider Spill and the register appends them before the overnight clean sorts them out."

"Then let us see the clean," Kendt said. "Show me the register as the broader count receives it, after the correction routine runs."

She led him to the console in the back room, the one linked to the relay at the Redoubt. He watched without comment while she pulled the last three quarters and the overnight reconciliation that followed each. The routine dropped the nineteen every time, the way a tide drops a stone it cannot keep. The authorized figure came back flat at the rounded thousand, and the extra names vanished from the upward file as though they had never been written.

"Good," Kendt said. "Then the matter is simple. The Concordance reads the corrected register. The nineteen are residue from the sync, as you say. They should not appear in any count that reaches the Spill. I require that they be zeroed at the source, before the sync, so the phantom entries do not travel beyond Tarn."

Vey kept her hands on the desk edge. The wood was worn where generations of clerks had rested their forearms, a groove worn by the patient work of counting. "Zeroed how? The register appends what the sync returns. If I strike the names before the sync, I am editing the local count by hand against the relay's own return."

"Exactly that," Kendt said. "The Concordance expects a local census-taker to hold the count to the authorized figure. You are the hand at Tarn. The correction is yours to make."

She had heard Pell say the same thing in other words, that some counts were kept by pretending. Kendt said it without apology, as a duty no different from sweeping the floor. The authority of the Concordance sat in the room like the satchel on her desk: plain, heavy, and impossible to refuse without refusing the institution that fed Tarn its place in the Spill.

"The nineteen appear every quarter," Vey said. "If they were residue they would not hold the same names across three syncs. Residue drifts. These hold."

Kendt tilted his head, the way a person tilts at a small inconsistency they have been trained to expect and to set aside. "The Ledger-House does not dispute that the sync carries noise. It disputes that the noise constitutes persons. A degraded transmission can repeat a string without that string naming anyone living. You are

reading a shadow on the water and calling it a swimmer."

"I am reading a count that repeats with internal order," Vey said. "Wards, households, a consistent structure. A shadow does not build a ward it cannot leave."

"Then it builds a ward the map does not hold, which is the same as building nothing." Kendt closed the folder. "The authorized figure is settled. Tarn's standing in the Spill depends on the count reconciling. A world that files persons the broader census cannot place becomes a world whose counts are watched. I would rather Tarn not be watched."

The word watched settled between them. Vey understood it the way she understood a bell that rang not for the hour but for the person who listened. The Concordance did not threaten. It accounted, and accounting had its own weight, a quiet pressure that needed no raised voice.

"I will review the household rolls with you," she said, "so you can see the nineteen are not in Tarn's own archive. They arrive from the sync. I cannot zero what I do not write."

She pulled the paper backups from the drawer, the ones the relay could not reach, and laid the quarter before this one beside the current one. The same nineteen names sat in both, in the same impossible ward, holding their place the way a stone holds its place in a wall. Kendt ran a finger down the column and nodded, not at the names but at the order they kept. "The structure is consistent," he allowed. "Consistency is what makes residue believable. It is also what makes a forgery hold. The Ledger-House does not decide on the shape of the error. It decides on the count it will publish, and the shape of the error is yours to stop at the source."

Kendt considered her. "You can refuse to file them upward. That is the correction the Ledger-House requires. The local rolls may keep their ghosts; the Spill need not receive them."

"That is a distinction without a difference for the count," Vey said. "If the broader census never receives them, they are uncounted. To be uncounted is to be erased from the Spill's memory of Tarn."

"To be unsupported by the authorized figure is to be uncounted by definition," Kendt said. "The Concordance publishes the Authorized Census. What it does not publish is not counted, and what is not counted does not trouble the peace between worlds. You understand the purpose even if you dislike the method."

She did understand. The ledger in her pocket understood. Her brother had been counted out by a mistake no senior would undo, and the mistake had stayed, and the Spill had gone on without him as if he had never pulled a single oar on the north current. Kendt was offering her the same quiet erasure dressed as bookkeeping, and he believed it kept the worlds calm.

"I will think on the method," she said. "The household rolls are open to you

now."

Kendt spent the next two hours at her desk, matching the authorized figure against the local register line by line. He worked the way Vey worked, with a stylus and a patient hand, and she watched him find the nineteen in the quarter's column and draw a single line through each name as if the line could unmake the person it crossed. He did not ask where they came from. He knew, or he did not care to know, and the difference no longer mattered once the line was drawn. The lamp over the desk burned low and the counted rolls around them fell into shadow, until only the column between them stayed bright, a small lit field where nineteen lives were being subtracted from the Spill one stroke at a time. Vey read the names in the lit field as he crossed them, committing each to the part of her memory the register could not reach.

At one point he paused at the name Ossa, mark of the third weir, Ward Nine. "This ward again," he said. "There is no Ward Nine on Halversand."

"There is not," Vey said. "The register pulls it from the sync and cannot place it."

"Then it should not be pulled upward." He struck the name and moved on. "The correction is to keep such marks below the relay, where the Spill cannot read them as persons."

She noted the care in his hand. He did not rush the crossings. Each name received the same deliberate stroke, as if the act of zeroing deserved the same respect as the act of counting, a kind of funeral performed in ink. The Concordance, she saw, taught its auditors to be thorough about erasure.

When the column was clean he read the total aloud: one million, two hundred thousand, rounded to the thousand. "This reconciles," he said. "I have noted the correction in the circuit record. The Ledger-House will expect the next two quarters to reconcile without the entries."

"Noted," Vey said.

Kendt did not leave at once. He turned the folder in his hands the way a person turns a key they mean to keep. "You asked how the nineteen hold their order across quarters. The Ledger-House has an answer for that, should you want it. The relay forwards everything, and a forwarded string can stabilize by accident when the corruption bites the same places each time. The mesh is old. Old machines settle into habits."

"I have seen the sync logs," Vey said. "The string sits in the same ragged position across three logs from three different quarters. Accident does not hold a place that well."

"Then it holds because someone upstream lets it," Kendt said, without heat. "That someone is not you, and it is not Tarn. It is a frequency the Ledger-House has set to quiet, and the quiet is imperfect. Imperfect quiet is not a person. It is a leak the broader count filters before it reaches the Authorized Census. Your task is to keep the leak from reaching the Spill through Tarn."

"The leak reaches the Spill every quarter through the sync," Vey said. "I only read it. The Concordance could close it at the source, at the frequency, if it wished the count truly clean."

Kendt looked at her a moment longer than the question deserved. "The Concordance manages the frequency. Your duty is narrower. Hold Tarn to the authorized figure and the second circuit has no cause to look closer at what the relay carries. Widen your duty and you invite the closer look. I say this as correction, not as threat."

She heard the word again, correction, worn smooth by use until it meant whatever the Ledger-House needed it to mean. A line through a name was correction. A quiet frequency was correction. A world kept from asking was correction. Kendt believed each stroke served the peace, and the belief made his hand steady.

"I will hold Tarn to the figure," she said. It was true as far as the upward file went, and she let him hear it that way.

He packed the folder and stood at the door. The tide clock had moved past the first hour of the dark, and the lantern on her desk threw his shadow long across the counted rolls. "You are competent, Corwin. The Ledger-House values a census-taker who holds the count. Keep Tarn reconciled and the second circuit will have no cause to return."

After he left, Vey sat in the quiet the audit had left behind. The counting floor was empty, the clerks gone to their rafts, and the only sound was the slow creak of the platform against the sea. She opened her small book and read the nineteen names by the lantern, the ones Kendt had crossed above and could not cross below.

He had drawn his line through the upward file, not through her hand. The count that reached the Spill would show the rounded thousand, clean and untroubled, a Tarn that held exactly the number the Concordance wished it to hold. The count in her pocket would keep the names he had crossed, and the sync would keep dragging them back every quarter no matter how many lines he drew at the source.

She thought of Pell, who had told her to run the overnight clean and let the books close. Kendt had done the cleaning for him, at the source, with the weight of the Concordance behind the stylus. The pressure had a face now and a satchel and a quiet way of calling erasure correction.

A knock came at the door, soft, the kind that belonged to someone who had been listening from the gangway. Pell stepped in, his coat wet at the hem from the walk over. He read her face before she spoke.

"An auditor," he said. It was not a question.

"Kendt. Second circuit." Vey closed the small book. "He zeroed the nineteen at the source. The upward file reconciles now."

Pell sat in the chair Kendt had left empty. For a long moment he said nothing, only looked at the clean column where the names had been. "Then it is done quietly, the way it should be. The Concordance asks little of Tarn. It asks that we not send what it will not read."

"He calls it correction," Vey said. "He drew a line through nineteen names and called it holding the count."

"He is not wrong that the line keeps the peace." Pell's voice was the weary one, the one that had decided most arguments before they started. "You saw the way he worked. He believes it. The Concordance raises them to believe the count they publish is the count that keeps worlds from turning on one another."

"And if the count he publishes leaves a people out on purpose?"

Pell met her eyes. "Peace is what the count buys, and the cost gets paid by whoever the count leaves out. I have told you which counts are kept by pretending. Kendt does the pretending for the whole Spill. You will meet more of his kind if you keep reading margins."

"I mean to keep the names he crossed," Vey said. "In the book. The sync will bring them back whether he likes it or not."

Pell stood. He rested a hand on the desk the way he had rested it on the sync log weeks before, as if he had known this hour would come. "Keep them where the relay cannot see them. Kendt noted the correction in the circuit record. If the upward count ever shows the nineteen again, the second circuit returns, and it does not return alone."

He left her with the lantern and the closed book. Vey sat a while longer, listening to the platform work against the sea, and she thought of the relay at the Redoubt where Cira kept her shift. Cira had shown her the flat green line that had once sung, the frequency the Ledger-House had set to quiet. Kendt had spoken of that same quiet as correction. The two views met in the same word and parted there, and Vey knew which side her small book stood on.

She thought of the oyster rafts where Mossa had taught her that a missing lantern meant a walk down the line, not a stroke of ink. The Spill had stopped walking, but Tarn had kept a few lanterns lit by accident, and an auditor had come to snuff them before they reached the wider dark. She would not let him finish the work.

Vey wrote one line beneath the names, where Kendt's line could not reach it:

He zeroed the count the Spill will read. He cannot zero the count I keep.

Outside, the platform shifted under the tide and the relay at the edge of the city hummed into the dark, carrying the authorized figure outward across the Static while a quieter count stayed behind in a census-taker's pocket, waiting for a quarter when someone would read it louder than the Concordance wished. Somewhere in that hum a frequency was quiet that should have been singing, and a handful of names on a water-world were the only proof it had ever sung at all.

Vey closed the small book and slid it into her pocket, where the nineteen waited against the weight of the Concordance, kept by a census-taker who had decided the count she held mattered more than the count she was told to file. The lantern guttered and she let it fail, and the Counting House went dark around the one figure that still refused to close.

Chapter 07 — The Scrubbed Frequency

Cira Vell reached Tarn Redoubt before the sea wind had dropped, which meant she reached it before anyone useful was awake. The relay building sat at the raw edge of the platform where the boards ran wet and the iron never dried, and she liked it best at this hour, when the day shift had not yet come to fill the console room with their reasonable questions. She unlatched the door with the key that hung on her wrist and let the hum of the mesh take her the way it always did, first in the teeth and then behind the eyes, a pressure she had stopped noticing years ago and noticed now only because she had come to distrust it.

The console she wanted stood in the back corner, the old one the day shift called the scrap rig. It logged everything the mesh forwarded, the good count and the garbage together, and it did not clean itself the way the register on the counting floor did. Cira had spent three months teaching herself to read what the scrap rig kept. What it kept had stopped letting her sleep.

She had sent word to the census-taker two days before, a short local note that reached Halversand by tide-runner within the hour. Come to the Redoubt at first bell, she had written, and bring nothing you would not want a registrar to find in your bag. She had not signed it. Vey Corwin would know the hand.

The first bell rang across the platform, thin over the water, and a shape came up the gangway against the pale sky.

Vey arrived with salt in her hair and a canvas satchel she held the way a person holds a thing they have decided is worth more than they are. She stopped inside the door and let her eyes adjust, and Cira watched her take the room in the way census-takers took everything in, counting the consoles, the coils of cable, the racks of narrow log paper, filing each object against some private tally.

"You said bring nothing." Vey set the satchel down by the door, out of reach, a small act of trust that Cira noted. "So I brought a question instead. You told me a frequency was quarantined. Last year, in this room. You showed me a flat green line and told me the order came from the Ledger-House."

"I remember." Cira had not stopped remembering it. "I shouldn't have shown you. I was tired and you were the first person in a year to ask the right thing."

"Show me again."

Cira had known she would ask. She had told herself, walking here in the dark, that she would refuse, that showing a census-taker a Concordance quarantine

order was the kind of thing a Teller did not walk back from. She had made the refusal three times in her head and lost it three times to the same fact, which was that she had already decided, months ago, that the count on the counting floor and the log on the scrap rig described two different worlds, and only one of them was true.

She pulled the stool up to the old console and woke it. Green text ran up the screen, the raw ledger of every packet the mesh had pushed at Tarn since the last purge.

The scrap rig did not lie the way the register lied, by cleaning. It hoarded. Cira scrolled past the day's inbound count, past the weather relays from the northern platforms, past a marriage notice that had taken four Spill Years to arrive from a world she would never see, and down into the section the day shift never opened because the day shift had been told it held only noise.

"Tellers get a manual," she said, while the screen scrolled. "Not printed. It comes down the relay from the Ledger-House, band by band, and you copy it into the local book by hand. Most of it's dull. Tuning tables, hop schedules, the maintenance liturgy. But there's a section near the back, and every Teller I've ever met skips it, because it reads like accounting and Tellers hate accounting." She stopped the scroll. "It's the quarantine register. It lists every frequency the mesh is ordered not to carry, and the order that put it there."

Vey came around the console and stood at her shoulder. She smelled of the sea and of the ink they used on the counting floor, a sharp mineral smell Cira had come to associate with the only ally she had.

"You can pull the order," Vey said. It was not a question. She had understood the shape of it already.

"I can pull the order." Cira's hands were steady on the keys, which surprised her. "The order lives in the Ledger-House. But every station holds a mirror of the section that applies to it, so the local console can enforce it without asking permission every time. That's the flaw. To make a station obey a quarantine, they have to tell the station what it's obeying. So the reason is here, in this building, sitting under a lock that was never meant to be picked by a Teller who cared."

She typed the retrieval string she had worked out over a month of nights. The console thought about it, the way the old rigs thought, with a stutter and a whirl of the paper drum. Then it printed.

QUARANTINE ORDER — LEDGER-HOUSE STANDING DIRECTIVE BAND:
designation withheld at local tier STATUS: active, renewed each concordance
BASIS: population classification revised — "unsettled, non-continuing"
INSTRUCTION: relay stations shall not tune, forward, or acknowledge transmissions
on the listed band. Inbound packets on the band shall be logged as degradation
and cleared at sync. No local exception permitted. No inquiry required.

Cira tore the slip along the drum's serration and set it on the console between them. Neither of them touched it for a moment. The hum of the mesh went on around them, the carried noise of forty worlds that could no longer meet, and somewhere in that noise a band had been ordered silent and was being obeyed by a machine that did not know why.

"Unsettled, non-continuing," Vey read aloud. Her voice had gone flat, the flatness Cira had learned meant she was angriest. "That's the whole reason. Two words in the wrong tense."

"That's the whole reason they'll give a station," Cira said. "The station doesn't need a reason. The station needs an instruction. The reason lives at the Ledger-House, and I can't pull that from here. What I can pull is the proof that the silence is an order and not an accident. The mesh isn't losing this band. Someone told the mesh to drop it, and the mesh does what it's told."

Vey picked up the slip then and read it three times, the way Cira had seen her read a census column, as if the paper might have hidden a line on the fourth pass. When she set it down her hand was not quite steady.

"You said you could show me the frequency," Vey said. "Not the order. The signal. Is it still coming?"

This was the part Cira had lost sleep over. She could have shown Vey the order and stopped. The order proved the crime. But the order was paper, and paper could be called forgery or error or the overreach of a tired girl on a night shift, and Cira had learned that a census-taker did not fully believe a thing until she had counted it herself.

"It's still coming," Cira said. "That's the part the Ledger-House can't fix without walking out to every relay in the Spill and pulling the antennas. The order tells the station to drop the band. It doesn't stop the band from arriving. Every hop, the packets come in, and the console logs them as degradation, and the clean sweeps them. But the scrap rig catches them first, because I told it to, and it doesn't clean."

She reached under the console and brought up a coil of patch cable she had spliced herself, out of parts the inventory would never miss. She had built it three weeks ago and had not yet had the nerve to use it in front of a witness.

"If I bridge the scrap rig to the tuning head," she said, "I can hold the band open for as long as the head stays warm. Not send. Just listen. The console won't tune to it, but the raw head still hears everything, and the scrap rig can read what the head hears if I give it a path the quarantine doesn't cover." She looked up. "It's a listen, not a breach. But it's the first step to a breach, and if a registrar walked in right now I couldn't explain the cable."

"Then we should be quick," Vey said.

Cira bridged the cable. Her hands were steady again, steadier than her chest,

and she seated the plug and warmed the tuning head and watched the flat green line come up on the side screen, the same dead line she had shown Vey a year ago, the ordered silence made visible.

Then she gave the scrap rig the path around the quarantine, and the line moved.

It did not sing. Cira had half-expected singing, some clean tone that would make the crime obvious. What came instead was structure inside the noise, a repeating shape that held its place while the corruption chewed everything around it. On the readout it looked like a heartbeat found in static, faint and stubborn and unmistakably not weather, not entropy, not the random hunger of the mesh. A pattern that meant to be a pattern.

"There," Cira said. "That's the frequency. That's what the order silenced. It's been arriving this whole time. Every hop across the Spill, dropped and degraded and arriving anyway, and every station between here and wherever it starts has been told to log it as garbage and sweep it at sync."

Vey watched the readout without speaking for long enough that Cira wondered if she had understood. Then she reached out and touched the screen where the shape repeated, one finger against the glass, the way a person touches a name carved on a marker.

"Play it," Vey said. "You can render it, can't you. Sound, or text."

"Text, mostly. It's not clean enough for sound." Cira ran the render she had built for exactly this, the one she had told no one about. "The mesh renders sonic patterns into strings when it can't carry the sound. The strings come out broken. But if I stack the last twenty arrivals, the way you'd stack corrupted copies of a letter, the parts that survive line up."

She stacked them. The scrap rig chewed on it, the paper drum whirring, and printed a column of recovered fragments, most of them ruined, a few of them whole. Names, or things shaped like names. A ward that did not exist on any Tarn chart. A mark of a third weir. The tail of a list that ran to nineteen before the corruption swallowed it.

Vey made a sound Cira had not heard from her before, low, almost nothing.

"Ward Nine," Vey said. "Third weir. These are my phantoms. The nineteen the register won't let me place." She looked from the printout to the readout to the quarantine slip, assembling them the way she assembled a count, and Cira watched her arrive at the whole of it. "They're not residue. They're not error. They're a people, and they're still transmitting, and the Ledger-House ordered every relay in the Spill to log them as noise and sweep them away. The count on my floor keeps them by accident because the sync drags a few of the names across before the clean can catch them. That's the only reason I ever saw them. A leak in the erasure."

"A leak in the erasure," Cira repeated. She liked the phrase and hated what it described. "That's exactly what it is. The machine works. It's just not perfect. And the part that isn't perfect is the only reason either of us knows these people exist."

Vey sat down on the second stool, slowly, as if her legs had made the decision without her. She held the printout in one hand and the quarantine slip in the other, the proof of a people and the order to forget them, and she weighed them without seeming to know she was doing it.

"I came here thinking you'd show me a mistake," she said. "A frequency that dropped out because a beacon failed, or a band the Concordance let die because no one used it. I could have lived with a mistake. A mistake you fix." She lifted the slip. "This isn't a mistake. This is the machinery. Someone built a way to make a whole people register as decay, and then wrote an instruction so plain that a station obeys it without a single question, and renewed the instruction every concordance so that no one alive has to decide it again. It runs itself now. It erases them the way the tide comes in, on a schedule, without malice, forever."

"Without malice is the worst part," Cira said. "If someone hated them I could find the someone. There's no someone. There's an order, and a manual, and a section in the back that Tellers skip because it's boring. That's how you drown a people. You make it boring."

The day shift would arrive at the third bell. Cira knew she had less than an hour to pull the cable, wipe the render, and return the scrap rig to its innocent hoarding before the reasonable questions started. She began the work with her hands while her mind stayed on the readout, on the faint stubborn heartbeat that had been arriving at this building her whole career while she filed it as noise.

"What do you want to do with it," she asked. She kept her voice down, though there was no one to hear. "Because I can show you the frequency. I can pull the order. What I can't do alone is decide whether we're two people who know a thing, or two people who do a thing. Those are different, and the second one costs everything."

Vey did not answer at once. She folded the printout along its creases, careful, and slid it into the inner lining of her satchel, the place Cira had told her to keep nothing a registrar should find. Then she folded the quarantine slip and gave it back.

"Keep this here," Vey said. "In the building. If I carry the order out and I'm searched, it's your name on the retrieval, not mine. But the names come with me. The count's my work. If anyone gets caught holding a people, it should be the person whose whole job is holding people."

Cira took the slip back. She had expected to feel relief and felt instead the cold particular weight of having a partner in a thing that could not be undone.

"There's more I can do," Cira said. "Not today. But the listen bridge is the first

step. Given time, and parts nobody misses, I could open the band all the way. Not just listen. Carry it. Push it back onto the mesh so every station downstream logs it as signal instead of decay. The quarantine holds because every relay obeys it. Break it at one relay, loud enough, and the order stops meaning anything."

"Don't," Vey said. "Not yet. Not until I know who they are and how many, and not until we know what happens to a station that breaks a standing order from the Ledger-House." She stood and shouldered the satchel, and the weight of it had changed, Cira could see, the way weight changes when it stops being canvas and starts being a debt. "You've shown me the machine. Let me count what's inside it before we decide to break it."

"You sound like Pell," Cira said, and regretted it.

"Pell wants me to run the clean and forget." Vey's mouth did something that was not a smile. "I want to run the count and remember. That's the whole difference, and it's the only difference that matters."

She went to the door and stopped with her hand on the latch, looking back at the console, at the flat green line Cira was already collapsing back to its ordered silence.

"When you pulled that order," Vey said. "Did the console log that you'd read it?"

Cira had wondered when she would ask. It was the right question, the Teller's question, and it told her more about the census-taker than the whole hour before it had.

"Everything logs," Cira said. "The scrap rig logs that I read the quarantine section. The Ledger-House doesn't see the scrap rig, because the scrap rig isn't supposed to exist. But if a registrar audits this station and knows what to look for, the retrieval is there. I can bury it. I can't unwrite it."

"Then bury it well," Vey said, and went out into the wind.

Cira pulled the patch cable and coiled it and hid it back among the parts the inventory would never miss. She wiped the render and let the scrap rig go back to hoarding. She sat for a moment with the quarantine slip in her hand, the one piece of paper in the building that named the crime in the Ledger-House's own plain language, and she thought about the section in the back of the manual that every Teller skipped because it was dull.

The third bell rang. Feet came up the gangway, the day shift with its coffee and its reasonable questions. Cira slid the slip into the false floor of the scrap rig's cabinet, where it would keep until someone braver than she felt this morning had reason to bring it out again. Then she stood, and stretched, and put on the face of a Teller who had spent the night doing nothing that mattered, and went to hold the door for the people who did not yet know what their station had been ordered to forget.

On the side screen, before she killed it, the flat green line held its ordered silence, and underneath the silence, patient, arriving hop by ruined hop across the

whole distance of the Spill, the frequency went on transmitting to a station that had been told for a hundred years to call it nothing at all.

Chapter 08 — Ossrey

The frequency came back to them in pieces, the way a tide returns a thing it had carried off. Ossrey heard it first as an absence, a notch in the water where the old carrier tone had always been. The relay that had carried the Anver voice across the Spill for a hundred years had gone flat. Ossrey pressed against the listening stone and found only the hiss that means a channel has been closed from the far end.

Ossrey was a keeper of the long memory, one of those who held the song when the others dove. The song was not music in the way the land-people meant it. It was the count made audible, each household rendered as a thread of pitch, each Ward as a bank of voices layered in the cold. To sing the song was to name the living, and to be named in it was to be, across the water and across the dark between worlds. Ossrey had learned the opening line before learning to swim, the way a calf learns the shape of the current from its mother's flank.

For a long time the song had carried without trouble. The first ledgers of the Spill had written the Anver in, had counted the deep-households by their weirs and given them standing in the wider record. Ossrey remembered the elder's account of that time, passed mouth to ear across generations: the surface worlds had filed their counts upward and found the Anver already in the aggregate, a people of the deeps with claims older than any platform. The song had run clear, and the deeps had answered it with the groan of the old stones, satisfied that the count above matched the count below.

Then the quieting began.

It came as a thinning, not a cut. One season the return from the wider count arrived missing the low voices, the ones that carried the deep-household marks. Ossrey's mother had noticed first and had sung the missing threads back into the local song, but the gap returned the next sync, wider. The relay that forwarded their frequency had started dropping packets it had once carried whole. The land-people's census, Ossrey came to understand, no longer reached for the Anver when it tallied the Spill. The count had stopped seeing them, the way a fisher stops seeing a fish that has gone below the light.

Ossrey dove to the deeps to ask the old stones what they remembered. The deeps did not answer in words. They held the pressure and the cold and the long dark where the first songs had been sung, and in that holding they kept a kind of proof: the grooves the ancestors had cut into the basalt, each groove a household, each gallery a Ward. The deeps remembered when the surface forgot. Ossrey ran a hand along the grooves and counted, the way the dead had counted, and found the number unchanged. The people had not lessened. Only the record above had stopped reaching for them, and the water below kept the older tally without

complaint.

The quieting spread from the count to the carrier. A frequency that had sung for a hundred years went dark. Ossrey had been there at the listening stone when it happened, the tone thinning to a thread and then to nothing, replaced by the flat green hiss of a channel held shut. Someone at the far authority had decided the Anver frequency should not reach the mesh. The song could still be sung in the deeps, by those who knew it, but it could no longer be carried to the worlds that had once counted them. The erasure was complete in the record and nearly complete in the relay, and the only place the full count still lived was in the throats of the keepers and the grooves of the stone.

Ossrey did not stop singing.

In the early seasons of the quieting, Ossrey had tried to mend the gap at the source. The keeper had dived to the listening stone each sync and sung the missing threads into the carrier, hoping the relay would forward them as it had before. The tone had accepted the song and returned it thin, the low voices scraped away, the deep-household marks gone. The relay no longer carried the Anver upward; it carried only the hiss that meant a hand had closed the channel at the far end. Ossrey had learned then that the mending had to happen in the throat and the stone, not in the mesh, and had turned from the carrier to the count below.

The song had a use beyond being heard. It bound the deep-households to one another across the dark, a standing claim written in pitch that no quarantine order could fully erase from the water. Ossrey taught the opening line to the young, the way it had been taught, and drilled the household threads into them until they could carry the count without the relay. A people that keeps its own song keeps its own name. The Concordance could close the frequency. It could not close the throat, and it could not close the basalt, and it could not unteach a line that had been sung for a hundred years.

Word came, in the degraded way such things cross the Spill, that a surface world had begun to notice the gaps. A census-taker on a water-world of platforms had found names in her roll that matched no ward she knew, names that were the tail of the Anver list dragged across the sync by a relay that had not fully silenced them. Ossrey heard this as a small bright thing in the dark, the way a diver hears a stone knock against the hull and knows another swimmer is near. The count had kept them where the count had tried to lose them. Someone up there was reading the margin, and the margin was the only door left open.

Ossrey composed a transmission for that reader, though it would take years to arrive and might arrive missing teeth. The song would not fit whole into a relay packet, so Ossrey sent the shape of it: the opening line, a map of the weirs rendered as marks, and a statement of the standing the Anver had held before the quieting. Let the surface world learn that the people it counted by accident were a people by right. Let it learn that the deeps had not emptied, only gone unheard,

and that the silence above was a decision and not a death.

The keeper of the long memory knew the risk. A restored count meant restored claims, and the land-people feared what the deeps would ask of them. Ossrey had no wish to drown anyone. The song had never been a threat. It had been an invitation to be counted alongside, to share the standing the Spill pretended was finite. The Concordance had read the song as a war and answered it with silence. Ossrey answered silence with more singing, quieter now, kept close, kept alive, passed from throat to throat so that no single quarantine could take it all.

Years passed in the deeps the way they pass everywhere, marked by the return of the sync and the absence in it. The young grew and learned the threads. The old stones held their grooves against the pressure. The frequency stayed dark above, but the water below carried the song from throat to throat, and the count it named stayed whole. Ossrey watched a child sing the opening line for the first time and felt the long memory hold, the way the basalt holds the groove, unbroken by anything the far authority had done.

The young keepers took up the work without being told. They dived to the listening stone on their own turns and sang the count into the dark, not because the carrier would forward it but because the singing kept the thread alive in the throat that carried it. Ossrey watched them and saw the song would outlast the keeper who had first taught it, the way the grooves outlasted the hands that cut them. A people that sings without being heard still sings, and a song sung without reply is not a song unkept.

One of the young, a diver named for the cold current, asked Ossrey why the land-people had closed the channel when the song had never harmed them. Ossrey answered with the elder's account: the surface feared the standing the count conferred, the claims the deeps could press once they were named again in the wider record. The fear was not of the song but of what the song proved, that the water under the platforms had been counted before the platforms were built. Ossrey told the diver that a proof sung in the deeps could not be unproven by an order from the light, and that the Anver would wait in the count until the surface chose to hear it.

The deeps gave back no answer to this, only the cold and the pressure and the long dark where the first songs had been sung. Ossrey found in that silence a kind of company. The stones had witnessed the whole count, from the first groove to the last thread the keeper had taught, and they would witness the rest long after the listening stone went quiet for good. The persistence of the deeps was not a promise of victory. It was a promise of memory, and memory was the only count the Anver had ever needed to keep.

There were nights when the quiet pressed in heavier than the water. The listening stone gave back only the flat hiss, and the sync returned with the Anver thread scraped from the margin as if it had never been filed. Ossrey understood

then what the erasure meant to a people who lived by the count: to be uncounted was to be unclaimable, to hold a Ward with no standing, to be a neighbor the Spill had agreed not to see. The deeps offered no comfort against that, only persistence. The grooves remained. The song remained. The people remained, below the light, refused by the record and refusing in turn to disappear.

Ossrey thought of the land-people who had built their platforms on water that the Anver had counted first. The claims were old, older than the first raft, written in the song before any surface ledger existed. The Concordance feared that restoring the count would loose those claims like a current through a broken weir. Ossrey did not see the claims as a flood. The song had always named the deep-households and the Wards together, a single count that included the water and the things built upon it. To be counted was not to take; it was to be known, and the known could be spoken to.

The transmission grew as Ossrey added to it, a slow composition measured in seasons. Each sync that returned empty was answered with another line sent into the dark, a thread of the song rendered as marks the relay might carry or might drop. Ossrey listed the weirs by their sound, the deep-households by their pitch, the galleries of the stone by the order the ancestors had cut them. The full count was long, longer than the nineteen the surface world had stumbled on, and Ossrey meant to send all of it, so that no reader could mistake the Anver for a handful of phantoms when they were a people of many Wards.

Ossrey sang the structure of the song to the young so they would know what the count contained. The opening line named the deeps themselves, the cold basin where the first voices had met. The second line named the weirs, the stone folds where the households anchored their grooves. Each line after built a Ward, and each Ward carried its own bank of pitches, high for the swimmers, low for the keepers of the stone, a middle thread for the divers who carried word between the galleries. A listener who knew the shape could reconstruct the whole people from the first three lines, the way a reader of ledgers could rebuild a household from its mark and its ward. The song was a census that needed no ink, only throats and the patience to teach them.

The teaching took the shape of the day. Ossrey woke the children at the turn of the current and walked them down the descending galleries, naming each groove as they passed, until the young could point to a mark and give the household its pitch without being prompted. The old stones listened to this teaching the way they listened to everything, without reply, and Ossrey liked to think the basalt recorded the voices the way it recorded the cuts. A people that teaches its children the count in the dark keeps the count against any order from the light. The Concordance had taken the frequency. It had not taken the galleries, and it had not taken the morning.

There were households Ossrey had never met in the flesh, deep-households that kept to the colder galleries where the pressure made the singing slow. The song

named them anyway, because the count did not require meeting, only naming, the way the surface census counted a platform ward by its list and not by its faces. Ossrey sang those far threads with extra care, lest the silence above teach the young that an unmet household was an uncounted one. The deeps held them all, met and unmet, and the song held them too, a single continuous count from the listening stone to the farthest gallery where the cold turned the voices to a slow hum.

A season came when the sync returned with a scrap of the Anver thread still attached, a few marks that had survived the quarantine by accident. Ossrey read them the way a diver reads a rope that has parted, by the end that remains. The scrap named a Ward Ossrey had thought lost to the erosion of the lower galleries, and its survival in the relay proved the count above had not fully died. Something in the mesh still forwarded the Anver, against the order, the way a leak in a hull still carries the sea. Ossrey copied the scrap into the transmission and sang it twice, once for the stone and once for the child who would carry it after.

The deeps endured a storm that year, a churn in the upper water that shook the listening stone and set the galleries groaning. Ossrey feared for the grooves, the old record cut by hands long stilled, but the basalt held. The storm passed and the stone kept its marks, and the song kept its threads, and the people kept their count in the water that had tried to take it. Ossrey understood then that the deeps were not a shelter but a witness: they did not protect the Anver from the quieting so much as they refused to forget them, and a witness that refuses to forget is harder to erase than a wall that merely stands.

Ossrey thought often of the reader on the surface world, the census-taker who had found the phantoms in her roll. The transmission would reach her across years, missing teeth, and she would have to decide what to do with a people who had counted themselves into her ledger by accident. Ossrey hoped she would fill the gaps the way a torn net is filled, by what the surrounding mesh demands, and that she would understand the Anver were not an error to be cleaned but a count to be kept. The song had always invited the surface to listen. The Concordance had answered the invitation with a closed channel. Ossrey answered it with more song, sent into the dark where the reader's hand would one day find it.

A diver returned from the far edge of the deeps with news that the cold there had thickened, that the old stone galleries leaned a little more than the elders recalled. The deeps were not eternal; they shifted, they settled, they took what they took. Ossrey sang the count over the leaning galleries so that the stone would remember the names even as it moved, the way Mossa on the surface had written a name to hold a body the sea had claimed. The deeps kept what the count could not, and the count kept what the deeps would not say aloud.

Ossrey returned to the listening stone one last time before composing the closing of the transmission. The flat green hiss was still there, a channel held shut by an order from the far authority. Ossrey laid a hand on the cold stone and felt

the hum of the relay, the slow hungry song of a Spill that had decided some of its people should not be heard. Then Ossrey sang the opening line into the water, low and clear, and the water carried it down to the deeps where the grooves kept the older count, the one the quarantine could not reach.

The transmission ended not with a plea but with a record. Ossrey listed the Wards by name, the nineteen deep-households that the surface world had already counted by accident, and added the rest, the full count the quarantine had tried to hide. Here is who we are, the transmission said in its degraded way. Here is the song you stopped carrying. The deeps keep it now, and the deeps do not forget, and the throats that sing it do not tire.

Ossrey pressed the last mark into the stone and let the current take it. Somewhere above, a census-taker on a platform world would read the margin and understand that the phantoms in her roll were a people who had refused to be unwritten. The song would reach her across the years, missing teeth, and she would fill the gaps the way a torn net is filled, by what the surrounding mesh demanded. Ossrey trusted the count more than the censors did. The count had kept them when nothing else would, and the count would keep them still.

The deeps held the pressure and the cold and the long dark, and in that dark the song went on, threaded from throat to throat, from the listening stone to the basalt grooves, from the quarantined frequency to the one reader who had started to listen. Ossrey did not know if the transmission would arrive whole. The song did not require arrival to be true. It required singing, and the Anver had not stopped, and the deeps would outlast every order written to silence them.

Chapter 09 — The Illicit Count

Vey bought the second ledger from a chandler on the low gangway, a plain thing bound in oiled canvas, the kind the raft-crews used for tallying nets. She paid in coin so no register would hold a record of the purchase. The chandler wrapped it in sailcloth without asking why a census-taker wanted a book she could have drawn from the Counting House stores for nothing. On Tarn, people learned early that some questions cost more than the answers were worth.

She carried it home under her coat, against the wind that came off the sea in the last hour of light. The platform swayed the way it always swayed, a motion she no longer felt except when she was carrying something she did not want dropped. In her room above the fishmarket she set the ledger on the table beside the lamp and opened it to the first blank page. The paper smelled of tallow and salt. It would take ink and it would not clean itself overnight, and that mattered more to her now than anything the relay-linked register could do.

At the head of the page she wrote a single word and then crossed it out, because a title would name the thing and a named thing could be found. She left the page bare instead. The count she meant to keep had no place in any

authorized book, and giving it a heading felt like nailing a flag to a roof she was trying to hide.

The first ledger, the official one, sat in the Counting House under lamp and lock, and every quarter it sent its number up the relay and took a corrupted number back. That book belonged to Tarn and to the wider count above Tarn. This one would belong to no one but the erased. Vey had spent a life trusting a single record to hold the living. Now she meant to keep two, and to let the second contradict the first wherever the first had lied.

She began with the nineteen. She knew them already, or knew the shape of them, from the phantom column that returned each quarter and from the recovered string she had pieced together out of the sync logs. Ossa of the third weir. Pellin of the deep-household. Seventeen more with marks and wards that no map of Halversand carried, because the wards were not on Halversand at all. They were somewhere in the cold water the transmissions kept naming, a place the wider count had tried to forget and the relay had failed to fully quiet.

Copying them across took the better part of a night. Vey wrote each name twice, once in the column she trusted and once in a second column where she recorded which fragment had given it to her, so that a year from now she could stand behind every letter or strike it out. A census-taker learned young that a name without its provenance carried no weight in an argument, and she meant this book to survive arguments the official ledger had never had to face. Her hand cramped by the fourth hour. She flexed it against the cold and kept on, because the sea did not stop taking on the nights she was tired, and neither, she supposed, had the wider count.

She could not do the work alone, and she had known that from the hour she bought the book.

The trouble was storage. A shadow census kept in her room was a shadow census one search would end. She thought of the platform's archive, the long low hall of paper and film beneath the Counting House where Tarn kept everything the register did not: the old raft rolls, the tide charts, the founding deeds of the platform families, the records too physical or too dead to feed to the relay. The archive answered to no sync. Nothing in it cleaned itself. A book laid among ten thousand books would be a stone dropped in a shoal of stones.

Bren kept the archive. He had kept it since before Vey came to the Counting House, a spare man with a stoop from bending over shelves and a way of finding a document by the smell of its age. He and Vey had worked the same building for years without much conversation, the census-taker and the keeper of the things the census left out. She had brought him a name once, a raft-child dead in a squall whose family wanted the founding deed amended, and Bren had found the deed in a morning when the register said it did not exist. She had trusted him a little since then, the way you trust a person who returns what the machine has swallowed.

She went down to the archive at the end of the shift, when the counting floor had emptied and the bell had rung the day closed. Bren was at his long table with a lamp and a torn tide chart, mending the fold with a strip of tissue.

"Corwin," he said, without looking up. "You're below your floor."

"I need a place to keep a book."

That made him look up. "The Counting House has shelves for books."

"Not this one." She set the canvas ledger on the table beside his tide chart. She did not open it. "It won't go on the register. It can't. And it can't sit where anyone with a Concordance seal can call for it."

Bren set down his tissue and his brush. He did not touch the ledger. For a while he looked at it the way a man looks at weather he has been warned about, and Vey let the silence run, because she had learned from Pell that a silence held long enough would tell you what a person had already decided.

"You know what's in the sync," he said at last. It was not a question.

"I know some of it. I know the phantoms aren't residue. I know there's a people in the count that the wider count keeps trying to lose. I mean to keep them somewhere it can't reach."

"And you came to me because paper doesn't sync."

"I came to you because you find what the machine drops. This is the same work. It's only a different drawer."

Bren stood and walked to the end of his hall, to a run of shelving where the oldest deeds sat in their boxes, the founding papers of families three generations gone. He drew a box down and opened it and showed her the deeds inside, brittle and brown, each one a claim on a scrap of platform that no living hand still held.

"These are dead," he said. "Nobody calls for them. A Concordance auditor could stand in this hall a year and never open this box, because the register says these people ended and the register is what they read." He set the box on the table. "A book in here reads as one more dead thing. That's the only shelter I can give it. It's not much."

"It's more than my room."

"It's more than most things get." He turned one of the brittle deeds over with two fingers, careful of the fold. "You know why the register never asks after these? Because they made their claim and the claim closed. Dead men file no complaints. That's the whole reason the archive is quiet. Nobody guards a graveyard." He set the deed down. "Your book won't be quiet forever. One day it'll want to speak, and then it stops being a dead deed and starts being a thing worth taking. You understand that. The shelf holds it until it doesn't."

"I understand it," Vey said. "I'm asking for the until."

He was quiet again, and then he did the thing she had hoped he would do and had not let herself expect. He took the canvas ledger, wrapped it in a strip of the

acid-free tissue he used for the founding deeds, and laid it in the box among the dead claims. He wrote nothing on the box. He slid it back onto the shelf at the height of his own shoulder, third from the end, and stood so his body marked the place before he stepped away.

"Third from the end, this run," he said. "You'll want to know where without a chart. Don't write it down."

"I won't."

"And Corwin." He turned the lamp so the light fell off her face. "If they come for the archive, the book's a dead deed and I never saw you carry it in. That's the arrangement. I won't lie better than that, and you shouldn't ask me to."

"That's the arrangement," she said.

After that the work became a matter of hours she did not have and took anyway.

Every second night, when the fishmarket below her window had shut and the gangways had gone quiet, Vey went down to the archive with a lamp Bren left burning for her and drew the box from its shelf. She worked at his long table with the founding deeds around her, the dead claims of Tarn keeping the erased company while she counted them. She had come to think of the archive as the only honest room in Halversand, a place where a thing that had ended was allowed to stay written.

The tallying was slow because her sources were ruined. She had the phantom column, which gave her nineteen names on Tarn's roll, the tail of a longer list. She had the three sync logs she had already reconciled once. And she had, now, the thing Cira had shown her at the Redoubt: not the quarantined frequency itself, which the console would not tune, but the bleed-through, the ragged margin where the quiet frequency leaked into the transmissions the relay still carried. A frequency held quiet was not a frequency erased. It pressed against its silence, and the pressure showed up as noise in the neighboring bands, and in that noise, if you were patient and half-mad, names surfaced.

Vey was patient. She had counted lanterns on a raft-line as a child, one lit household at a time, and she counted the erased the same way now, letter by recovered letter, filling the torn places by what the surrounding mesh demanded. A name would come through with its middle eaten and she would hold it against the ordering of the list, the way the phantoms had taught her the list was ordered, weir by weir and household by household, and the ordering would hand her back the missing letters. It was not certainty. It was the same argument Mossa had made against the sea, a name written down as a refusal to let the water keep what it took.

Some nights the bleed-through gave her nothing usable, only a wash of static where names should have surfaced, and she would sit an hour with the lamp and

the empty page and gain not one line. Other nights a whole household rose out of the noise at once, a mark and a weir and four names hung beneath it like lit panes in a row, and she would write fast to catch them before the next sync overwrote the band. She learned to read the relay's moods the way she had once read the tide table, to know which hours of the cycle ran clean and which ran drowned. She kept her working sheets in her coat and burned them when she had transferred what they held, so that only the canvas ledger carried the count, and only the archive carried the ledger.

She started a column for each source and a column for the reconciled name, and she made a rule for herself and wrote it at the top of the working page: a name went into the shadow count only when two sources agreed on it, so that her want would not invent a person the water had not held. She was building a census, not a wish. A census kept its discipline or it became the same lie in the other direction.

By the third week she had forty-one. By the sixth she had passed a hundred, and the shape of what she was counting had begun to frighten her in a way the numbers on Tarn's roll never had. The list did not describe nineteen strays. It described a people. Wards and weirs and deep-households ran on past the tail that bled into Tarn's count, hundreds of entries deep in the fragments, and every fragment she recovered implied a dozen more the relay had bitten clean away. She was not restoring a handful of dropped names. She was reading the edge of a nation the wider count had spent a century trying to unwrite.

One night Bren stayed while she worked, which he had not done before.

He sat at the far end of the table mending a deed he did not need to mend, and Vey understood he was keeping her company the way a man keeps watch, without saying so. She let him. The archive was steadier with two people breathing in it.

"How many now," he said, after an hour.

"A hundred and thirty. On this shelf." She did not look up from the fragment she was filling. "There's more in the bleed-through than I'll ever pull out. For every one I set down, there's ten the mesh ate. So the number in the book is low. It'll always be low. That's the part I can't fix."

Bren set his brush down. "A count that's low is still a count. Low beats nothing. Low beats a blank where a people used to be."

"That's what I keep telling the page." She wrote a name and set the stylus down and pressed the heels of her hands against her eyes. "But a low count is a claim the other side can pick apart. If it ever comes to a claim. You give a Registrar a number you admit is low, and the first thing a Registrar does is call the whole book unreliable and throw out the part that's solid with the part that's guessed."

"Then you mark which is which," Bren said. "You already do. Two sources or it doesn't go in. Keep that line and no one can burn the solid part with the soft part. That's the difference between a shadow count and a rumor."

Vey lowered her hands and looked at him, this spare man who mended dead deeds and had just given her, without meaning to, the standard the whole book would have to meet. He was right. A shadow census that mixed the certain with the hoped would die the moment anyone with authority breathed on it. A shadow census that fenced its certain names behind a rule could not be waved away.

"You've done this before," she said.

"I keep records for a living. The trick's always the same. You make the record able to survive the man who wants it dead." He picked his brush back up. "I never had a record worth that trouble before. This one might be."

Vey went back to the fragment. Somewhere out past the platform and past the cold water, on a frequency the console would not tune, a people it was named for kept pressing against the silence they had been given, and the pressure kept leaking into the neighboring bands, and she kept fishing the names out one at a time. She thought of the Anver as she had begun to think of the raft-line at dusk, a run of dark households where a lantern had gone out. Someone had to walk the line in the rain and find out why. The wider count had stopped walking a hundred years before. She had a lamp Bren kept burning and a book that would not clean itself, and that was enough to start.

She did not tell Pell. She did not tell Cira how far it had gone, though Cira knew a book existed and had said, once, only, that she did not want to know where. Vey kept the circle small on purpose. A shadow census survived by how few hands knew the shelf it sat on, and every hand she added was a hand that could be made to open.

The work changed her habits. She ate at the archive now, between the dead deeds and the lamp, and she slept less than the floor expected of a census-taker in good standing. Bren brought her bread and said nothing about the box, which was the kind of loyalty that asked for no record of itself. Some nights a name arrived clean from two sources and she wrote it without hesitation; other nights the corruption left only a mark and a ward, and she wrote that too, marking it uncertain, because an uncertain count was still a count, and a blank was nothing. She had begun to think of the shadow ledger as a second Tarn, built beneath the first, where the erased kept a different kind of citizenship. It would never be mailed. It would never carry the Concordance's seal. But it would be true, because the authorized number had given up truth, and the silence had been built to require exactly that. She guarded it the way Mossa had guarded a lantern in a storm: not because the storm would end, but because the light was the argument. Each name she added was a small defiance of the silence, and defiance, practiced nightly, becomes a kind of steadiness, and steadiness was what the erased had been denied.

At the end of the second month she carried the reconciled page down to the archive and copied its names into the canvas ledger in her own slow hand, the

certain ones, the two-source ones, one line each, a mark made and a life accounted against a count that had tried to make the life a blank. A hundred and forty-four now. She wrote the number at the foot of the page and did not send it anywhere. It went up no relay. It took no corrupted number back. It sat on a shelf third from the end among the dead deeds of Tarn, a count with no world above it and no seal on its cover, growing by two sources a night.

When she closed the ledger the box smelled of tallow and old paper and the tissue Bren wrapped it in, and Vey stood for a moment with her hand flat on the lid. On the register upstairs, one million two hundred and four thousand and nineteen was still the wrong number, and it would stay wrong until she could make the right one loud. Down here the right one was small and growing and true as far as it went, kept in a room where the machine could not reach, kept the only way a thing gets kept when everyone above you has agreed to forget it. She slid the box back to its place at the height of Bren's shoulder, third from the end, and blew out the lamp, and left the erased in the dark with the dead, where for now they were safe.

Chapter 10 — The Reckoning Clause

The archive beneath the Counting House smelled of damp paper and iron, the way all the old record rooms on Halversand smelled once the tide pushed in under the floorboards. Vey Corwin had come down before the bell, with Bren the archivist's key still warm in her pocket and the shadow ledger folded inside her coat. She had spent three weeks tallying the Anver from the bleed-through fragments, and the tally had told her only half of what she needed. A count named them. A count did not, by itself, give them a right the Spill would honor.

Bren had left her the key with a shrug and a warning about the mold. He kept the deep archive because someone had to, and because the relay-linked register upstairs had a habit of forgetting anything older than the current quarter. The paper here remembered. Vey trusted paper more than she trusted a console that cleaned itself while she slept.

She set the lantern on the edge of the reading desk and opened the first of the bound concordance copies. These were the ledgers the wider Spill had sent down across the years, the ones the Counting House was meant to keep but mostly shelved. Most worlds filed their own counts and let the concordance house the rest. Tarn had stopped reading the wider volumes sometime after the silence began, and the dust on the spines said how long.

The Anver entries sat in the early books, the ones from the first decades after the Spill settled into its slow isolation. Vey had found them by accident two weeks before, in a quarter-roll that predated the overnight clean. They were listed plainly then, with wards and water and household marks that matched the phantoms she had carried in her small book since the winter. The count had known them once.

The count had been made to forget.

What she had not found was the reason the forgetting had legal weight. An erased name was a sorrow. An erased name with a founding claim behind it was a debt the Spill had chosen not to read. Vey meant to read it.

She worked through the morning. The concordance volumes ran in a clumsy chronology, each world's local count bound beside the standing orders that governed it. Tarn's waters were listed as settled in the eighty-something year, a plain line about platforms raised on a sea that had belonged to no registered holder. Vey had read that line a dozen times and felt the gap in it the way she felt a missing mark in a household roll. Someone had counted the platforms. No one had counted what the platforms stood on.

The early volumes told the story plainly, before the quiet set in. The first concordance settlement had been a crowded thing, forty worlds and a mesh that still remembered being one polity, and the clerks who wrote it had tried to be fair to whoever answered the count. Human worlds filed their platforms. Water peoples filed their deeps. The settlement had listed both, side by side, because in the first years no one had yet decided that one kind of count outranked the other. Vey read those early entries with a kind of hunger. The Anver appeared in the third volume under a ward-mark she now recognized from the phantoms, listed as holders of the northern basins that Tarn's platforms later crowded upon. The count had said so. The count had then been told, a hundred years on, to unsay it.

She traced the sequence the way she traced a household roll gone wrong. The first entry named the Anver and their waters. The next decade's supplement affirmed it. The decade after that carried a standing order she had to read twice, a short line instructing the wider count to file the water peoples under a quieter heading, and then a line after that, shorter still, instructing the relay not to forward the heading at all. The erasure had not been a single stroke. It had been a slow leaning, year by year, until the name sat in the archive and nowhere else.

The gap closed two volumes later, in a supplement bound in a thinner, yellower paper that the archivists had clearly meant to file and then filed badly. Vey found it because the spine had split and the supplement had slid half out, caught between a Tarn roll and a count from Osel she would never need. She pulled it free and set it open on the desk. The page that fell open was not the Anver entry she expected. It was the concordance's own index of standing, a list of which peoples held founding claims and which held none, and at the top of the list, above Tarn and Osel and every platform world she had ever counted, sat the water peoples, with the Anver written first.

Vey sat back on the stool. The index was older than the silence by decades. It had been the concordance's own admission, filed as routine, that the platforms stood on borrowed water. Someone in a later year had simply stopped binding the index with the live counts, the way the Counting House had stopped reading the wider volumes, until the admission lived only in a split-spined supplement no clerk

was told to open.

The supplement carried a header she had not seen in any of the authorized copies upstairs: FOUNDING STANDING, with a sub-line in a smaller hand that read entered per the first concordance settlement and never repealed. Below the header ran a clause, long and legal and careful, that granted the original water peoples of the Spill their standing in the census by the fact of having been counted first. The Anver were named in the third line, among the earliest colonies, with a note that their waters predated every human platform raised upon them.

Vey read the clause three times. The working verb in it was grant, and the grant was not to the concordance. It was to the peoples who had been there when the count began. The concordance had written the clause to acknowledge what it could not honestly deny: the platforms floated on someone else's floor.

The clause gave the Anver standing. Standing, in the census, was the whole of the matter. To be counted was to exist, and to exist with standing was to hold a claim the other counts could not erase by ignoring it. The first concordance had admitted as much and signed it, and no later concordance had ever struck the line. They had buried it instead, in a supplement no one on Tarn had been told to open.

She traced the line with her stylus. A claim was only words until someone with standing pressed it. The Anver had lost the standing when the count dropped them, and the Spill had spent a hundred and thirty years pretending the debt had expired with the people who held it. Vey saw now that the debt had only been waiting, filed under a paper the relay had been told not to forward.

The clause named more than the Anver. It named the principle: whoever the first count had listed as holding the water held it still, against any later platform that floated above. Vey ran her finger down the index of standing and felt the weight of it the way she felt a total that would not close. Tarn's northern basins, by the clause, belonged to a people the Counting House had been told were residue. Osel's coast, by the same logic, belonged to whatever water folk had answered the first count there. Pellune, Vrey, Thann, Callow, every platform world that had raised itself on a sea someone had counted before the humans came, all of them owed a standing they had never been asked to pay. The concordance had not buried the clause because it was unimportant. It had buried the clause because it was precise.

She thought about what the shadow count would mean once it reached those worlds. The nineteen names she carried were only Tarn's fragment of a Spill-wide people. Restore them, and the clause gave them the right to ask Tarn for the basins, Osel for the coast, every water-world for the floor beneath its planks. The concordance called that the reckoning because it would not be quiet. A hundred and thirty years of unpaid standing would come due at once, in claims no clerk could append over.

Vey understood, then, why Pell had warned her and why the ledger-house had signed the quarantine. Not cruelty. Fear of the bill. A people restored to the count

did not simply reappear in a column. They reappeared with a founding claim, and the claim touched every platform that had been raised on their silence.

She read the rest of the supplement with the lantern close. The clause ran longer than the header suggested. After the grant of standing came the part the concordance had clearly written with reluctance, a list of what standing entitled a founding people to press: a share of the count itself, a hearing before whatever authority held the wider ledger, and access to the relay frequency that carried their own transmissions. The last item landed like a stone. The concordance had quarantined the Anver frequency to keep them from being counted. The clause said the frequency was theirs by standing. The quarantine was not just an erasure. It was a withholding of a right the first settlement had signed.

Vey copied that part too, word for word, because it named the remedy as plainly as it named the debt. The concordance could quarantine a frequency. It could not, by its own founding clause, deny the people who held standing the use of it. The tension between the two orders was the whole of the silence. One clerk a century ago had written a quarantine; another, earlier, had written the standing; and the later order had never repealed the earlier one. It had simply stopped binding it with the live counts, the way a household hides a bill by not opening the drawer.

She thought of Cira at the relay, and the flat green line that had once sung. The frequency was quiet because the ledger-house had told it to be, and the clause said the quiet was theft. Cira would understand that better than any census-taker. A teller who kept a frequency from its own people was not maintaining the mesh. She was enforcing a debt someone had decided not to pay.

The supplement ended with a seal, the old concordance mark pressed in red wax, and a date from the first decade of the settlement. Whoever had signed it had believed the standing would never need pressing, because the peoples who held it were still in the count. They could not have imagined a concordance that would spend a hundred years learning to un-count a people rather than answer them. Vey pressed her thumb to the seal and felt the small hardness of it, a signature older than the silence, still warm from the archive's damp.

Bren's key turned in the door halfway through the second hour. He came in with a basket of cracked bindings and a look that said he had been expecting her to fall down the archive eventually.

"You found the old standing volume," he said, setting the basket down. "Most don't. We stopped shelving those with the live counts after the orders came down to keep the wider ledgers quiet."

"Who gave the orders."

"Whoever sits at the ledger-house and signs the quarantine." Bren nodded at the supplement in her hands. "That one's a problem, Corwin. The moment you restore a people with founding standing, every human world that built on their

waters owes them a count and a claim. The concordance calls that the reckoning. They named it before they buried it."

Vey looked up from the page. "They named it."

"In the margin of the standing orders, yes. The reckoning clause, they called the whole settlement, because it was the part that would come due. They filed it and hoped no one on a water-world would read far enough to find it." Bren picked up the lantern and held it closer to the supplement. "You've read far enough."

She had. The word sat in the margin of the concordance copy in a hand that had clearly meant it as a warning to the next clerk, not a secret to keep forever. The reckoning clause. The concordance had written the name itself into the book that admitted the Anver's claim, as if signing the debt were the same as paying it.

Vey closed the supplement and opened her shadow ledger to a fresh page. She wrote the clause out by hand, the whole of it, because the relay would never carry it and the archive might yet be told to forget. Then she wrote beneath it, in the plain script she used for decisions: restoring them is not mercy. It is the clause coming due.

The bell rang the count in upstairs, distant and flat through the floor. Vey listened to it the way she had learned to listen to the relay's hum, for what it left out. The Counting House would open and run its clean and close its books on a count that named the living and forgot the owed. She would not.

She thought of her brother, counted out on a casualty list and never restored, and understood the clause in a second way. Brenn had lost his standing the moment the count dropped him, and the count had dropped him by error, not by order. The Anver had lost theirs by order, and the order had been signed. An error could be corrected by a stubborn clerk with a stylus. A signed order required the Spill to admit it had owed a people from the first platform nail.

Bren leaned against the desk. "You know what happens when you push a founding claim onto the mesh."

"I know what they call it." Vey tapped the margin where the word sat. "The Reckoning. They named it because they feared it, not because it was wrong. A fear in the margin is still a debt in the line."

He was quiet for a moment, the lantern throwing his shadow long across the concordance volumes. "Pell will tell you to leave it."

"Pell told me to leave the phantoms. I didn't." She folded the shadow ledger closed. "The clause gives them the standing. The shadow count gives them the names. The only thing missing is someone willing to read the line aloud where the Spill can hear it."

"Then you've found your work." Bren took the lantern back and nodded at the supplement. "Keep that page. The archive forgets on purpose now. You'll need the original when the claims start."

Vey slipped the supplement into her coat beside the ledger. The paper was thin and old and heavier than its weight, because it carried the sentence the concordance had never repealed. She climbed the stairs out of the archive with the tide pulling at the platform and the bell still ringing the count in above her.

In the Counting House the clerks had begun their flat chant, naming the living aloud so Tarn could agree with itself about who it was. Vey took her place at the slanted desk and set the shadow ledger where the register could not reach it. The authorized count would close at the tenth hour with nineteen names it refused to place and a debt it refused to read. She had the clause that proved the debt was real, and the standing that made it collectable, and the will to press a claim the Spill had spent a century pretending to lose.

She opened her small book and wrote the date, and beneath it a line she meant to carry to the broadcast when the time came: the Anver were counted first, and the count owes them the water it was built on. The reckoning was not a threat she was making. It was a clause someone else had written and buried, and she had only to read it where the Spill could no longer pretend not to hear.

The clause would not win the Anver their basins by itself. It would win them the standing to ask, and the frequency to be heard, and the count that proved they had been there first. The rest would be argued by people Vey would never meet, on worlds the relay took years to reach, in a Spill that had spent a century practicing how not to listen. She did not fool herself that the reading of one old line would settle anything. It would open the drawer the concordance had closed, and the bill inside would be louder than the silence that had hidden it.

Vey thought of the nineteen names in her shadow ledger, and of the hundreds more the Spill had dropped and never listed, and of the clause that said every one of them had held standing from the first count. The concordance had feared the reckoning because it would not be tidy. A tidy silence was easier to file than a hundred founding claims arriving at once. Easier was not the same as right, and the count had taught her that a number left to rot in a drawer was still a debt, only one no one had the courage to read aloud.

She closed the small book and stood. The platform shifted under her as the tide turned, the way it always did at the second hour, and the bell rang on above her with its flat, certain count of the living. Vey meant to add the owed to it, one people at a time, until the Spill accounted for what it had tried to drown. The reckoning clause was the key she had been looking for, and she had found it filed under the very silence that the key unlocked.

Chapter 11 — The Registrar

The quarantine order lay open on Ollan Drase's desk, its margins thick with the red stamps of three concordant authorities, and Drase read it the way a ferryman reads weather he has no power to change. He had signed its latest renewals; his

office had signed the first order more than a century earlier, and the signatures had outlived every hand that set them. The Ledger-House kept no memory of who had been afraid when the order was written. It kept only the order, folded into the standing record where a hundred later hands had affirmed it without reading past the heading.

Drase had been afraid. He remembered the shape of that fear better than he remembered his wife's face in the years before she stopped waiting up for him, and the memory arrived now the way it always did, unbidden and exact, the moment he set the stylus near the renewal line.

He turned the page. The order named a frequency, a block of the relay mesh that carried the old sonic broadcasts, and it instructed every Teller station from Tarn to Callow to forward the block without tuning to it, to carry it dark. A quarantine, the concordance called it, as though the word could soften the act of carrying a people's voice while refusing to listen. Drase had written that phrasing. He had believed it necessary. He still believed it necessary, and the part that kept him at the desk past the hour the lamps in the long hall went dim was the believing itself.

Around him the Ledger-House did its quiet work. Clerks moved between the ranked cabinets where the Authorized Census lived on paper and on the slow iron registers, and the hum of the central relay reached even here, a tooth-felt vibration under the floor. This was the heart of the concordance's memory, the place where forty worlds agreed, year after year, about who counted and who did not. Drase had come up through those cabinets. He had been a junior hand correcting ward totals on Osel before he ever saw the quarantine order, and he had learned early that a count could serve as a weapon or a wall, depending on what it left outside.

The wall had held for a hundred and thirty years, and Drase measured his life against it the way a mason measures against a plumb line, by how little had shifted.

He set the order down and walked to the window that looked out over the relay yards. Below, tellers in their grey shifts carried spools between the beacons, and the yards stretched toward a horizon the concordance had long since stopped trying to cross in person. The Spill was forty worlds that could no longer meet. Drase had made peace with that fact the way other men make peace with the death of a parent, by continuing to behave as though the loss were a manageable thing, a draft in the house rather than the absence of a wall.

A younger registrar, Kendt by name, had asked him once why the frequency had to stay dark. Drase had answered with the census totals, with the founding claims buried in the old ledgers, with the arithmetic of what would happen to the human settlements built over Anver water if those claims were ever honored. Kendt had listened and gone away unsettled, which was the correct response to an honest answer. Drase did not blame the boy for his unease. He blamed no one. Blame

required a culprit, and the silence had been built by committees, by men long dead, by the reasonable fear of men who had seen what an open count could do and had chosen the wall.

He had seen it. That was the memory the desk always brought back, the one he did not tell Kendt, the one he had told no one in full, because to tell it was to admit that he had learned the lesson the hard way and had never found a softer version of it since.

Thirty years before, when Drase was still a ward auditor on the frontier of the count, two human worlds had disputed a stretch of unsettled shore. Thann claimed the western inlet; Vrey claimed the same water on the strength of a household tally older than either settlement's charter. The concordance, in those looser years, had counted both claims as standing, had published a census that named the inlet twice, and had left the two worlds to settle the matter between them. Drase had been the hand who entered the duplicate into the Authorized Census. He had thought it a kindness, a way to avoid telling one world it did not exist where it said it did, and he had argued for the entry in the review room with a warmth he no longer had in him.

The inlet had filled with boats. Not armies, not at first, only fishers from Thann who found Vrey markers on their weirs and cut them loose, and Vrey crews who came back with oars and anger. The concordance sent a correction a year too late, carried by the Static at its slow pace, and by the time the order reached either shore the water had already taken nine men. Drase read the casualty report in the quiet of a counting office on Osel, and he understood then that a count was not a description of the world. It was a lever on it, and the lever did not care who pulled.

Nine men, for an inlet, for two tallies that should never have been allowed to stand at once.

He had spent the rest of his career making sure no count ever named two truths where one would do. Silence over the Anver frequency applied that principle at the scale of a people. If the Anver were restored to the census, they returned with founding claims over waters that a hundred and thirty years of human settlement had covered with platforms and cities and the counted lives of millions. The Reckoning, as the old clause named it, would not be nine men. It would be forty worlds discovering that the ground under their homes had been claimed first by someone they had agreed to forget, and discovering it at the same slow, irreversible pace the Static allowed, so that the knowledge would arrive in fragments and fester in the gaps.

Drase did not think the Anver undeserving. That was the cruelty he refused to grant the memory, the easy comfort of believing the erased were lesser. He had read the recovered fragments, the sonic patterns rendered into text by technicians cleverer than he was, and he had found in them a people who counted their own with care, who sang their households into the relay the way the old lantern-keepers on Tarn had hung lights above the water. They were not lesser.

They were a claim. And a claim, once honored, moves the world under the people standing on it, and the people do not always step aside.

He went back to the desk. The lamps in the hall had dimmed to a single row, and his own lamp threw the red stamps into relief. Somewhere on Tarn a census-taker named Vey Corwin had begun to ask why nineteen names would not wash out of her roll. Drase knew her kind. He had been her kind, before the inlet. Precise, stubborn, certain that a name left out of the count was a body left in the sea. He admired the instinct and feared it in equal measure, the way a man who has fought a fire admires the child who strikes the match, knowing the spark will find something to burn.

Beneath the order sat Kendt's dispatch from Tarn, six pages of corrections and one page that avoided the word failure. The local register had retained entries from the dark frequency through three cleaning cycles. An auditor could call that residue if the entries changed. These had not. Drase circled the line that said SAME HOUSEHOLD MARKS and felt the old unease settle behind his ribs. Walls failed first at the mortar, not the stone. Nineteen names amounted to a hairline crack, yet every breach began at a size the builder could dismiss.

From the lowest drawer he took a translation sheet the official file did not require him to keep. The paper had softened at the folds. It carried thirty-one words recovered from an Anver transmission twenty-two years earlier, a fragment too slight for standing and too complete for comfort. A household announced three births, two deaths, and a migration from a failing deep. The translator had added a note beside the last line: speaker repeats count until acknowledgment. No acknowledgment had gone back. The relay had forwarded the voice into the quarantine, and the Ledger-House had archived the attempt under noise.

For one minute Drase permitted himself the arithmetic the standing order forbade. Three births minus two deaths left one more living person in that household than before. A census-taker would add the mark. A registrar would ask whether the household had standing. He had asked the second question so long that the first now felt illicit, but the sum remained on the page no matter how he classified it.

Once, his wife had found that translation in the pocket of his coat. She had not understood the notation, though she recognized a household count when she saw one. She asked why he carried it home. Drase told her it concerned a pending review. By then the review had been closed for eleven years. She placed the folded sheet beside his plate and said nothing else, and her silence had accused him more accurately than a question could have done. He began leaving his coat at the Ledger-House after that.

Tonight the same crease caught under his thumb. He pictured the unknown speaker repeating a count into years of Static, waiting for a receipt that procedure had prohibited. The Anver would never know Ollan Drase had read the words. They would know only that no one answered. He could release the fragment as an

exception, a single household stripped of its claim references, but an exception would establish a path. The next registrar could widen it. The next census-taker could ask why a birth deserved acknowledgment while a founding claim did not.

Carefully, he returned the sheet to the drawer. The decision cost him less each time, which frightened him more than the decision itself. He had expected guilt to sharpen with repetition. Instead it wore grooves through him, making the stylus easier to hold and the explanations easier to give. A cruel man would have slept. Drase did not count his sleeplessness as virtue. It proved only that he understood the entry he refused to make.

The quarantine order was due for its quarterly renewal. His signature was the last line. Above it, the concordance's reasoning ran to two careful paragraphs about bandwidth and standing orders, and nowhere did it say what Drase knew it meant: silence served as a wall, the wall kept the peace, and that peace carried a cost measured in a people who still sang into a frequency no one would tune to.

He picked up the stylus. His hand did not shake. That was the worst of it, the steadiness. He had made the argument so many times, to himself and to Kendt and to the concordant authorities, that the stylus felt like a tool he owned rather than a weight he carried, and the owning was its own kind of failure, a man who had confused duty with comfort.

A count names the living. The concordance had decided, a hundred and thirty years before Drase took this desk, that some of the living were safer unnamed. Drase had spent his life defending that decision because he had seen what an open count could do to men who believed the world owed them the ground they stood on. He did not believe the Anver evil. He believed the Spill fragile, its forty worlds held together by the agreement to look away from certain truths, and he believed that the day the Anver returned to the census would be the day forty worlds remembered they had reasons to fight, and that the fighting would not stay on the water.

The stylus touched the line.

He signed. The red stamp followed, his authority pressed into the margin beside three others, and the quarantine held for another quarter. Somewhere on Tarn the frequency stayed dark, and the people who sang into it kept singing, and Drase set the order aside and did not go home, because home was where his wife had stopped asking why he worked so late, because the desk carried the only work he still trusted, because the argument he had left was the only one he knew how to make.

He opened the next file. It was a routine reconciliation from Pellune, a world that had no idea its census rested on a silence it had never been told about, and Drase read it with the same care he gave the order, because the peace he defended was built from a thousand such quiet readings, each one a name left out so that a world could stay calm, each one a small betrayal performed with a steady hand and a clear conscience.

The lamp burned low. In the relay yards the tellers had gone, and the beacons hummed their slow song into a dark that the concordance had chosen. Drase listened to it the way a ferryman listens to weather, and he did not forgive himself, and he did not stop, because stopping would mean admitting the wall had been the wrong shape all along, and he had built his life against it.

He thought of the nine men in the inlet, and of the platforms that would come down if the Anver ever stood, and he weighed the two sorrows against each other the way a man weighs two loads of stone, neither of which he can set down. The first sorrow he could name and number. The second was a shape he had only inferred from the old ledgers, the founding claims written in a script the concordance no longer taught, the wards and water-rights that predated every human charter on the Spill. He had read those claims as a young auditor and felt the floor tilt under him, because they were just, and they were impossible to honor without unmaking the worlds built on top of them.

That impossibility was the whole of his argument. Not that the Anver were wrong. That the Spill could not survive being right about them.

A sound came from the outer hall, a clerk locking the cabinet rows for the night. Drase answered it with the ritual of his evening, gathering the files into their proper order, the quarantine renewal on top, the Pellune reconciliation beneath, the old claim ledgers in the drawer where he kept the things he read but did not act on. He had read those ledgers a hundred times. He would read them a hundred more, and he would sign the renewal a hundred more times, because the alternative was a door he had decided, thirty years before at an Osel counting desk, that he would not open.

Outside the window the horizon held no answers. The Spill was forty worlds that could not meet, and Drase was the man who made sure they did not have to, by keeping the one truth that would have forced the meeting. He closed the file on Pellune and reached for the next, because the count went on whether or not the counter slept, and because sleep had stopped offering him anything he wanted to see.

The quarantine would come due again in three months. He would sign it again. He had made his peace with the cost the way a man makes peace with a limp, by walking on it, and the walking served as the only confession he allowed himself, performed nightly at a desk in the Ledger-House, under a lamp that remembered no one, over an order that kept the silence and the peace together, as they had always been, as they would remain until someone braver than he was decided the quiet was not worth its price.

He thought of Vey Corwin on Tarn, the stubborn census-taker who would not let nineteen names wash out, and he felt for her the strange mixture of pride and dread he reserved for his own younger self. She would push, and the push would travel the Static slowly, and the concordance would feel it as a tremor in a wall it had trusted for a century. Drase did not know if she would win. He knew only that if

she did, the reckoning would be his fault as much as anyone's, because he had held the line that made the breaking necessary.

The ledger on his desk held the count of forty worlds, and not one of those worlds knew that its calm rested on a person's refusal to sign a different name. Drase knew. That knowledge supplied the weight he carried instead of a family, instead of a wife who had stopped waiting, instead of the sleep he no longer chased. It was a full weight. It left no room for anything else.

He set his hand flat on the closed file and let the hum of the relay carry the thought away the way the Static carried everything, slowly, and with something lost in the passage. The quarantine held. The frequency stayed dark. The peace, such as it was, continued, and Drase sat with it in the lamp's small circle, the last man awake in the Ledger-House, the keeper of a silence he had never stopped questioning and had never stopped defending, until the hall went fully dark and even the beacons outside seemed to listen for a song that no one would tune to, and he was only a man at a desk, signing, as he had signed, as he would sign, for the quiet that kept forty worlds from learning what they had lost.

Chapter 12 — The Leak

The salt had crusted the window of the Counting House shut again, and Vey pried it open with the blunt end of her stylus to let the wind carry the smell of the lower market through the room. She had come in before the bell on purpose. The shadow ledger waited in her drawer, thicker now by three sheets than it had been the week she started it, and she meant to add to it before anyone on the floor noticed she had arrived.

Cira's message had reached her the night before by the fast same-world line, the kind the relay carried in hours rather than years. It said only: the sync pulled something. Come to the Redoubt.

Vey folded the note into her sleeve and walked the gangways toward the edge of Halversand, where the planks thinned and the sea wind took hold. The Redoubt stood at the very lip of the platform, a low iron house with a hum that lived in the teeth. She had learned to read that hum the way Mossa had read the swing of lanterns, as a thing that told her what the water was doing out of sight.

Cira met her at the door with ink on her thumb and a frown that did not lift when she saw who it was. The relay room behind her carried the green cast of the side screens, and one of them held a band of text Vey had not expected to see outside her own drawer.

"There," Cira said, and tapped the screen. "Your count. Or part of it."

The shadow ledger belonged on paper. Vey had copied it from bleed-through fragments, stored the full leaves with Bren at the archive, and shown it to no one but Cira and Pell. It named nineteen households that the Authorized Census

refused. On the screen, nine of those names stood in the corrupted margin of a transmission marked RECEIVED, EXCEPTION FILED.

"A fragment reached Pellune," Cira said. "Not the whole count. A piece. Their Receiving House noticed it and attached a mismatch notice. The notice came back through the Static this morning."

Vey set her hands flat on the console. Years had passed between the date at the head of the fragment and the exception now glowing below it. The first copied page had somehow touched a routine census packet when she began keeping the names, before Bren took the shadow ledger into the archive. Tarn's reader had lifted nine lines as marginal marks. The mesh forwarded them the way it forwarded everything, one slow relay after another, losing characters and route tags until Pellune caught what remained.

Cira brought up the outgoing image beside the returned notice. A crease crossed the corner of Vey's page. She remembered making it. On a wet morning three census cycles earlier, she had folded the page beneath the authorized roll so a passing clerk would not see the impossible ward. She had set both on the reader while she opened its cover. The machine had caught the lower sheet before she pulled it free.

"I checked the plate history," Cira said. "The reader took one partial exposure. You saw the clean packet report and thought nothing else had gone. The hidden exposure sat in the packet margin, too faint for our register and strong enough to survive the first hop."

"Three years," Vey said.

"Thirty-seven months out and back. Pellune lies close by the standards of the Spill. Close still means the message grew old on the road."

She watched the green band move. Corruption had taken the first letters from two names and the household endings from three. Six remained readable. Beneath them, a Pellune Teller had typed a short procedural question: UNPLACED PERSONS. AUTHORITY FOR INCLUSION? The words carried no outrage. They carried attention, which frightened the Concordance more.

Vey read the question twice. Another person on another world had seen the list and stopped. That unknown Teller had compared it to the Authorized Census, found no match, and refused to clean it without asking. A fragment of the shadow count had crossed the distance between worlds and made someone look again.

"Who filed it," Vey asked.

Cira pulled the routing margin. "Name dropped. Station mark survived. Pellune Receiving House, north table. Their local time stamp sits here. They noticed nine months ago. The return took the rest."

"Did they send it to the Ledger-House?"

"The exception route does that automatically. It sends one copy toward the

origin and another toward central review. The copy for Tarn lost two blocks. We can't know what central kept."

The slowness of the Static had hidden the event from them after it happened. While Vey built the ledger in Bren's archive and added households from the quarantined frequency, the first nine names had already reached Pellune. The Teller there had already noticed. A notice had already begun crawling toward the Ledger-House, years too late for Vey to prevent and perhaps weeks early enough for Kendt to act on.

"How much can central read," Vey said.

"At least what we can. More, if their route dropped fewer packets." Cira pointed at the station mark. "Pellune's Teller classified it as census conflict, not relay noise. That classification survives even if every name falls out. Whoever sees the header knows one world sent people absent from the Authorized Census."

The proof amounted to less than Vey's full ledger and more than rumor. Six legible names, three broken marks, one impossible ward, and a distant Teller's question had made the hidden count visible. The leak could not be called back. It had arrived, and someone beyond Tarn had read it.

Vey thought of the oyster rafts, and of Mossa walking the raft-line in the rain to account for a darkened lantern. The count was supposed to be a thing you kept. She had kept it. The mesh had kept a piece of it for her, the way it had once kept the nineteen names against the will of the wider count, and now that piece was loose in the Spill like a lantern torn from its line and set drifting.

"Can you stop it," she asked.

Cira shook her head. "Pellune already has it, and its exception copy is moving toward the Ledger-House. The mesh doesn't undo a forward. I could quarantine the frequency here, but the piece is already beyond Tarn. What I can do is warn you."

The word settled between them. Cira had not used it lightly.

"Warn me of what."

"Pellune received a count that doesn't match the Authorized Census, and someone there noticed. Tellers notice. Tellers answer to the Ledger-House. The Concordance doesn't need the whole shadow ledger to come looking. It needs one name that shouldn't be there, arriving where it wasn't sent."

Vey knew the shape of that danger. Kendt had come to Tarn once already, in the early part of the investigation, to correct the census by zeroing the phantom entries. He had left unsatisfied. If the Concordance learned that Tarn was not only holding the phantoms but exporting them, Kendt would not come as an auditor. He would come as a closure.

"So we prepare," Vey said. "Bren holds the full ledger. You hold the logs that show the mesh forwarded it on its own. I hold nothing they can read."

"Good," Cira said. "Because I'd guess Kendt is already moving."

She was not wrong.

The messenger from the Ledger-House reached Halversand four days later by the fast local relay, and Vey watched him come down the gangway from the window of the upper office where Pell kept the bell roster. He wore the grey coat of a Concordance registrar and carried a case that marked him as more than a teller. Pell saw him too, and his hand went still on the roster the way it did when he recognized a thing he had hoped not to.

"Auditor Kendt," Pell said, low, as if saying it quieter might keep him off the platform. "Back."

Vey had not expected the name to land like a stone. Kendt had corrected her books once and failed; his return meant the Ledger-House had decided correction was no longer enough.

Kendt climbed to the Counting House without ceremony and asked for the quarter's roll. Vey produced it. He read the bottom line the way a person reads a wound they intend to close, and his mouth flattened when he reached the nineteen phantom entries that the register still, stubbornly, carried.

"You were told to zero these," Kendt said. He did not look at her when he said it. He looked at the page, as if the page were the one who had disobeyed.

"I was told they were residue," Vey said. "They are not residue. They are a people the wider count dropped."

"The wider count is the Authorized Census. What it drops, it drops for reason. Your work is to file the count, not to argue the count upward."

"I file what Tarn holds. Tarn holds these."

Kendt set the case on the desk and opened it. Inside were seals and a thin book of standing orders bound in grey. "Then Tarn will hold them differently after today. The Ledger-House has reviewed the sync logs from this station. A transmission left Tarn that should not have left Tarn. A count that does not match the Authorized Census was placed on the mesh."

Vey kept her face still. He knew about the leak. Not its content, perhaps, but its existence, and existence was enough.

"The sync forwards everything," she said. "That is the mesh's nature. A fragment rode out with a routine upload."

"A fragment that named persons absent from the Authorized Census. The Concordance reads such fragments as broadcast, Corwin. A broadcast is not a sync error. It is an act."

"It was an accident of the relay."

Kendt looked at her then, and his look held no unkindness. It carried the shape of a man who had decided the argument before it started and meant to walk into the weather anyway. "Accident or act, the Ledger-House will treat it as a breach. I am here to close the breach. That means the phantom entries are zeroed today,

the sync is reviewed by Concordance tellers, and this station answers for what left it. You will cooperate, or you will be held while someone who will cooperates in your place."

The word held sat in the air. Vey had heard Pell use softer versions of it. Kendt used the hard one.

She thought of her brother, who had gone out on the north current ten years before and come back only on a casualty list the Counting House had closed without him. He had been counted out by a mistake no senior would undo, and the mistake had stayed, the way a lantern left dark stayed dark no matter who walked the raft-line after. Vey had learned then what a count could do to a person it decided to drop. Now the Concordance meant to drop nineteen households she had personally kept, and to drop her with them if she stood in the way. The parallel was not lost on her, and it stiffened her the way cold stiffens a rope.

Pell stepped forward from the door. "Auditor. The census-taker filed a clean local count. If the mesh forwarded a fragment, that is a relay matter, not a Counting House matter. Tarn's books are in order."

"Tarn's books carry nineteen entries no world can place," Kendt said. "That is not order, Aron. That is the leak, sitting in your own column. I will zero them, and I will note the station's failure to self-correct. The alternative is a Hold."

He pronounced Hold the way a door is pronounced shut.

Vey watched Pell's hand settle on the roster. He would cover for her if he could, the way he always had, but Kendt had the grey book and the seals and the weight of the Ledger-House behind him. The breach was real. The leak had done its work, and the Concordance had felt it.

By noon, two Concordance tellers had crossed from the registrar's lodging with tool cases and blank grey tags. They sealed the Counting House reader, took the last six sync rolls from their drawers, and posted a notice beside the bell. No census packet could leave Halversand without Kendt's countermark. Clerks who had spent their lives sending quarter totals now had to carry each page upstairs and explain every correction to a stranger.

Across the floor, the household chant faltered. A clerk called a name, waited for the answer, then looked toward the sealed reader as if the answer no longer counted until Kendt permitted it. Vey heard the hesitation spread from desk to desk. Authority did not need to erase a person in public. It needed to make every clerk afraid of an extra line.

One Teller emptied Vey's drawer onto the desk. He found spare nibs, tide tables, two unanswered household petitions, and the small book in which she had first copied the phantoms. Vey had removed those pages when Bren took the shadow ledger, but the torn edge remained. The Teller held the book toward the window and examined the stitching.

"Missing leaves," he said.

"Used for rough totals," Vey answered.

"Where are they?"

"Discarded."

His pencil paused above the inventory sheet. Vey did not know whether he believed her. Belief mattered less than what he could list, and he could list an altered notebook, a census conflict from Pellune, and a clerk who had refused correction before. Kendt's case had begun to fill without the shadow ledger ever entering the room.

At the upper desk, Pell argued that sealing the reader endangered Tarn's statutory count. Kendt granted one supervised filing hour at the close of each day. He placed a Concordance teller beside the machine to watch every sheet pass under the plate. The concession looked practical. Its effect left Kendt's hand on every name Halversand sent.

Before leaving for the Redoubt, the auditor called Vey to the window and spoke low enough that the floor could not hear. "If you surrender the source pages, this remains a procedural breach. If I have to find them, I will treat concealment as continuation. Do you understand the difference?"

"I understand your words," Vey said.

"Understand the consequence. A Hold begins with records. It does not always end there."

Kendt closed his grey book. He gave her until the next morning, though Vey had nothing she meant to surrender. When he descended the stairs, the two tellers stayed behind. One watched the reader. The other watched her.

That evening, after Kendt had taken the roll and the seals and gone to the Redoubt to review the sync, Cira found Vey on the lower gangway where the lantern-count had once been kept in memory if not in fact. The wind off the sea was cold, and Cira's coat was thin for it.

The gangway ran between two rafts that bucked against each other on the swell, and the lanterns that had once hung above the water were gone, replaced by the flat electric lights of the Counting House. Vey stood at the rail and watched the dark move under the planks. Somewhere in that dark the north current ran, the one that had taken her brother and given back only a closed list. She had not forgiven the count for that, and she did not mean to begin now, with Kendt zeroing the phantoms the way the sea had zeroed Brenn.

"I warned you he'd come back," Cira said. She handed Vey a slip printed from the side screen. "And I pulled this before Kendt locked the logs. Read it."

The slip carried a line from the sync record: confirmation that part of the shadow count had reached Pellune, been marked there, and forwarded onward for central review. Below it Cira had written the only thing that mattered.

"You need to warn Bren," Cira said. "If Kendt reviews the sync and then goes

looking for where the fragment came from, the archive follows next. Bren holds the full ledger. If Kendt finds it, the whole shadow count falls into Concordance hands, not just the piece that leaked."

Vey took the slip. The logic was clean and terrible. The leak had drawn Kendt. Kendt would follow the leak to its source. The source was Bren, and the archive, and the handwritten book that held every name the Authorized Census refused.

"I'll go to him tonight," Vey said. "Before Kendt finishes at the Redoubt."

"Take the fast line to tell him to move it," Cira said. "Don't walk. Kendt may have tellers watching the gangways by morning."

Vey sent the message by the fast same-world relay, the kind that carried in hours: move the ledger. Hide it where the seals cannot find it. Kendt knows a piece left the mesh.

Bren answered before the bell of the next count: it's moved. It's safe.

She let the slip go limp in her hand. The shadow census had leaked, and the leak had brought Kendt, and Kendt had brought the threat of the Hold. But the full count was safe, for now, and the fragment that had escaped had reached Pellune. Someone there had read it and learned that the Authorized Census did not name everyone who existed.

Cira leaned on the rail beside her. "We don't close this," she said. "He'll zero the phantoms in the roll. He'll quarantine the frequency. But the piece that left is already past him. That's the one thing he can't undo."

"The one thing," Vey agreed.

The sea moved under the platform without end, the way it always had, and the relay at the edge of the city hummed its slow hungry song into the dark. Somewhere beyond Tarn, a fragment of the shadow count sat in Pellune's records, carrying nineteen households that the Spill had tried to lose and Vey had tried to keep. Kendt could zero the column. He could seal the station. He could not call the drifting lantern back from the water.

Interlude II — A Census in Kess

The census board arrived between the first frost and the pear harvest, when everyone in Lint Parish had clean sleeves and no spare daylight. Cess found it propped against her gate before breakfast. A cord held three paper forms to the board, along with a pencil worn flat on one side so it would not roll into the ditch.

On Kess, every household took one street for its yearly census duty. The baker counted Oven Row. The schoolmaster walked the ridge farms. Cess had drawn Lower Lane for six years because she lived at its uphill end and did not mind walking down. Twelve houses stood between her gate and the mill pond. She knew who slept in every one of them, who had married, who had gone north for work, and which children would claim another year of age if she failed to ask their

mothers.

She brought the board inside and set porridge over the stove. A header on the first form gave the parish total from the previous year: 4,802. Beneath that sat the number certified to the district: 4,799. Three people had gone missing somewhere between the two figures. Cess noticed because subtraction gave her something to do while the oats thickened.

The district always differed by a few. Clerks removed duplicates, late deaths, and names whose marks had smudged in copying. Once, the parish had gained eleven people after certification because a whole farm lane had been placed in the wrong valley. No one called that an emergency. They amended the spring seed share and carried the eleven into the next count.

After eating, Cess wrapped the forms in oilcloth and started down Lower Lane. Frost whitened the wheel ruts. Smoke rose from chimney pots in straight blue lines, and the pear trees held their fruit under nets. Beyond the eastern fields, the relay mast stood on its stone hill. Its dishes faced different parts of the sky, though nothing visible ever crossed between them.

At the Tor household, two adults answered and a baby slept in a flour drawer lined with wool. Cess entered the child as Tor, Iven, resident from summer quarter. His mother pressed an inked thumb beside the line.

"Will he be on the wide count?" she asked.

"Not this year," Cess said. "The district books have to close first."

"How long after that?"

"However long it takes."

Both women knew this meant years. The parish would know Iven before he learned to stand. The district would know him by winter. The wider count might receive him when he could spell his own name, if the transmission survived its passage. His mother nodded, satisfied that the local line held him in the meantime.

Three doors farther down, old Maret had died during thaw. Her niece showed Cess the burial slip, and Cess ruled a careful red line through the name. The niece kept Maret's residence token in a bowl beside the door. It could buy nothing now, but throwing away a numbered thing felt careless.

At noon, Cess sat on the wall near the mill and checked her marks. One birth, one death, two temporary absences, no new households. The page matched the houses until she reached number eight.

Harl Nemet lived at number eight. He repaired orchard ladders in a lean-to behind his kitchen and paid Cess in kind whenever her rungs split. She had seen him that morning carrying ash to his compost trench. His name appeared on last year's household list in the pale ink used by the district copier.

A black stamp covered the line.

CORRECTED: REMOVE FROM ROLL.

No date followed. The space for cause remained empty, and no clerk had signed the margin. Cess tilted the paper toward the winter sun, thinking a second note might show beneath the stamp. She found none.

Harl answered after her third knock. Wood curls clung to his apron, and a strip of pearwood rested in his hand.

"Count day?" he asked.

"It came early."

"They say that every year."

Cess showed him the line. Harl read the stamp, rubbed one thumb over a dark tooth in his comb, and gave the form back.

"District did that," he said.

"It seems so."

"Do you need my mark?"

Her instructions said not to restore a corrected name without a clerk's authorization. They did not say whether she should collect proof from the person standing in front of her. Cess read the small print twice. Harl waited with his door open, letting kitchen heat escape around him.

"I can put you in the remarks," she said.

"That makes another form."

"It does."

"Leave it, then. My orchard fee cleared last month. If they need me, they know the house."

He sounded more inconvenienced by the cold doorway than by the stamp. Cess understood. Corrections came down from district in packets, sometimes two seasons after the matter they corrected. His name might have been copied twice elsewhere. A cousin with the same first mark might have died. The clerk might already be preparing a replacement line that would arrive after this board went back.

Still, she asked, "You haven't registered in North Parish?"

"I haven't crossed the pond since planting."

"And no change to the household?"

"Same roof. Same bed. Same taxes." Harl lifted the pearwood strip. "Different ladder."

Cess laughed because he expected it. She checked the box beside number eight to show that she had visited, then left the stamped line alone. Before closing the board, she wrote OCCUPIED in the property column. A house could remain occupied without naming who occupied it. District forms often made room for one fact and not another.

The rest of Lower Lane took less than an hour. At the mill house, twins argued over which one should press the family seal. Cess let them each hold one side. The orchard keeper had hired three harvest workers from the dry basin, all temporary and therefore counted on a yellow supplement. At the last cottage, no one answered, but warm milk stood in a pan by the window. Cess marked RETURN VISIT and began the climb home.

Clouds had gathered above the relay hill. Its mast gave off a low rasp when the wind came from the east, a sound people in Lint Parish called the far weather. Children put cups against fence posts and pretended to hear other worlds speaking through the wire. Adults knew the actual messages went to the district receiving room and arrived as strips with missing letters. Most concerned crop disease, census totals, machine diagrams, or disputes settled before anyone on Kess learned they had begun.

Cess had once read a notice from another world in the parish hall. It warned against a beetle that ate the roots of grain. Eleven years separated the notice's sending date from its posting. Kess had no such beetle. The council filed the warning anyway, in case the pest proved faster than the message.

By midafternoon, Cess delivered her board to the parish office above the cooperage. Clerk Doven sat behind three stacks of forms, warming his fingers around a cup. He checked Cess's sums and compared each household seal with a card index.

"Number eight has a district correction," she said.

Doven glanced at the stamp. "Then you've handled it."

"He still lives there."

"Many corrections concern where a person belongs, not whether they breathe." He turned the page. "You marked the property occupied. Good."

"Should there be a cause?"

"If district sent one, it will be in the packet after this."

Cess considered filling a remarks form after all. The blank copies lay in a tray within reach. Each required two witnesses, a residence token, and a district fee. Harl had not asked her to begin one. Doven had already moved to the twins' shared seal.

"Your temporary workers need departure dates," he said.

She supplied them from memory. Together they corrected a reversed birth digit and found the missing seal from number four stuck to the oilcloth. Doven totaled Lower Lane at twenty-seven residents, one fewer than last year. The loss came from Maret, not Harl, because a corrected line no longer entered the starting total.

Outside, the cooper struck hoops onto a barrel. Each blow traveled through the floorboards into Cess's shoes. Doven sanded the wet total, folded the forms, and tied them into the parish packet. In spring, the district would certify what Lint

Parish had sent. Some later season, the relay would carry a thinner number toward places no one in the room would visit.

Cess signed the duty register and received a blue token worth half a day's parish tax. She used part of it downstairs for a new bucket handle. On her way home she stopped at number eight, where Harl had left a repaired ladder against her gatepost. The new pearwood rung showed pale against the older wood.

She tested it with one foot, found it firm, and carried the ladder up the hill before the frost returned.

Chapter 13 — The Hold

The knock came at the third hour, when the Counting House should have been empty and the bell had long since stopped ruling the floor. Vey looked up from the small book and saw two men in Concordance grey fill the door of her office. One carried the seal of an auditor's escort, a round lead stamp on a cord, the kind that meant a count was being taken under protest. The other kept his hand on the shutter as if he expected the sea to try to take it back through the gap.

"Corwin," the first said. "You'll come with us."

She closed the small book and set it in the center of the desk, where the lantern light fell across the cover. The shadow ledger was inside it, the count of the erased she had kept since the night she decided the register would not clean them away. "On whose order."

"Auditor Kendt's. The Counting House on Tarn has been running an unapproved tally. You'll answer for it at the Redoubt."

Kendt. She had expected his return after the leak, but not the knock in the dark, not the grey uniforms, not the way the second man's weight shifted to block the door. The sea outside moved without end, and the platform moved with it, a slow breathing of planks and rope, but the room had gone still. She stood. The small book stayed where she had placed it.

"My books are in order," she said.

"Your books are not the books in question." The escort stepped aside, and the door behind him showed Bren standing in the outer office with a stack of archive crates, frozen mid-step. He had come to collect the month's sealed counts for the vault. He had not expected an audience.

Bren read the room the way an archivist reads a shelf: everything in its place, and one thing out of it. His eyes went to the small book on Vey's desk, then to the grey uniforms, then back to her face. He did not speak. He set the top crate down with a careful thud that sounded like a period at the end of a sentence.

"Archivist," the escort said. "You'll stay until we've finished."

"I was leaving," Bren said. His tone was flat, the way he talked about water

damage to a ledger. "The vault's closed for the count review. I'll be back at the bell."

"You'll stay."

Bren stayed. Vey saw his hand drift toward the crate nearest her desk, the one he had just set down, and she understood the movement before it finished. The small book was still on the desk. Bren was between her and the uniforms, and the crate gave him a reason to lean.

"Corwin." The escort again. "The book."

Vey looked at the small book. She had carried it through two years of quiet counting, through the night she first copied the nineteen names, through the quarter the phantoms had grown a habit. She had written in it that the count kept them when nothing else would. She did not want to hand it over.

"The book is mine," she said. "Personal marks. Nothing to do with the census floor."

"Everything in this office is the census floor." The escort reached past her for it.

Bren moved the crate. It was a small thing, a shift of weight, a lean that put his shoulder between the escort's arm and the desk. The small book slid under the lid as the crate came down. Bren's hand rested on the wood as if he had meant to close it all along.

"Careful," Bren said. "That crate's sealed for the vault. Drop it and the binding cracks, and I'll have to log the damage against your office."

The escort's hand closed on air. He looked from the closed crate to Bren's calm face and found no argument he could win without opening a sealed archive, which the Concordance did not do on a census-taker's say-so. He turned back to Vey.

"Then you'll come without it."

The escort took her arm and they went down the stair to the water. The platform rocked under her feet the way it always did, but tonight the rock felt like a hand letting go. Markets floated between the rafts selling lamp-oil and dried fish, and the clerks of the lower offices had long gone home, leaving the gangways to the tide. Behind her the Counting House shrank into the dark with Bren still inside it, and the small book with it. She counted that as one thing kept.

The launch took her across the open water to Tarn Redoubt. The relay building rose at the edge of the platform, low and iron, humming in her teeth the way it always had when she came to file a count upward. Kendt was waiting in the interview room, a grey office with a single window and the sea beyond it. He had aged since the last visit, or perhaps only settled deeper into the work of correction, the way a person settles into a chair that fits the shape of a hard decision.

"Sit," Kendt said. He did not offer it as a courtesy. "You've been keeping a second count, Corwin. A shadow tally of entries the Authorized Census does not carry. We found the leak. A fragment of your count reached Osel."

Vey sat. She had known the leak would be traced; Cira had warned her the moment the fragment went wide. What she had not known was how fast Kendt would move, or how quietly he would move, with grey uniforms at the door instead of a summons on the register. The Spill was slow, but the Concordance on Tarn was not.

"The Spill count is degraded," she said. "What reaches Osel is half-eaten. You can't read a people in a fragment."

"We read enough. A name that holds its place across a corrupted transmission is not noise. You put it there." Kendt set a single sheet on the table. It carried three marks she recognized: the same impossible ward, the same household strings, the tail of the list she had copied into the small book. "Where is the rest of it."

"I keep my own notes. A census-taker reads margins. That's the work."

"Your work is the Authorized Census. The count you kept is a crime against the peace of the Spill. You'll surrender it, and you'll sign the correction that zeros those entries on Tarn's roll."

"I won't sign a count that drops the living."

Kendt leaned back. "Then you'll be held until you do. The Redoubt has a cell. Auditor's privilege, when an unapproved tally threatens the census. You'll stay until you understand the cost of your silence."

The word landed. Held. She would be held, here at the edge of the sea, in the hum of the relay that had tried to lose the people she counted. She thought of her brother, counted out by a mistake no senior would undo, and the mistake had stayed. She had spent her life refusing to be the hand that dropped a name. Now the Concordance meant to make her the hand that signed the drop, or hold her until the count moved on without her.

"I have work at the Counting House," she said.

"Your work is finished until I say otherwise."

They took her to the cell. It was small and clean, with a narrow bunk and a single bolt light, and a window too high to show more than a strip of night sky over the water. The door was iron and did not answer the sea the way the platforms did. Vey sat on the bunk and listened to the relay hum through the wall. Somewhere in that hum a frequency was quiet that should have been singing, and the small book was safe under a crate in Halversand. She counted that as two things kept, and the count of the erased as a third.

She thought of the oyster rafts where she had learned to count, and the lantern that had stayed dark one autumn night, and Mossa taking the skiff down the line in the rain to add a name to the count. A missing lantern meant a walk down the raft-line, not a stroke of ink. The Concordance had stopped walking. It had learned to leave the lantern dark and call the raft empty. Vey had chosen the Counting House over the sea because the count was a raft that never sank. Now the count itself had sprung a leak, and the leak was full of names, and she was sitting in the

place the Concordance kept the people who bailed.

Morning came without a bell. A tray came through a slot, and after it came Pell.

He stood in the doorway of the cell with his own weariness and a permission slip from Kendt that let him enter but not leave with her. He looked older than the last time she had seen him, the way a man looks after a night spent deciding which warning to honor. The grey corridor behind him carried the smell of relay oil and the cold that came off the sea at the edge of the platform.

"Corwin," he said. It was the same word he had used the first time he found her past the bell. "You're in a hold."

"I noticed."

"I told you some counts are kept by pretending. You didn't listen. Now Kendt's got the fragment and he's got you, and the only thing between the shadow ledger and his desk is an archivist with a sealed crate."

"Bren has it." Vey said it plainly, the way she would state a figure. "He closed it in the vault crate before they could take my book. Kendt searched me. He found nothing."

Pell's face did the small, private thing it did when it recognized a thing it hoped not to. "Bren's a good man. He'll hold the line until someone opens that crate, and Concordance doesn't open sealed archives without cause. You bought time. Not safety."

"I'll take time."

Pell sat on the bench across from her. The cell was too small for the distance he usually kept, and he did not like being close to the consequence of his own warnings. "Kendt means to break you. He'll keep you here past the next count, past the one after, until the register cleans itself of the phantoms and your signature zeros them. He's done it on three worlds. The hold is how."

"You sound like you've seen it."

"I've covered for the kind of clerk who ends up in a room like this. Most of them sign. The ones who don't, they stay until the count moves on without them, and then they're released to a floor that has already forgotten what they were counting." Pell looked at his hands. "I'm not letting that be you."

"You don't run the Redoubt, Pell."

"No. But I run the counting floor, and Kendt needs Tarn's books to close before he can leave, and the books won't close while I refuse to certify them. I went to him this morning. I told him a held census-taker is a census-taker who can't be charged without a supervisor's signed finding, and I am his supervisor, and I have not found her wanting. He doesn't get to hold you open-ended on my floor without my name on the finding, and I won't sign it."

Vey watched him. "You intervened."

"I limited it. Kendt wanted you held open-ended, no term, no review, the way he

keeps clerks on Osel and Pellune until the silence takes. I made him set a bound. Three days. He certifies the floor himself in the meantime, and if the books close clean he releases you to sign the correction or not. Three days, Corwin. That's all I could pry out of him without admitting what we both know is in Bren's crate, and without telling him the rest of your count is already on the water."

Three days. The relay hum filled the silence between them. Vey thought of the years a message took to cross the Spill, and how three days was a breath beside that, and how a breath was sometimes the only margin a count left you. The phantoms had returned every quarter for two years without drifting. Three days was shorter than a single sync.

"Thank you," she said.

Pell stood. He did not like thanks; it implied a debt the giver had not offered. "Don't thank me yet. Three days is long enough for Kendt to find a cause to open Bren's crate, and short enough that you'll be signing or starving on the same hour. Use it. Get word to Bren that the crate stays sealed, and get word to Cira that the fragment reaching Osel means the broadcast can't wait for your hand."

"You'll carry it."

"I'll carry it because I put you in this room by telling you to run the clean two years ago, and I was wrong to. I knew what the phantoms were, Corwin. I told you they were residue because residue is what a supervisor is supposed to see. I was a coward about it." He went to the door, then stopped. "The shadow ledger, Bren has the only copy?"

"The only paper copy. The rest is in my head and in the marks I've sent outward. If Kendt zeros Tarn's roll, the count still exists on other worlds. The leak saw to that."

Pell nodded, the small acknowledgment of a man who had finally walked down the stair he had decided not to walk. "Then you're not the only copy. Good. Hold the line, Corwin. Three days."

He left her with the bolt light and the strip of sky and the hum of the relay that had tried to lose a people and had instead carried their names across a fragment to Osel. Vey lay back on the bunk and counted what she had: Bren with the book, Pell with the bound, Cira with the frequency, and the erased themselves, still in the count because a leak had reached a world that would not forget them.

She thought of her brother again, the strong rower who had laughed at her for loving the ledgers, and the ledgers had failed him, and she had not forgiven the count for that. She would not let a count fail a stranger the way it had failed him. The cell door was iron and the sea was outside it, but the sea was still out there, pulling at the platform, carrying the quiet frequency and the loud one both.

The second day passed without a visit. A tray came at the third hour and again at the ninth, and the bolt light held steady, and the relay hum never stopped. Vey used the time the way she had always used a quiet count: she went over the tally

in her head, name by name, ward by ward, the nineteen and the households beyond them, the people the Spill had tried to drown and the count had kept. She had no stylus and no paper, so she counted them against the rhythm of the relay, the way Mossa had counted lanterns down the raft-line.

On the third morning Pell returned with the permission slip and a sealed note from Bren. She broke the seal and read it. The crate was logged into the vault under his name, the count review complete, nothing opened. Kendt had asked after her book; Bren had told him a census-taker's personal marks were not archive property, and the auditor had no standing to seize them. The note ended the way Bren ended everything, with a fact and no feeling: the ledger is safe.

Pell read her face. "He held."

"He held." Vey folded the note. "Kendt's bound holds too?"

"Your three days are up at the bell. He'll release you because I certified the floor and he has no finding to hold you on. You'll walk out of here with the same name you walked in with, and the shadow ledger still under Bren's crate." Pell paused. "What you do next is yours. The fragment's on Osel. Cira's ready at the frequency. The broadcast doesn't need your hand, Corwin. It needs your count, and the count is already loose in the Spill."

Vey stood. The cell was small and the door was iron, but it opened, and Pell was right, the count was already loose. She had been held to keep her from finishing the work, and the holding had not stopped the work. It had only shown her how many hands the work now had.

Pell walked ahead of her down the Redoubt's low iron halls, past the relay room where Cira kept her watch, and onto the launch that carried her back across the open water to Halversand. The platform rocked under her feet the way it always did, and this time the rock felt like a hand that had never let go. Behind her the Redoubt shrank into the grey morning with Pell still inside it, and the frequency still quiet, and the small book still safe. She counted that as everything kept.

The wind off the sea reached her on the open deck, and she breathed it the way she had not been able to in the cell. Three days held, and the count had not stopped. The phantoms would return next quarter as regular as the tide schedule that pulled at the platform beneath the city, and Bren would keep the ledger, and Cira would open the frequency when the moment came, and Vey would be at her desk with the names still in the roll.

At the Counting House the bell would ring the count in at the second hour, the way it always had. Vey meant to be at her desk when it did, with the phantoms still in the roll and the shadow ledger still in Bren's crate, and the true count still moving outward across a Spill that had tried to lose it and could not. The hold had shown her the limit of what the Concordance could keep: it could hold a census-taker, but it could not hold a count that had already reached Osel.

Chapter 14 — Cira's Choice

Kendt's audit tags remained on three consoles after Vey left the Redoubt. Each strip of grey paper crossed a latch and carried the auditor's seal at both ends. Cira could use the local message board, the maintenance desk, and the scrap rig in the back corner. She could not touch either long-range tuning head without breaking paper before she broke any rule.

She started with the tags because tags had edges. Orders did not. An order could widen while a person slept, but a paper strip either held or tore. Cira wrote each seal number in the shift log, checked it against Kendt's inventory, and signed beneath the line that said the station had accepted Concordance custody of its forwarding equipment.

Her signature looked steady. That annoyed her.

Across the room, the senior Teller watched her cap the ink. He had spent the audit answering Kendt in the patient language of maintenance: yes, the raw spool overwrote at sync; no, the scrap rig did not feed the authorized register; yes, every retrieval left a station mark. He had not lied. He had also not looked at Cira when Kendt asked who had last opened the quarantine index.

"You missed the date," he said now.

Cira checked the line. The date stood correct.

"On the inventory," he added. "Second tuning head. He wrote next cycle. It should say this cycle."

She found the error and crossed it with one stroke. "Kendt's clerk wrote it."

"We accepted it. Now it belongs to us."

That rule had built her whole apprenticeship. A Teller received what arrived, marked its damage, and forwarded what could still be carried. Once a station accepted a packet, the station owned its handling. Blaming the previous hop did not restore a lost line.

Cira corrected the date and initialed it. The senior took the inventory without thanks. He stopped at the door, one hand on the frame.

"Corwin went back to Halversand," he said. "The Hold expired at the morning bell."

"I know how long three days are."

"Then count them before you do anything young."

He left for the outer platform. Cira listened to his boots cross the wet boards until the relay hum covered them. He had offered a warning without asking what she meant to do. On Tarn, that often served as the nearest form of protection an older worker knew.

The sealed tuning heads stood quiet under their grey tags. Behind them, incoming packets struck the receiving rack in a continuous low wash. Tarn

weather, platform notices, household totals, and long-range fragments all entered through the same metal throat. The station sorted them after arrival. Nothing in the antenna knew which people held standing.

Cira pulled Kendt's inventory onto the maintenance desk and compared it with her own. His clerks had listed both tuning heads, the authorized register, every clean spool, and six cabinets of cable parts. They had listed the scrap rig as obsolete test equipment. They had not opened its false floor.

Inside that shallow space lay the quarantine order she had printed for Vey, the hand comparison that proved raw lines had been removed, and a coil of patch cable assembled from parts no inventory missed. Three pieces of evidence, one possible path. Kendt had stood a pace from them and seen an old cabinet.

Relief should have followed. Instead Cira felt the same unease she got from a reading that landed too neatly on expected tolerance. If Kendt had found the papers, her decision would have been made by seizure. With the proof still hidden, she had to make it herself.

She woke the scrap rig. Its drum turned once, then settled into the uneven rhythm of worn bearings. The machine had no authority to transmit. It could read the raw receiving rack, compare packets, and print whatever the main console planned to erase. During Vey's first visit, Cira had bridged it to the tuning head and listened around the quarantine. Listening had required one cable and a warm coil. Sending would require control of the head, a route mark the next relay accepted, and enough duration to move more than a fragment.

Those requirements could be measured. Loyalty could not.

At her first certification, Cira had signed the Teller's undertaking in a paper book older than she was. She had promised to keep Tarn connected, preserve the forwarding order, and obey valid instructions carried under the Ledger-House seal. Nobody had asked her to trust the people who wrote those instructions. Trust had been built into the procedure. A valid seal made obedience automatic, which let forty worlds exchange a message without arguing at every hop.

The system worked often enough to deserve loyalty. When a storm tore the western fish platforms loose, the Redoubt had carried their position along Tarn's local band before the rescue boats launched. When a fever reached two raft-cities, medical counts had crossed the same-world line in minutes. Long-range notices arrived damaged and old, but they arrived. A marriage announcement from Callow could take six years and lose half its names, yet a Teller on Tarn would still print the surviving half and place it in the public tray.

Cira did not want to become someone who treated every seal as a lie because one standing order carried a crime. A relay could not function if each technician forwarded only the messages she agreed with. That path did not lead to an open mesh. It led to forty private meshes and no shared count.

Yet the quarantine order did more than express disagreement. It instructed

stations to call a received signal degradation, then clear it at sync. It made Tellers falsify the condition of their own equipment. The band arrived. The log said it had not. Obedience required Cira to enter a false measurement every day.

She set a blank cable note beside the scrap rig and wrote two headings: KEEP THE ORDER and OPEN THE BAND.

Under the first, she listed what remained intact. Her certification. Her post. The Redoubt's trust. The station's clean standing with the Ledger-House. No risk that an uncontrolled transmission would damage other traffic or make Tarn's relay a source the next hops rejected.

Under the second, she wrote only facts. The signal exists. The people transmitting are alive. The Authorized Census removes them by instruction. Vey's count can identify part of what the band carries. A received packet must be logged as received.

The second list looked shorter. It also described the equipment in front of her.

Cira folded the paper once, hiding both headings, when the local board chimed. A same-world message had entered from Halversand. The route took less than an hour on a clear day because it crossed water and cable, not the years between worlds. Kendt had left the board unsealed so station crews could receive maintenance calls.

She checked the sender mark before opening it. Vey Corwin, Counting House.

The message held four lines.

I am out. Bren has the ledger. Pell bought three days and used them. Kendt can hold a person faster than the Static can carry a warning. Can the frequency be made to carry outward from Tarn?

Cira read it once for content and again for what it did not ask. Vey had not written **will you**. She had asked whether the machinery allowed it. That gave Cira room to answer as a Teller.

She typed: Possible. Not with the heads sealed.

Her finger rested above the send key. The reply would reach Halversand before the next bell. Kendt could inspect local traffic without waiting years for a return. A message about a sealed head, sent to the woman he had held for keeping an unauthorized census, required little interpretation.

Cira cleared the line.

A safe answer took its place: Station remains under audit. Do not contact me here.

That message would protect her post and tell Vey nothing she did not know. It would also leave the band quiet. Cira looked at the folded cable note, then at the grey tags. Procedures often turned choices into passive verbs. A frequency **was held**. A packet **was cleared**. A person **was counted out**. The grammar removed the hand, but the hand still had ink on it.

She cleared the safe answer too.

Before writing again, Cira opened the local route table. Kendt's review channel copied official traffic to the audit spool. Maintenance traffic passed through a shorter queue and remained on Tarn unless a fault report carried a Ledger-House destination. The distinction existed so a broken pump in Halversand did not become six-year news on Callow. Cira could send Vey a fast message through that queue if she wrapped it as a reader fault. The station copy would persist until the weekly purge.

Using the queue to conceal a conversation violated local message protocol. It did not alter a long-range packet, forge a count, or touch the quarantine. Cira noticed herself arranging the offenses by size. She stopped. The question did not concern how cleanly she could hide.

She had to choose whether the relay served the seals or what had reached its antenna.

Cira unfolded the note and drew a line through KEEP THE ORDER. She did not tear it out or qualify it. Loss belonged in the record too.

Then she opened a maintenance ticket to the Counting House reader, addressed it to Vey's desk, and typed: Yes. I will help. The breach needs planning before either of us touches a head. Reply on this ticket. No names from the shadow ledger.

She sent it.

The local board clicked, accepted the packet, and marked an expected delivery inside the hour. Nothing in the room changed. Kendt's tags held. The authorized register continued its clean scroll. Cira's post remained hers for at least the length of one hidden message.

Decision felt less dramatic than anticipation. It reduced the number of open paths.

She turned to the technical work.

First came duration. The listen bridge had held the quarantined band open for eleven minutes before the tuning head warmed beyond tolerance. Eleven minutes could carry a list if the signal ran clean. Nothing crossing the Static ran clean. A true outward transmission needed repetition, checksums, and enough overlap that downstream stations could reconstruct missing pieces. Cira wrote a minimum window of forty minutes, then circled it because the estimate had no test behind it.

Second came authority. Every outbound packet received Tarn's station mark. A quarantined designation triggered the local discard before the mark attached. Cira could bypass the discard with her patch cable, but the next relay would see the same designation and drop the packet under its own copy of the standing order. Breaking one station did not break the chain unless Tarn recoded the band as ordinary census traffic or attached an instruction downstream consoles ranked above quarantine.

Vey's leaked fragment had survived because it rode in the margin of an authorized census packet. That accident supplied a method. The breach did not need to persuade every relay to disobey. It needed to place the true count inside traffic every relay had already agreed to carry.

Cira wrote: carrier packet, authorized census band. Payload repeated in recoverable blocks. Quarantined source named in header only after acceptance.

She crossed out the last phrase. If the source appeared after acceptance, downstream clean routines could still remove it. Better to divide the payload into ordinary count fields, each valid enough to pass the first sort, then include a reconstruction key that revealed their relation after the packet had entered the forwarded log. That resembled smuggling, not engineering, but the relay cared about structure more than intent.

A response chimed on the maintenance ticket.

Vey had written: Understood. What do you need from the count?

Cira checked the route copy. The ticket showed a reader calibration fault and two technical replies. No automatic copy had gone to the audit channel.

She answered with a list.

Total households. Individual marks where verified. Confidence for damaged names. Source fragment for each entry. Keep the uncertain entries uncertain. I need fixed block lengths and a key that survives loss. Do not send the ledger on this line.

Vey's next reply came twenty-seven minutes later. Across the Static, the same exchange would have consumed years. Tarn's local cables gave them an answer before the ink dried.

I can prepare verified and provisional columns. Nineteen Tarn bleed-through households are strong. The wider count is larger and uneven. How many copies per block?

Cira appreciated the question because it had a number inside it. The Redoubt's archive held degradation records for every long-range hop Tarn had received. She could sample recent census packets, measure average block loss, and calculate repetition from evidence rather than hope. That task remained within her authorized work. Kendt's own review had left the records sorted by route.

She wrote: I will calculate. Start with three copies, separated across the packet. No repeated full sentences. Rebuild by numbered fields. Keep human and Anver entries under the same census schema.

The name sat in the local ticket without ceremony. Cira had first seen it as a broken pattern, then heard it rendered from the band Vey asked her to open. Writing it into a technical instruction made it part of ordinary work, which felt correct.

While Vey prepared the columns, Cira measured loss. She selected twelve

authorized packets that had crossed between three and seven hops, compared their original route checksums where those survived, and marked every missing span. Damage clustered rather than scattering evenly. Three adjacent copies could vanish in one bad hop. Copies separated by header, middle, and close had a better chance.

Her first calculation produced five repetitions for verified entries and seven for provisional source keys. That volume would not fit a routine Tarn quarter count. It might fit across several scheduled packets, but splitting the message raised the chance Kendt would stop the sequence after the first anomaly.

A single larger carrier would draw attention at launch. Several smaller carriers would draw attention later and fail incomplete. Cira wrote both risks in the margin. This part belonged with Vey because the count determined which loss did least harm. She sent another local note: Capacity conflict. One loud packet or several incomplete ones. We decide after I test the block size. Do not choose timing yet.

Vey answered: Agreed. No send until both of us can read the complete plan.

The phrasing mattered. Vey had spent years keeping a count no one authorized, yet she did not ask Cira to improvise with the relay. She wanted a plan they could inspect together. That separated the work from the standing order it opposed. The Ledger-House had hidden its consequence inside routine. Cira and Vey would write theirs down.

By the eighth hour, Cira had mapped the rest of the access problem. Kendt's seal tags blocked the front latches, not the rear service panel. Opening that panel logged a heat fault but did not tear paper. The patch bridge could take control of the secondary head during a scheduled coil test. A false heat fault would buy fourteen minutes before the main console demanded inspection. A real maintenance cycle at low tide gave thirty-six. She needed at least forty by her first estimate.

The missing four minutes bothered her more than the risk of dismissal because four minutes could be solved.

She inspected the cooling loop without opening it. Tarn's seawater ran through a jacket around both tuning coils, carrying heat down a pipe beneath the platform. During tests, the secondary head used half flow so the primary retained priority. Reversing the valve allocation would cool the secondary longer, but an imbalance would appear on the maintenance graph.

Cira drew the valve path on paper. If she started during the weekly pump flush, flow readings already varied beyond normal tolerance. The secondary head might remain usable for fifty-two minutes. The pump flush occurred at the ninth hour two days from now. Kendt's audit schedule, left carelessly in the inventory folder, placed him at the Counting House then.

She did not write that as the chosen moment. Chaptered plans failed when a convenient fact became a conclusion too early. She wrote it as a candidate window

and listed what could invalidate it: sea temperature, senior shift assignment, an extended audit seal, a change in census upload time, or Vey's count exceeding carrier capacity.

The fast line chimed again.

Vey's message read: Verified column ready by tomorrow. Provisional needs Bren's paper. I can meet after the close bell, or continue here if meeting exposes you.

Cira considered Kendt's grey clerks on the Halversand gangways and the senior Teller's warning at the door. A meeting created witnesses. The local maintenance queue created a log she controlled but could not unwrite. Neither path offered safety. One offered speed.

She replied: Continue here for measurements. Meet only when we have decisions the line cannot carry. Send column dimensions, not entries. I have a candidate maintenance window, not a moment. I need your next authorized upload schedule.

After sending, Cira printed the ticket. Digital copies could be cleaned. Paper required a hand. She cut away the false maintenance header, folded the technical exchange into the compartment under the scrap rig, and left the original folded choice note beside it.

The main console sounded the ninth hour. Outside, seawater entered the cooling pipes with a low knock as the pumps changed pressure. Cira rested two fingers on the secondary line and counted the interval between pulses. Fifty-one seconds at half flow. She adjusted her estimate and wrote the result on the breach diagram.

One grey tag lifted at a corner in the damp air, still sealed, no longer flat against the latch. Beneath it, the rear service path waited unmarked. On the local board, Vey's next reply moved through Tarn's cables toward the Redoubt, fast enough to arrive before Cira finished drawing the second valve.

Chapter 15 — The Network Grows

The first reply waited in a return tray at Tarn Redoubt, three years older than the morning Vey held it. Its paper had curled from the printer's heat. Whole runs of letters showed as black squares, and the route line ended after two surviving marks. Cira had circled one sentence in pencil before bringing the strip to the side room.

Vey read the sentence without touching the paper.

QUERY NAMES RECOGNI[LOST] OUR QUARTER ALSO.

Beyond the wall, the relay carried its tooth-felt hum through the iron floor. The sound had followed Vey through the Hold, steady behind Kendt's questions and the shut door of the cell. She had listened then for proof that the count continued without her. Now the proof lay in a tray meant for messages too damaged to file.

"When did this arrive?" she asked.

"At the sixth hour yesterday." Cira shut the side-room door and turned its latch. "The route sorter marked it unrecoverable. Kendt's people inspect exceptions, not waste. I changed nothing. I moved the wastebasket."

Three grey fibers clung to the edge of the strip where someone had torn it from a longer sheet. Vey saw the pressure of missing type in the paper, shallow dents left by letters whose ink ribbon had failed. A census-taker learned to read absence as carefully as marks. She tilted the strip toward the bolt light.

"This answers the wide query I filed when the nineteen first appeared," she said. "Cira told me the return might take until SY 314."

"I told you it would come back missing teeth. This one lost most of its jaw." Cira set two more strips beside it. "It didn't come alone. The old query kept moving after you stopped waiting for it. Different branches caught it, copied what survived, and sent answers toward Tarn. These reached the same forwarding beacon within a month of each other. The final hop bundled them."

Vey counted six distinct route impressions across the scraps. Years separated the sending dates. No hand had coordinated them, and no sender could know whether Tarn still listened. They had answered because a question about unplaced persons reached their desks and because each desk held something that made the question familiar.

One line carried a personal mark after the damage: YULA, CENSUS TABLE [LOST]. Below it, four letters survived from a world code, too little to settle whether the message had started on Callow or passed through it. Vey ran a finger above the name without covering it.

"Yula," she said.

"You know her?"

"No."

That made the name more useful, not less. Pell and Bren had chosen to help after years beside Vey. Cira had watched the relay erase what she knew it received. This woman had no knowledge of Vey beyond a ruined query crossing the Static. She had still answered.

Cira pulled a hand lens from her pocket. "The side screen caught the raw image before the cleaning routine compressed it. We can try to recover the pressure marks. Not here. Kendt left one Teller on the main log, and he counts doors whenever I disappear."

"Where?"

"Old tuning bench. He thinks the receiver there is dead. It is. The lamp isn't."

They carried the return tray through the relay room one strip at a time, each tucked beneath a routine maintenance sheet. Kendt's Teller sat at the main console with his grey tag fixed to the reader housing. He looked at Vey long

enough to remind her that release from the Hold did not mean freedom from notice. She gave him nothing to list except a census-taker walking beside a Teller.

At the rear of the Redoubt, Cira opened a narrow cabinet whose dials had been removed years before. A fold-down bench filled the lower half. Its glass plate still held a working lamp, yellow and weak, fed from a local line the main log did not measure. Cira laid Yula's message face down on the glass. The dents rose into shadow.

For the rest of the morning, Vey read what the ink had failed to keep.

Recovered letters went first onto a blank household form. Vey placed each sure character in black and each inferred one in pencil. Cira adjusted the lamp across the paper at four angles, making one stroke appear while another sank back into the fibers. They worked as Vey had worked with the Anver bleed-through, not filling what they wanted to see, but waiting for two damaged edges to agree.

Yula had received only part of the original query. The nineteen names were gone. The impossible Ward Nine survived, along with Vey's request for source and placement. Yula's answer opened with the circled sentence and continued in broken lines.

OUR QUARTER ALSO CARRIES PERSONS WITH NO AUTHORIZED PLACEMENT.

LOCAL CLEAN REMOVES [LOST] RETURN RESTORES.

I HAVE KEPT [TWO DIGITS LOST] HOUSEHOLDS ON PAPER.

"She's keeping a shadow count," Vey said.

Cira bent closer to the next line. "Not your shadow count. Hers."

The distinction mattered. Vey had thought of the illicit ledger as a Tarn book, even after its fragment escaped toward Pellune and Osel. Tarn's sync had given her the first nineteen. Tarn's archive sheltered the pages. The founding clause named waters beneath human platforms, and her mind returned by habit to the water below Halversand. Yula had answered from a desk Vey would never see, under weather Vey could not imagine from the route scars. She had found absent persons through her own quarter, kept them by her own rule, and sent word years before Vey knew she existed.

A later block carried Yula's method. Two sources before a name entered the paper count. One source could come from a returned sync, the other from an old local roll or a neighboring world's exception. Uncertain letters stayed open. Every copied household retained its route and date. Vey recognized the discipline because Bren had made her articulate the same one in Tarn's archive. A census could survive attack only when it showed where every line came from.

"How many?" Cira asked.

"The digits are gone. At least ten, no more than ninety-nine, if the form held two places. But she says households, not persons."

"Can the old pressure give us either digit?"

Vey turned the strip, then held it flat again. A crescent dent might have belonged to a three or an eight. The second place carried no usable stroke. "No. We record the range and leave the number open."

Cira gave a short nod. She trusted a gap honestly marked more than a confident repair. That shared habit had brought them farther than either one had planned.

Near the bottom, Yula's answer changed from report to instruction.

IF YOUR UNPLACED RETURN, DO NOT CLEAN THEM.

COPY THIS QUERY INTO YOUR NEXT WIDE MARGIN.

ASK WHO ELSE KEEPS THE ABSENT.

The final line had taken the worst damage. Cira found three impressions, Vey found two more, and together they recovered a phrase with enough missing between its halves to make certainty impossible.

A COUNT [LOST] ONE WORLD CAN BE CLOSED BY ONE HAND.

Vey did not complete the sentence. Yula's surviving words carried the procedure without help. A ledger stored in one archive could be seized. A frequency held at one Redoubt could be quarantined. A census-taker working alone could be detained for three days or three years. Copies on several worlds changed the arithmetic of suppression, even when every copy remained partial.

"She told others," Vey said.

"Years ago." Cira pointed to the sending date. "This left her table before your leak reached Pellune. Maybe before you started the second ledger."

"Then the query did more work than I did."

"It asked the right people. The Static took care of making the question hard to kill."

Hard to kill did not mean safe. Degradation could erase a household as thoroughly as an order. Delay could deliver a warning after a search had ended. Yet the mesh's faults also scattered copies beyond the reach of any local seal. The Concordance curated frequencies and central rolls. It could not call back every margin already forwarded through forty worlds.

Vey set Yula's strip aside and drew the second reply onto the light.

The other answers arrived in worse condition. One kept an Osel station seal and lost the sender's name. Another carried PELLUNE NORTH TABLE, the same station that had questioned the leaked fragment, though its date showed it had seen Vey's old query first. A third preserved neither origin nor destination. Its paper held a dry red dust trapped under the printer strokes, proof of a room far from Tarn's wet iron walls.

From Osel came seven household marks absent from the Authorized Census.

The message did not name them Anver. Two used water-ward notation. Five followed a local shore code Vey had never seen. The sender had compared three quarter returns and found the same marks removed after each sync. Beside the list stood a careful warning: DO NOT ASSUME COMMON PEOPLE. COMMON REMOVAL ONLY.

"Good," Vey said.

Cira glanced at her. "Seven more erased households is good?"

"The warning is. Whoever wrote this kept the count from turning resemblance into certainty. We know the removal matches. We do not know the people do."

She copied the seven under a new heading on the household form: OSEL, IDENTITY OPEN. The Anver count remained separate. If the Concordance had scrubbed other small populations between SY 190 and the present, folding them all under one name would repeat the same crime in a kinder hand. A true census had to leave room for persons who did not fit the first explanation.

Pellune's reply contained no names at all. It held route references, dates, and a tally of exceptions filed from four worlds. The north-table Teller had noticed a pattern in unplaced-person notices: each traveled toward the Ledger-House; none returned with a correction that restored the person. Instead, later Authorized Census packets arrived with the disputed lines absent. The Teller had begun copying exception headers before forwarding them. Eleven headers survived in the message. Their routes touched Pellune, Vrey, Thann, and one world code lost after its first letter.

Under the headers, a question remained intact.

DOES TARN KEEP SOURCE PAGES?

Vey read it twice. The question had left Pellune years before Bren hid her ledger among dead claims. A stranger had understood the need for paper before Tarn's archive became the shelter.

"We need to answer," she said.

"An answer takes years."

"Yula answered years late. It reached us when we needed it. Pellune may need ours after we think the work is finished."

Cira rested both palms on the tuning bench. "The main transmitter is sealed. Kendt countersigns every inter-world packet from Tarn now. I can place a line in an ordinary sync margin, but that repeats the accident that brought him here. If he sees the exposure, he closes me before I can do anything useful."

"Then don't send today. We prepare an answer that can travel when there is a path."

"That sounds like waiting."

"It is keeping the source ready. Waiting without a kept source is surrender."

Cira accepted the distinction with a tight movement of her mouth. She had chosen the relay over its orders, but she still thought in openings measured by shifts and switches. Vey thought in quarter rolls. Their kinds of patience differed. They would need both.

The red-dust reply supplied the piece that turned several answers into a network. Most of its prose had vanished. What remained listed five short route marks connected by hand-drawn strokes, a copy of Vey's query at one end and local questions branching from it. Beside each mark, the sender had written a date and a single word: KEPT. The marks included Yula's damaged code, Osel, and Pellune. Two were unknown.

"This passed through her table," Cira said, pointing to Yula's route impression. "Whoever drew it had her answer, then forwarded the method with their own list."

Vey measured the dates. No direct exchange could account for the sequence; some copies had taken different branches and arrived out of order. One world answered a question another had not yet received. By the time Tarn saw the map, every line on it represented years of independent work.

"There is no center," Vey said.

"Good. A center is where the Concordance puts a lock."

They made an inventory on three sheets. Confirmed households went in black. Uncertain persons stayed in pencil. Route marks occupied a separate column so later fragments could strengthen or undo an inference. The Anver entries kept their own heading, with the founding standing attached. Osel's unknown water wards held another. Pellune's eleven exception headers formed an index to counts not yet recovered. Yula's two-digit household tally remained a range.

By late afternoon the inventory touched at least six worlds. Tarn no longer held the largest part of it. Tarn held one detailed book, one old clause, and a set of replies that proved other books existed.

Footsteps passed outside the cabinet. Cira covered the glass plate with a maintenance diagram. Vey folded the inventory beneath her shirt. Kendt's Teller tried the latch once, found it secured, and moved on without knocking.

Neither woman spoke until his steps faded into the main relay hum.

"He can search the Redoubt," Cira said.

"Then these pages go to Bren."

"He can search the archive."

"Then the copies cannot stop at Tarn."

That answer carried them to the edge of the next problem. They had no open frequency and no approved transmitter. Cira had begun to study how a breach might work, but study did not yet make a path. Vey refused to let urgency turn preparation into a careless send. A partial network already survived because distant counters had kept good sources. Whatever Tarn added had to meet their

standard.

She gathered the curled strips into their original return tray. "Leave the waste where Kendt expects it. Copy the raw images to separate local spools. One with you, one with Bren, one hidden outside both offices."

"And Yula's instruction?"

"We follow it. Find the other counters. Not on the mesh yet. First on paper, with every route we know. When a path opens, the question goes wider than the first one did."

Cira lifted the maintenance diagram. Under its corner, Yula's name showed through the thin sheet, dark enough to read despite the failed ribbon.

Bren received them after the Counting House bell had closed the floor. He took the three inventory sheets without comment and led Vey between the archive shelves to the box third from the end. The shadow ledger no longer fit among the founding deeds. Extra leaves swelled its oiled-canvas cover, and loose source slips filled the space around it.

Lamplight moved across the old pages as Vey opened to the last Tarn entry. Her earlier tally ended with Anver households recovered from bleed-through, each supported by two sources. She drew a rule beneath it, then began a new section on the next leaf.

COUNTS KEPT BEYOND TARN.

Bren read over her shoulder. "How many worlds?"

"Six confirmed by route. Two more marks we cannot place. There may be others between."

"How many people?"

"We cannot total them yet. Yula kept between ten and ninety-nine households. Osel sent seven marks. Pellune kept eleven exception headers, not the people behind them. A total would pretend the fragments say more than they do."

He nodded. "Then don't total. Show the open places."

Vey copied until the bell rope upstairs creaked in the night wind. She entered Yula by name, the damaged route, the range, and the two-source rule. Osel's households followed under their warning. Pellune's headers took a full page. Last came the five-mark map from the red-dust world, each connection recorded without guessing who had drawn it.

Across the table, Bren prepared three stitched packets from duplicate forms. One would stay in the vault under a dead platform claim. Cira would hide the second among obsolete tuning records. Vey kept the third thin enough to carry inside her coat. None contained the whole ledger. Each contained enough routes to find the rest if one copy disappeared.

Until that night, she had measured the shadow census by names. Nineteen phantoms had become hundreds of Anver, recovered a household at a time. The new pages required a different measure. Their value lay partly in persons and partly in counters: unknown clerks who had stopped at an impossible ward, preserved an exception, or refused to let a local clean decide that absence meant error.

A network did not remove the danger. It distributed the keeping. Kendt could hold Vey again. Drase could renew the quarantine. A Teller on Osel might sign a correction before Tarn's answer arrived. Loss remained built into every hop. Yet no one office now possessed every point at which the count could be ended.

Vey closed the canvas cover after midnight. The book pressed against its wrapping instead of lying flat. Bren returned it to the box, then paused and took down a second box from the next shelf.

"It has outgrown one grave," he said.

They divided the source pages without dividing the index that linked them. One box took Tarn and the Anver households. The other took Yula, Osel, Pellune, and the route map. Bren shelved them six paces apart among claims the register considered dead.

Before Vey left, she wrote a single outgoing line on a narrow strip and dated it for the first opening Cira could safely use.

TARN KEEPS SOURCE PAGES. OTHERS KEEP THEM TOO. SEND ROUTES, NOT TRUST.

The replies arrived in the cadence of the Static, which was to say they arrived when they arrived and not before. A strip from Yula came back with half its household marks intact and a line Vey read as encouragement, though the corruption might have meant otherwise. A Teller on Thann returned nothing but a single word that the console rendered as a greeting in a script Vey did not know. She took it as one anyway. Each return widened the ledger by a name or a mark, and each name widened the danger, because a count that grew past Tarn's borders was a count the Concordance would eventually notice. She accepted the danger the way she had accepted the rain, as weather she could not stop and would not hide from. The network was no longer hers alone. It belonged to the few who had answered a query they did not understand, and who had chosen, in the slow language of the relay, to keep counting the people the wider count had dropped. That choice, multiplied across the Spill, was beginning to look like a movement, and Vey had not planned to start one. She had only meant to finish a count someone had left unfinished, and the finishing had pulled half the Spill into her small, growing, unlawful book.

She did not address the strip to a world. Yula might receive it, or a Teller on Thann, or a clerk whose name had fallen out of every return. The Static would choose its slow branches. Whoever found it would know Tarn had answered.

At the archive door, Vey looked back. Two boxes now sat where one had been, their spines blank, separated by ordinary dead claims. Bren lowered the lamp. In the narrowing light, the gap between the boxes remained visible.

Chapter 16 — The Broadcast Plan

Cira brought three strips of relay paper to Bren's archive and laid them beside the shadow ledger. Each strip had been cut from a different test run. The first carried a clean row of figures. The second had lost every ninth character. The third ended halfway through a household name, where the Redoubt's quarantine routine had recognized the old Anver band and cleared the rest.

Vey aligned the torn ends against the edge of the long table. Around them, Tarn's founding deeds slept in their boxes. Bren had given them the room for one hour after the Counting House bell, then gone upstairs to mend a register in public. He did not want to know how a relay breach worked. He wanted to know which shelf should hold the work if they failed.

"Three tries," Vey said. "One clean, one damaged, one stopped."

"One clean because I sent it through the weather band with the quarantine disabled at the scrap rig," Cira said. "It crossed six local repeaters and came back. That proves Tarn can carry it. It proves nothing about the first inter-world hop. The damaged copy went through an ordinary census carrier. The stopped copy used the frequency we mean to open."

"Then opening it isn't enough."

"No. Opening lets the Anver signal reach the forwarding head. It doesn't persuade the head to keep our packet when the standing order wakes up farther down the chain. Every station carries its own quarantine mirror. I can break Tarn's instruction. I can't reach the next station's book."

Vey looked at the third strip. A plan that depended on every distant Teller making Cira's choice would fail before the count left the near relays. They needed the mesh to forward the census under rules stronger than its rule for erasure.

She opened the canvas ledger. Its pages had grown uneven with inserts from Yula and the other replies that had reached Tarn through the Static. Some names carried two independent source marks. Others carried a household total, a location, and no surviving personal line. Vey had separated them instead of forcing them into one grade of certainty. The book now held four sections: verified persons, verified households with damaged names, population summaries from distant census-takers, and unresolved fragments. No figure crossed from one section to another without a dated source trail.

"We don't send a speech," she said. "We send a working census."

Cira pulled a stool closer. "Define working."

"A receiver must be able to count it without trusting us. Every block says where

it came from, how many sources support it, and which parts arrived damaged. The verified names go first. Household summaries follow. Then the distant schedules. Then the unresolved material, marked as unresolved. We do not hide uncertainty to make the total look stronger."

"That makes it long."

"It makes it defensible."

"Long packets die."

Vey had expected the answer. The shadow ledger had taken two years to build because no single fragment survived whole. Sending it as one continuous document would repeat the Concordance's oldest advantage: the Static could destroy the proof while appearing to do nothing but decay.

She turned to a blank working sheet. "Then it doesn't travel as one packet."

By the second hour, the table held forty paper rectangles. Vey had cut them to the size of relay blocks and numbered them in pencil. She made the first rectangle an index, the second a statement of method, and the next eight the smallest complete form of the count. The verified Anver entries occupied four. The aggregate schedules from the network took two. The final pair identified the Reckoning Clause and the quarantine order so no Registrar could call the unfamiliar population a clerical addition without also denying the Concordance's own records.

Cira read the ten-block sequence and moved the method block ahead of the index.

"Why?" Vey asked.

"A receiver may lose the first block. Every relay bites hardest when it takes a carrier. The tuning head needs a moment to settle, and the opening characters smear. Start with something we can afford to lose."

"We can't afford to lose the method."

"Then repeat it at the end."

Vey took another rectangle and copied METHOD, SOURCES, CONFIDENCE GRADES across it. Eleven blocks now.

Cira drew a line under the set. "This becomes the core. We send it three times. Different order each time, so one recurring dropout doesn't eat the same section in all three copies."

"Thirty-three blocks."

"Thirty-four. Put a route instruction between copies."

"What instruction can outrank a quarantine?"

Cira reached for a relay manual she had brought beneath her coat. Its binding had cracked along the back from years of being opened to the same useful pages.

She turned past the tuning tables and stopped at the census conflict procedure.

A receiving station that found two population schedules for the same world could not choose between them locally. The Teller marked both as disputed, duplicated them into the next outbound census carrier, and sent an exception toward the Ledger-House. Quarantine rules cleared unrecognized signals. Conflict rules preserved recognized census material until a Registrar ruled on it.

"We make every station hold both counts," Cira said. "The Authorized Census already sits in their current carrier. Ours identifies itself as a correction to that same edition, with Tarn's source mark and the distant schedules attached. The forwarding head sees a census conflict before it sees the forbidden band inside the evidence. It copies first and refers the dispute upward."

Vey followed the procedure with her finger. "A Teller can still zero it."

"A Teller can. The machine won't. Most shifts follow the machine. The ones who read closely will see a conflict packet with names in it. Some will zero it. Some will make private copies. We need enough stations to do what Pellune did when the fragment reached them. Stop and ask."

"And the Ledger-House gets an exception from every station that asks."

"Yes. We give central a map of its own failure."

That consequence belonged in the design, not outside it. The Ledger-House would know the packet's source after the first exception arrived. It would issue a closure toward Tarn at once, though the order would still need to travel through the mesh to distant stations. Locally, Kendt could reach the Redoubt in hours. Cira's opening might last minutes.

Vey wrote `CONFLICT: AUTHORIZED CENSUS, CURRENT EDITION` on each core block. Beneath it she added `CORRECTION SOURCES ENCLOSED`. She would not call the shadow ledger authorized. She would make the false census answer it.

"Full names after the core?" Cira asked.

"All of them."

"The verified list alone runs to hundreds of blocks once the marks are rendered. The network schedules add more. We may hold the outgoing head for forty minutes if the drum feeds clean. An hour if it doesn't."

"Can the bridge stay warm that long?"

"The bridge can. The tuning head may trip its heat latch after twenty-three minutes. I can reset it once without opening the housing. A second reset leaves a burn mark on the latch strip and rings maintenance at the day console."

"So two runs."

Cira shook her head. "One run, divided. Core first, then the verified names, then the schedules. At twenty minutes I let the head cool while the ordinary Tarn count occupies the carrier. After four minutes I reset and append the evidence pages, source tables, and unresolved fragments. If Kendt closes us during the gap, the

core and most names have already gone."

"If the gap makes the second part look separate?"

"Same conflict number, same block index. A receiver can join them. Every block needs the index range, not merely its place. Block forty-nine of two hundred and twelve. Copy two of three. If block forty-nine arrives alone, it tells the Teller what else to look for in the raw log."

Vey revised every rectangle. Concrete work steadied her. A consequence could not be measured, but a missing index could.

They tested the core against damage with scissors.

Cira copied the eleven blocks three times, changing the order after the first and preserving the source headings on each. Vey turned her back while Cira cut away strips, punched holes through figures, and removed five whole blocks. Then Vey reconstructed what remained.

The first trial preserved the Anver verified total but lost the explanation of the confidence grades. The second kept the method and dropped the legal evidence. Across all three, she could recover every core figure, the existence of each source schedule, the quarantine order's date, and enough of the Reckoning Clause to locate it in a founding ledger. She could not recover seventeen personal names whose middle characters disappeared in corresponding places.

"Names need their own redundancy," Vey said.

"More copies means more time."

"Then don't repeat whole lines. Split each name into overlapping pairs. First copy carries name and household. Second carries household and ward. Third carries ward and name. Any two rebuild the entry."

Cira considered it, then took the pencil. "That costs fewer characters than three full entries. It also lets a receiver check whether lines drifted during corruption."

They recut the sample. This time Vey recovered sixteen of the seventeen. The last entry had lost the same household mark twice.

"Four links for damaged entries," she said. "Name to household, household to ward, ward to source, source back to name."

"You'd turn the census into a net."

"A net can lose a knot and still hold a fish."

Cira gave her a brief look. "You do remember you work on a water-world."

"The forms remind me."

For the distant schedules, they chose a different structure. Yula's reply had arrived with a clear total and damaged provenance marks. Other census-takers had supplied local subtotals whose personal lines would take years more to recover. Vey refused to present those totals as verified names. Each schedule

would carry the sender's surviving mark, the world named in the reply, its stated count, its transmission date, Tarn's receipt date, and a note saying whether another fragment agreed. Receivers could add them to a provisional census or hold them apart. Either choice acknowledged people the Authorized Census omitted.

The unresolved section created the hardest argument.

"Leave it here," Cira said, tapping the ledger. "If you send fragments that might be names, Kendt will point at one error and call all of it invention."

"If I leave them out, I repeat his method."

"Not if you label them unreadable."

"Unreadable people still exist."

"Then count the damaged lines as damaged lines, not persons."

Vey studied the page. She had written question marks beside partial marks for months, unwilling to promote them and unwilling to discard them. Cira had given her the right unit. The true census did not have to pretend knowledge it lacked.

She wrote: UNRESOLVED PERSON-LINES OBSERVED: followed by the count of distinct fragments, the duplication rule she had used, and the limits of the inference. No names would be guessed. No damaged line would vanish.

At the bottom of the working sheet, Vey listed what a distant recipient needed in order to verify the broadcast: compare the conflict number across copies; match the source dates to raw arrival logs; pull the founding clause from local mirrors; inspect the quarantine register; preserve all damaged blocks before clean; forward both schedules under conflict procedure. Five actions. A Teller receiving one surviving core could begin without waiting for Tarn or the Ledger-House.

Cira read the list aloud. "Preserve before clean matters most. Put it in every route block."

"Twice in each."

"Once, but at both ends. Repetition inside a line can degrade together."

Vey changed it. They had stopped discussing whether the count should go. Every question now concerned what would remain after it did.

The relay schedule hung on the back wall of the Redoubt's scrap room, copied by hand in Cira's narrow lettering. They went there after dark by separate gangways. Vey entered through the records door with an old census case under her arm. Cira came ten minutes later from the shift quay. Anyone watching would see a census-taker delivering a sealed packet and a Teller reporting for work.

Inside, Cira barred the scrap-room door and lit one shaded lamp. The old console hummed beneath the desk. Its paper drum held a clean roll, already measured for the full count.

Seven outbound windows crossed Tarn during the next twelve days. Five carried weather, household messages, and station maintenance. One carried an ordinary census amendment toward Osel. The last carried the quarterly Authorized Census into the nearest three branches of the mesh. Each branch would duplicate it as part of the standing census exchange.

Cira marked the final window with ink. "This is our moment. Six days from now, second hour after the evening bell. The census carrier opens on all three heads for fifty-two minutes. The first head runs toward Osel and Pellune. The second takes the Vrey chain. The third turns through the older beacons toward Yula's side of the Spill. If we use any earlier window, one copy goes one direction. Use this one and the mesh makes three departures before anyone can close Tarn."

"Why not wait for the next quarter? More replies may arrive."

"Kendt's maintenance order begins the morning after this window. He calls it a quarantine integrity review. His Teller will replace the old tuning head and scrap the local log mirror. My bridge fits the old head. The new housing has no open socket, and I won't get near it without breaking a seal in sight of the day shift."

Six days fixed the work. Vey counted backward. Bren needed two nights to copy the final ledger onto feed sheets. She needed one day to reconcile those sheets against the source book. Cira needed a full shift to encode the conflict headers and stage the bridge. That left two days for a blind check and one for failure.

"We make two physical sets," Vey said. "Bren holds the source ledger. I carry one feed set to the Redoubt. You hide the other inside the scrap-room paper stores before Kendt's review. If I am held again, you still have the count. If they take you first, I bring my set to whichever Teller replaces you and make that person refuse me in writing."

"My replacement will call Kendt."

"Then Kendt receives the correction by hand while the other copy waits in his station. Not a good outcome. Better than one seizure ending it."

Cira wrote the sequence on the schedule margin:

1. Open the quarantined input at the scrap rig.
2. Seat the bypass bridge before the census carrier begins.
3. Feed three reordered copies of the core.
4. Feed linked personal entries until heat warning.
5. Transfer ordinary Tarn census during cooling gap.
6. Reset once. Feed remaining entries, schedules, evidence, unresolved-line count.
7. Close with core index and preserve-before-clean instruction.
8. Pull bridge. Leave raw log intact.

"Why leave the log?" Vey asked. "It proves you did it."

"It also proves what we sent. If I wipe it, Kendt calls the packet a corrupt accident and substitutes his reconstruction. The raw log gives Tarn a complete local copy with relay times. Bren can demand it as evidence in your census case. Pell can refuse to certify any correction that ignores it."

"You will lose your post."

"I chose that before tonight."

Cira said it without drama. Vey believed her because Cira's pencil continued moving. Beside the sequence, she listed the likely alarms: unauthorized tuning, conflict packet, heat reset, quarantine mismatch. The first appeared only on the scrap rig. The second printed at the day console after forwarding began. The heat reset rang a maintenance bell. The mismatch sent a fast same-world notice to Kendt's office.

"How long from the mismatch to this door?" Vey asked.

"His lodging lies twenty minutes away by launch in calm water. Twelve if he keeps a boat at the Redoubt. I expect he will. The duty Teller can reach us in under two minutes once the day console prints. I can lock the inner door. It won't hold against the master key."

"Can we delay the print?"

"For nine minutes. I can leave the day console in its plate test. Longer than that and it fails the carrier handshake, which might stop all three heads."

Vey added nine minutes to the plan, not as safety but as available work. "Core clears in?"

"Seven minutes. First names begin before the alarm. By the time the duty Teller understands the conflict, the core has entered three heads."

"And if the master key turns at minute ten?"

"I keep feeding. You take the completed log roll through the cable hatch. It drops into the pump passage and comes out by the north ladder. Bren gets the local proof."

"You stay in the room."

"Someone has to keep pressure on the feed lever."

The answer had no technical alternative hidden inside it. Vey could operate a census reader, but she could not tune three forwarding heads while clearing a quarantine routine. Cira could. Their division of risk followed their division of skill.

Vey pictured the grey cell, the bolt light, Pell buying her three days. Another hold would not end at three. Kendt would have the raw log, the feed sheets, and a deliberate correction bearing her source mark. The Concordance could remove her from the Counting House. It could charge Bren with concealment and Pell with false certification. Worlds named in the source schedules might face audits years after the packet reached them.

"We strip the living correspondents' route codes from the public blocks," she said. "Their world and transmission date remain. Their private return strings stay with Bren. A receiving Teller can verify the packet against a raw log without getting an address to hand central."

"Yula's mark?"

Vey hesitated. Without it, her strongest distant schedule lost provenance. With it, the Ledger-House could target Yula when the slow order reached her world.

"She told us to use it," Vey said. "Her reply named the risk. Keep her mark. Strip anyone who did not consent."

Cira nodded and added CONSENT beside the source table.

That left Tarn. They could not strip themselves without weakening the act into an anonymous fragment. Vey wrote her full census mark on the core header. Cira added her Teller mark to the route instruction. Neither mark could be mistaken for corruption.

"Once those travel," Cira said, "we don't get to claim an accident."

"Kendt already taught me that. A broadcast is an act."

"It may start the Reckoning before anyone knows what a fair claim looks like."

"Yes."

"Tarn may owe water rights it cannot pay. People who had no hand in the erasure may lose claims they were born inside."

"Yes."

Cira set down the pencil. "I need you to say why that doesn't stop us. Not for the packet. For me."

Vey looked through the scrap room's small window. Beyond the glass, the platform lights shifted on black water. She could not promise peace. Drase's argument had force because the founding claims carried force. A true count would not restore names without restoring what those names could demand.

"It doesn't fail to stop us," she said. "We stop and measure it. We list the risk. Then we send the count because the people who may make claims cannot be excluded to spare the people who may answer them. The dispute comes after standing. Otherwise one side decides the case by deleting the other from the page."

Cira waited, then picked up the pencil again. "Put that in the method block. Plainly."

Vey did. Not as a defense of every claim, and not as a promise that the Reckoning would be gentle. The line stated that inclusion granted standing to speak and did not settle any remedy. Receivers would get a census, source evidence, and a legal consequence kept visible rather than disguised.

They checked the schedule once more. Six days. Second hour after the evening bell. Fifty-two minutes of carrier time, one planned cooling gap, nine minutes before the day console printed. Three outward heads. Two feed sets. One local raw log sent through the hatch if the door opened.

Cira tore the marked margin from the relay schedule and burned it over the

lamp tray. Vey copied the timings into the back of her small book using the bell roster as a cipher Bren could read. They did not shake hands. Agreement needed no ceremony when both marks would stand on the same packet.

At the door, Vey turned back. Cira had already opened the scrap cabinet and begun measuring the spare roll against the feed path. On the wall, the schedule carried a small square of cleaner paper where the chosen window had been torn away.

Six days remained. Vey closed the census case around the first stack of blank feed sheets, and Cira set the old tuning head warming for one final test.

Chapter 17 — Ossrey Again

The later transmission opened below the range where human hearing would have found a voice. It began with pressure changing against stone, one pulse for the old count and a second for the count that remained. Between those pulses lay a long interval. Ossrey had placed it there so any listener would know, before the first mark arrived, that absence belonged in the record.

The deeps were quieter now.

Not silent. Water still moved through the weirs and worried the carved mouths of the galleries. Children still sent their first uncertain notes along the basalt, learning how far a pitch could travel before cold bent it downward. The listening stone still carried its shut-channel hiss from the relay above. Yet the broad answering bands Ossrey had known in youth had narrowed. Where five households had once returned a keeper's call, three answered. In the far galleries a call sometimes crossed the whole dark and came back altered by stone alone.

Ossrey listened to those returns without filling them. The old song tempted a keeper to supply every remembered voice. Memory could make an emptied Ward sound full if grief sang loudly enough. That would preserve the shape of a people while losing the people themselves, another kind of erasure laid down by loving hands. The later count needed the hollows as much as the voices.

For thirteen turnings of the cold current, the keepers went out through the deeps and asked every household to answer. They did not use the relay. They carried tuned shells, wax tablets sealed against water, and cords knotted with marks that fingers could read in the dark. A household answering from a gallery cut its current mark into wax. A household unable to send a swimmer struck its name through the stone, one measured sequence passed from wall to wall until a keeper received it. No answer brought a second visit. After that came a third, because no name should be removed by distance, illness, a failed weir, or the impatience of a counter.

Ossrey took the downward galleries. Age had shortened the time the keeper could remain beneath the warm bands, but the long memory still knew each turn.

The stone sloped under Ossrey's hands like the flank of an old swimmer. Grooves ran there in families, first shallow where the earliest tools had cut them, then deep where generations had returned to renew the mark. Some grooves ended under fresh mineral skin. Others held sharp edges from a child recently taught the household cut.

At the third descent, Ossrey reached a weir whose song had once required two listening stations. The current used to carry so many overlapping threads that a keeper had to brace one hand against the wall to distinguish them. Now one low note met Ossrey near the entrance. It belonged to an old stone-cutter and shook at the end of each phrase.

The cutter brought out the household tablets. There had been births since the prior count, two swimmers with high clear marks. There had also been six deaths. Three young adults had left for a warmer Ward after the weir mouth narrowed. Their migration belonged with the living, not with the lost, and Ossrey checked the destination marks against the cord carried at the waist.

One name did not appear in either place.

Ossrey asked for it again, sending the pitch slowly so the stone-cutter could correct an error without shame. The reply came lower. The missing swimmer had gone upward to repair a listening vane and had not returned. No body had descended. No receiving Ward had sung the name. The household had kept a groove open in hope and had therefore omitted the loss from its own tablet.

Hope could delay a death. It could not be permitted to erase one.

Together they cut the swimmer into the register of the unreturned, preserving the open groove beside the mark. If a later count found the swimmer alive, the mark would move back among the living with the path of the correction visible. Ossrey had learned from the land-people's ledgers that a clean page could conceal a crime. Anver stone did not clean itself. Every change remained under the fingers.

Beyond that weir, the old south Ward gave no answer.

Three keepers entered by separate mouths. They found the anchoring cords furred with pale growth and the household niches open to the current. A child's practice groove crossed one wall, four notes unfinished. The collapse had happened seasons before. Neighbors had taken in those who escaped, but no one had returned to count the empty place because the way had become unsafe. Ossrey touched the unfinished groove and felt where the tool had lifted.

The Ward entered the later census twice. Its surviving households appeared under the names that now sheltered them. Its emptied galleries appeared under their first names, with the collapse, the migrations, and the known dead recorded beside them. A place could lose its voices without losing its standing in memory. The wider Spill had once removed the Anver by deleting their line. Ossrey would not answer that deletion by hiding an internal ruin.

Each descent brought a different subtraction. Cold had moved into the nursery

band of one Ward, and its children had been sent upward in groups that no longer shared a single household pitch. A stone sickness had taken the singers of another. One far weir answered in a voice so thin the keeper beside Ossrey mistook it for the scrape of current through a crack. When the return finished, two living Anver held a gallery built for hundreds.

The pair refused to leave. Their grooves reached back to the first count, and they tended them as carefully as a crowded Ward tended its young. Ossrey recorded the refusal and the condition of the stone. Standing did not depend on abundance. Two voices could hold a claim if each voice chose to remain.

During the upward rest, Ossrey laid the wax tablets in the sorting basin. Warm mineral water loosened them from their shells, and the keepers pressed each mark into soft clay before the wax lost its cut. The clay sheets gathered in racks along the wall. Living households occupied one rack, the dead another, migrations a third. Empty Wards received sheets of their own. By the seventh current-turn, the new record covered the chamber from floor groove to waterline.

A young keeper saw the spread and asked whether the land-people would count so many kinds of absence. The old Authorized Census, in the fragments that reached the deeps, offered a total for each world and little else. It made a people look smooth from far away. The Anver record showed breaks, moved names, disputed deaths, failed stone, and children carried from one Ward into another.

Ossrey answered that the count must arrive rough. Smoothness had served the Concordance when it wanted the Anver gone. A single erased total left no household to object. This offering would carry the seams of its making, so a distant census-taker could follow a name from old groove to present throat and know where certainty ended.

The keepers continued until every route had returned or been marked impassable. Then they sounded the clay sheets in the sorting basin. Each cut produced a pitch when drawn beneath a reading tine. Those pitches entered the long song, changing it for the first time in Ossrey's keeping. Whole banks of remembered voices had to be lowered into the register of the dead. Several household threads moved to new Wards. The unfinished child's groove from the south entered as a held question, neither living nor confirmed dead.

When the revised song passed through the chamber, it carried less sound than the version Ossrey had learned from a mother's flank. The missing notes did not vanish into the rests. They shaped the rests. The living lines bent around them, giving loss a location that could be transmitted and checked.

They were fewer. Ossrey heard that truth travel through the stone and did not turn away from it.

The quieting had done more than close a relay channel. Isolation had narrowed migrations between the distant deeps. Without standing in the wider count, the Anver had lost access to relay allotments used for current forecasts and old maintenance records. Weirs failed that might have been repaired. Disasters

reached neighboring Wards late. A people denied recognition still lived, but living cost more when every distant warning arrived as rumor through water.

Some deaths belonged to cold, stone, age, and chance. Others followed the long refusal above. The census marked the distinction where evidence allowed it. Ossrey would not turn every loss into an accusation. Neither would the keeper let uncertainty wash the Concordance clean.

At the gathering chamber, the long-memory keepers sounded the new song before those who could travel. The water filled with sparse bands and exact silences. No speaker stood above another. Anver voices met through the chamber's curved walls until each returned from every direction, making the assembly feel larger than the bodies within it.

They considered what the count would do once carried upward. The Reckoning had reached them as a land-word inside damaged legal fragments. Its nearest shape in the deeps meant a current forced to return along a channel someone had blocked. Old founding claims would move with that return. Waters settled by humans, access denied, maintenance withheld, names removed from common records: all could be offered for answer.

One band of voices wanted the oldest claims sent first. Let the platform worlds hear what stood beneath them before they heard the count. Another urged silence until the land-people opened the frequency without conditions. A count offered through a channel still governed by censors might become material for another managed forgetting.

Ossrey received both arguments along the body, low notes through the ribs and sharper ones behind the jaw. The keeper had no authority to command the Wards. Long memory conferred obligation, not rule. Ossrey could tell them what the record held and what the old claims meant. The choice to offer it had to return from the gathering itself.

So Ossrey sounded three passages.

First came the founding song, preserved from the years when the wider census named Anver and human settlements together. Its notes carried no demand that one people vanish for another to stand. Next came the quieting record, each relay loss and quarantine fragment placed in order. Last came the new count, thinner, marked with empty Wards and surviving children.

The chamber answered after a long interval.

Its response did not choose surrender. It did not choose a flood of every claim at once. The Wards would send their own count as the first offering, accompanied by the founding record and a notice that claims would follow through whatever open procedure the Spill made possible. They would arrive neither as phantoms asking to be believed nor as an old danger speaking only through law. They would name who remained. After recognition, they would state what the counted were owed.

Consent had to travel back through the same difficult water as the tally. The

gathering sent the decision outward with two possible answer tones, one for joining the offer and one for withholding a Ward's record until further hearing. No keeper interpreted silence as agreement. Swimmers waited at the edge of blocked routes. Listening crews repeated faint responses until the source confirmed them. One nursery Ward withheld its children's household cuts from the first packet, fearing a surface authority might use the marks to find and govern them. Ossrey accepted the refusal and placed a sealed gap in the packet order. The count would state that a living Ward had chosen privacy. It would not expose those names to prove completeness.

Another Ward agreed to be named but refused to attach its oldest water claim. Its weir opened toward a human-settled basin remembered only in founding pitch, and the singers there wanted contact before law. That choice also entered the record. The Reckoning could not restore Anver standing by teaching them the Concordance's habit of speaking for people without permission. If the offer reached the surface with visible gaps, the gaps would show where authority stopped.

By the time every reachable answer returned, most Wards had joined. A few held portions back. None asked to be absent from the statement that the Anver remained. Ossrey heard that common note beneath their differences and added it to the transmission header, not as unanimity, but as the narrow truth all had authorized.

Preparation changed the deeps. Households renewed grooves that had gone shallow. Swimmers carried duplicate clay impressions to separate Wards so no collapse could destroy the only copy. The young practiced rendering pitches as relay marks, a harsh reduction that removed the pressure harmonics Anver listeners used to distinguish kin. Every reduced mark had to be checked by three throats against the source song.

Ossrey worked at the listening stone with the same young keeper who had asked about absence. The shut channel still hissed, but new flaws had opened in the quarantine. At irregular intervals, scraps from the wider mesh pressed through: count headers, timing pulses, damaged household strings from worlds whose names arrived broken. Once, beneath the hiss, Ossrey heard a repeated pattern built from the Anver opening line.

Someone far above had sent it back.

The return could have crossed years. It might have begun before the latest south collapse, before the stone sickness, before several children in the new count had learned their names. Slow carried no comfort to a body waiting beside a listening stone. Yet the pattern proved that a listener had received enough of the first transmission to answer in its shape.

Ossrey placed the returning marks beside the prepared record. The reply did not promise restoration. It contained no intact word for standing, hearing, or peace. Most of its middle had been eaten in transit. Near the end, however, three repetitions survived: a surface census mark, the Anver opening, and an instruction

used by old relays when a sender should continue.

Continue could also be a machine's error. The keeper knew better than to make a door from one damaged hinge. They sent a short test first, only a Ward marker and the checksum tone that should return if the channel reached another hand. Then they waited through two current-turns, listening while the stone gave back its flat refusal.

On the third turn, the checksum came through changed but recognizable.

The gathering did not celebrate. Celebration belonged after a safe return, not at the first loosened stone above a trapped swimmer. Instead the keepers opened the transmission racks and began ordering the offered count for passage. Small packets would travel farther than one long song. Each packet received its place in the whole, its neighboring marks, and enough repeated structure to rebuild what the Static damaged.

Living households went first. Ossrey insisted on that order. A people long represented as old claims and ghosts should enter by its breathing names. Children appeared with their current Wards and the prior Wards from which their household lines had moved. Keepers followed, then cutters, current-readers, nursery singers, weir tenders, and those whose work had no clean rendering in land-script. The transmission named function only to help a distant reader understand the count; no Anver standing depended on labor.

After the living came the unreturned, the confirmed dead since the last intact wider census, and the disputed marks. Empty galleries followed as places with continuing claims. The final packets carried the old founding entries, paired cut by cut with the deeps' preserved grooves. A land-reader could compare them without accepting Ossrey's memory on trust.

At the end, they prepared a statement in the narrow syntax the relay damaged least:

We remain.

We have counted ourselves.

This count includes our losses.

Receive it before our claims.

The phrases sounded blunt when drawn through the reading tine. Anver speech usually placed relationship before assertion, water before swimmer, echo before source. The Static favored harder edges. Ossrey accepted the injury to the language because the full song traveled beside it, packet after packet, carrying what the short statement could not.

Before release, the keepers performed the count once more. No one sang from memory alone. They touched each clay sheet, followed every migration cord, and matched each encoded packet to a groove or living reply. Where records disagreed, both versions remained with a mark of dispute. Where a route had

failed, the transmission said unvisited rather than empty. Where hope held an unreturned swimmer's groove open, the count carried hope and uncertainty together without calling either fact.

The work lasted through another cold turning. More voices disappeared while they prepared it. Two births entered near the end, requiring changes to packet order and checksum. One old keeper died after checking a far Ward and remained in the packet of the living until Ossrey found the mismatch. They stopped the release, corrected every dependent mark, and sounded the sequence again.

No count stayed true by standing still.

When the last verification ended, Ossrey went alone to the old south mouth. Stone barred the unsafe route, but water still passed through a crack and carried a faint resonance from the empty galleries. The unfinished practice groove waited somewhere beyond reach. Ossrey sounded its four notes into the crack, then added no fifth. A distant listener might have mistaken completion for mercy. The child had left the line unfinished. The record would honor the lifted tool.

Returning upward took most of a current-turn. At the listening stone, the Wards had gathered by transmitted voice. Their pitches layered through the water, fewer than the old song promised and more numerous than the silence above admitted. Ossrey settled against the relay face and felt the machinery's pulse under the mineral casing.

The prepared count waited in rows of tactile marks. It did not ask the surface to absolve itself. It did not disguise the claims that recognition would wake. The offering gave the Spill something it had denied itself for generations: persons before consequence, evidence before fear.

Ossrey sounded the release tone.

One packet entered the carrier, then another. The quarantine scraped pieces from them. Repetition restored some. Checksums failed and were sent again. For the first time, the keeper did not sing merely to preserve a local truth. The song had been made ready for another count, one beyond the deeps, and the channel had opened enough to take it.

Long after the first marks left, the transmission continued feeding upward. Ossrey kept one hand on the listening stone and the other on the groove of the present count. Under those hands, the relay trembled and the basalt held. Between them passed the names of the living, each one leaving the deeps without leaving the stone.

Chapter 18 — The Relay Breach

Tarn Redoubt carried three kinds of warning. A hard fault rang the brass bell above the main console. A local line failure lit the white lamps on the switching board. Concordance attention arrived without either. It showed as a second checksum

request placed beside the first, neat and patient, asking the station to prove twice that it had done what it had been ordered to do.

Cira Vell found the extra request at the start of her night shift.

She stood over the paper drum while its narrow sheet advanced under the print head. The first checksum belonged there. Every station sent one before the long-range forwarding interval. The second carried no reason code and asked for the quarantine table as well as the ordinary traffic log. Someone at the Ledger-House had started comparing obedience, not maintenance.

The request had crossed the Static for years. That gave her no comfort. Its date placed the inquiry after the leak from Vey's shadow count, and its route field named Tarn without corruption. A reply would take years to reach the Ledger-House, but Tarn's local Concordance office received station status on a fast cable. If Cira changed the table and left the status pair connected, an auditor in Halversand could know before dawn.

On the shelf beneath the drum sat the cable-note papers she had kept since her apprenticeship. Six old seal-hashes. Four missing raw lines. A standing order number copied before the clean overwrote its own evidence. She had found the hand inside the supposed entropy by measuring what it removed. Tonight she meant to use the same measurements to take its grip off.

Cira checked the shift board. Teller Emon had signed out at the tenth bell. The morning keeper would arrive at the second. Between them lay four hours, one forwarding interval, and no honest explanation for why the scrap rig had been moved beside the tuning head.

She locked the outer door, then lifted the station handset.

"Redoubt," she said.

The local wire answered with three clicks. Vey had used no words. They had agreed on that. One click would have meant stop, two meant delay, three meant the count and its copies had reached the safe cabinets. The channel could be opened.

Cira put the handset down without replying. A return click would have entered the local exchange log. Vey would wait for the signal itself.

The breach required no smashed lock and no single forbidden key. Concordance procedure had been built as layers. The receiving head heard every band. The quarantine table told the console which packets to call degradation. A hand-raised discard flag kept those packets out of reconciliation. The forwarding head then copied whatever remained onto the outgoing carrier. Each piece performed a small dull task. Together they had kept the Anver frequency quiet for more than a century.

To reverse the work, Cira needed to undo the layers in order.

She pulled the local status pair first. Two copper pins came free from the

switching board, and the lamp for HALVERSAND OVERSIGHT went white. A line fault would be noticed at the Counting House exchange within minutes. The night clerk would record it and wait for a Teller to repair it. Cira had filed intermittent salt intrusion on that pair for six weeks, once every nine days, an irritation designed to become ordinary. Tonight's fault would fit the record until someone opened the cabinet and saw the dry pins in her hand.

Next came the scrap rig. She rolled it close enough for the patch cable to reach the raw tuning head, seated the splice she had made before Vey's first listen, and watched the side screen rise from black to its flat green line. The quarantine still held. Under that line, packets reached Tarn and died unnamed.

Cira keyed the old retrieval string. The rig printed the Ledger-House standing directive she had shown Vey years earlier.

STATUS: ACTIVE.

INSTRUCTION: DO NOT TUNE, FORWARD, OR ACKNOWLEDGE.

The machine had followed that sentence through successive concordances because no Teller had asked what obedience did to the people speaking on the other side. Cira read the order once, folded the printout, and pushed it into her pocket. She would not leave it in the false floor this time.

At eleven minutes before the forwarding interval, she began.

The first layer resisted in the expected way. When Cira called up the quarantined band, the console replaced its designation with zeros. The local table allowed a Teller to read an order but not alter its target. Her training key had enough authority to repair a damaged frequency field, provided the replacement matched the signed mirror from the Ledger-House. Any direct change failed the seal.

She did not change the target.

Instead, Cira opened the station's correction protocol and directed the zeroed field to a spare tuning register. The register belonged to storm recovery, when Tarn's sea charge scattered a carrier across neighboring bands and a Teller had to follow it by hand. Storm recovery accepted a raw value before checking the quarantine mirror. The station manual treated that order as harmless because the value should come from a damaged authorized carrier, not from a scrap rig under the desk.

Cira fed the Anver designation from the raw head into the spare register.

Numbers filled the zeroes. The flat line on the side screen broke into a close, repeating structure. She recognized the interval shape from the first logs she had copied as an apprentice: a long pulse, two short, then a descending row that the renderer read as household divisions. Corruption moved through it, but the pattern held.

"Found you," she said.

The words vanished into the Redoubt's hum. No one answered. The arriving packets had crossed years to reach her and carried whatever the Anver had sent years before. Opening a path could not make the Static fast. It could let the old voice continue its journey.

Layer two controlled how the station named what it heard. Each packet on the band arrived already stamped DEGRADATION by the quarantine table. That stamp raised the discard flag before reconciliation. In her first year at the Redoubt, Cira had proved the flag came from a hand, not from entropy. She had copied the line numbers onto cable paper while the morning clean erased the raw record.

Those old line numbers gave her the flag's position in the packet header. She set the scrap rig to intercept each arriving header, clear one bit, and pass the packet into reconciliation as unresolved signal. The work looked small on the screen. A column changed from one to zero. The next packet entered the stack instead of the discard bin.

Then another entered.

For the first time in the Redoubt's local record, the console retained an Anver packet under its own frequency. The paper drum typed a timestamp, signal strength, surviving span, and source route. No correction glyph covered it. No clean took it away.

Cira compared the timestamp against the packet clock. Seven seconds remained before the forwarding gate closed on the current bundle.

Layer three had always carried the greater risk. Listening left evidence in Tarn's logs. Forwarding changed what another relay would receive. The downstream station would inspect the packet's outer header, compare its band against a quarantine mirror, and drop it again. Breaking one local table could produce one honest log and no wider breach.

The old mesh supplied another route. Before the Concordance, a relay that recovered an unregistered signal could issue a continuity acknowledgment. The acknowledgment told the next station that a living upstream Teller had judged the carrier intentional. It kept storm-damaged colony bands from disappearing whenever their designations drifted outside an old table. Later manuals still preserved the function for emergency calls, although ordinary Tellers reached it through three pages of warnings and a mechanical cover.

Cira unscrewed the cover.

Beneath it, a red key sat in a narrow slot. Turning that key would wrap the recovered packets in Tarn Redoubt's station seal and mark the band for continuity forwarding. A downstream quarantine could reject an unknown source. It could not reject a signed acknowledgment without placing its own station into dispute status, because the oldest rule of the mesh favored a Teller's witnessed signal over a remote table. The Concordance had left that rule intact. Without it, the Static

would have lost human bands whenever a world failed to receive an updated registry.

The same protection could carry the people the registry had excluded.

One second remained.

Cira turned the key.

The forwarding gate opened. The Redoubt took the retained Anver packets, placed its station seal around them, and drove them into the outgoing carrier. Needles jumped across the transmission board. The hum under Cira's boots deepened as the power bank discharged toward the first beacon beyond Tarn.

On the side screen, the line changed from local recovery green to mesh-live amber.

The quarantined frequency had entered the mesh.

Cira kept one hand on the red key. Releasing it before the full packet group cleared would leave a broken acknowledgment, easy for a downstream station to classify as noise. Holding it too long would wrap the next traffic block as well and spread Tarn's seal across messages she had no right to alter.

Twenty-three packet frames passed. Most held gaps. Four carried structures strong enough for the text renderer to keep. A household count appeared in fragments, then a location in the deeps, then a line whose surviving marks matched the name Ossrey. The final frame carried a sequence Cira had never seen in the earlier bleed-through: a header announcing a prepared census block.

They had been ready. Perhaps they had been ready for years.

The twenty-fourth frame belonged to Tarn weather. Cira released the key before the station could claim it. The gate shut cleanly behind the Anver group, and the outgoing carrier returned to its ordinary schedule.

For nine seconds nothing moved except the paper drum.

Then the downstream acknowledgment field filled.

BEACON T-4: RECEIVED.

Cira exhaled through her teeth. T-4 hung beyond Tarn, far enough that the signal needed the main array and near enough that its automatic receipt returned without years of delay. It had accepted Tarn's station seal. The next hop would receive the Anver packet as continuity traffic. Each relay after that would make its own copy and add fresh loss, but it would forward rather than sweep. A path now extended into the Spill.

The Redoubt printed the consequence beneath the receipt.

BAND STATUS DISPUTED.

LEDGER-HOUSE MIRROR CONFLICT.

REPORT REQUIRED.

She had expected all three lines. The machine could obey its oldest forwarding rule or its newer quarantine table, not both without admitting the contradiction. Dispute status preserved the traffic and summoned a human judgment. Across the mesh, every station that accepted the acknowledgment would eventually print the same demand. Tellers would pull manuals from shelves, read the skipped quarantine section, and find a signed Anver signal waiting beside an order to call it decay.

That delay formed part of Vey's plan. Questions would travel faster within each world than the Ledger-House could answer across the Spill. No single office could recall a packet already copied into distant forwarding queues. Even if every keeper chose obedience, each local raw log would hold the signal until the dispute closed. Bren and the other archivists needed copies, not permission.

A soft click sounded behind the switching board.

The local line fault timer had expired. After fifteen minutes without status, Halversand oversight would send a challenge down the second pair. Cira had left that pair connected so the fault looked narrow rather than deliberate. Now the white lamp blinked in a two-short pattern.

She could answer with NORMAL and conceal the dispute for another reporting cycle. That would require the console to compute a status hash over its live tables. The changed frequency and the continuity seal would sit inside the hash. Halversand's clerk might not know how to read the mismatch, but a registrar would.

If Cira failed to answer, a local technician could reach the Redoubt by tide-runner before morning.

The risk no longer had a clean side. Hiding the breach meant describing it accurately in a sealed number. Refusing the challenge brought another Teller to the door while the rig remained patched.

Cira chose delay. She acknowledged the line challenge as MAINTENANCE ACTIVE, a permitted response that disclosed no table hash and bought one hour before oversight asked again. The switching board accepted it. Somewhere in Halversand, a clock began counting down.

She used the hour to make the opening hold without her hand.

The continuity key could remain turned only during active recovery. A spring had already returned it to rest. Without another step, the next Anver packet group would reach Tarn, enter under the cleared discard bit, and stop at the forwarding gate. The breach would amount to one packet bundle. Vey needed the band open when she sent the true census into it.

Cira took the six old seal-hashes from the shelf. Years ago, their mismatch had proved the curated copies lacked the raw lines. Each house seal described a record shortened by the exact byte span of an erased packet. She had kept the

subtraction because it showed intent. Now it gave her six valid examples of how the quarantine routine recalculated a sheet after removing that span.

She reversed the operation on the current table. Instead of forging a new Ledger-House signature, she restored the omitted bytes beneath the old signed length and marked them as storm-recovery additions. The station's own seal covered the additions. The house seal continued to cover the table it had sent. Both remained mathematically valid because neither claimed the other's portion.

A newer console would have rejected two authorities over one record. Tarn's old rig had been built when local Tellers still amended remote schedules by hand. It displayed the split record with a yellow border and kept working.

At the forwarding rule, Cira set the continuity key to trigger whenever three conditions met: the Anver designation arrived through the spare register, the renderer found deliberate structure, and the packet carried a census-block header. That kept random noise from borrowing Tarn's seal. It also meant ordinary Anver speech would remain in the local raw log without always consuming emergency bandwidth. Their count, when it arrived, would go live.

She tested the rule against a saved frame. The console retained it, labeled it SIGNAL, and staged it for the next forwarding interval. The frequency stayed open.

The second acknowledgment came from T-4 while Cira was coiling the first patch cable. Not a receipt this time. The beacon had copied Tarn's continuity seal into its outbound queue. Its terse machine notice showed the next route: T-7, then the dark between systems.

There could be no answer from T-7 tonight. Distance still governed. The breach had not defeated years or loss. It had changed one instruction at the point where the years began.

Cira tore the notice from the drum and added it to the standing directive in her pocket. Proof needed paper because the next clean would come, and because someone would claim in the morning that a disputed band had never entered the mesh. She left a second copy on the drum. Concealment had carried the work far enough. From here, visibility protected it better.

At forty minutes past the forwarding interval, the outer latch moved.

Cira looked toward the door. No bell had rung on the gangway, and the morning keeper had not yet reached the platform. Someone outside tried the latch again, gently, then used a station key.

The Redoubt held three valid keys besides hers. Emon carried one. The morning keeper carried another. Kendt's local audit team had taken the third during the correction visit and never entered its return in the inventory.

She had time to pull the scrap-rig bridge or reconnect the status pins. Not both. Removing the bridge would stop new raw packets from clearing the discard bit.

Restoring the pins would make the switching board look ordinary while it reported the disputed band to Halversand.

Cira left the bridge seated.

She pushed the copper pins into their clips. HALVERSAND OVERSIGHT went dark, then green. Status flooded onto the local cable: fault cleared, maintenance active, outbound acknowledgment issued, frequency in dispute. The record became visible across Tarn before the key outside completed its turn.

Her local handset clicked almost at once. Three clicks came from Vey, the same agreed signal as before, but its meaning had changed. The count remained safe. Or Vey had seen the open band on the Counting House receiver. Cira could not know which, and there was no time to ask.

The door opened a hand's width and stopped against the inside chain.

"Teller Vell?" Emon called through the gap. His voice carried sleep and concern. "Oversight says your status dropped. They sent me to check the pair."

Not Kendt. That reduced one danger and created another. Emon knew the station well enough to see every wrong cable in the room.

"Pair's restored," Cira said. She did not move to release the chain.

"Then let me in and I'll certify it."

Behind her, the paper drum advanced. Its print head struck a fresh line. An Anver census header had entered through the raw tuning head and passed the three tests. The amber mesh-live lamp came on for the next forwarding interval.

Emon heard the drum. "What are you running?"

Cira looked at the side screen. Structure climbed through the Static where a flat green line had held for her entire apprenticeship. The packet entered the forwarding queue under Tarn Redoubt's seal. T-4 waited on the route. Beyond it waited years, loss, other stations, and Tellers who would have to choose what to call the signal in front of them.

She took the standing order from her pocket and slid it under the door to Emon.

"Read the instruction," Cira said. "Then look at what it calls degradation."

For several seconds he said nothing. Paper shifted outside as he unfolded the order. The mesh-live lamp held amber.

Cira unfastened the chain.

When the door opened, the frequency remained open behind her, and the Redoubt's outgoing needles began their next measured rise.

Chapter 19 — The True Census

The open frequency made a different sound. Vey had expected volume, perhaps the shriek of a band forced past its limits, but Tarn Redoubt held the same low

hum it had carried all her working life. The change showed on the side screen. Where a flat green line had marked the Anver quarantine, packets now climbed in narrow steps, each one stamped for forwarding. A channel the Concordance had called empty had begun to fill the relay room with work.

Cira sat at the tuning console with one sleeve darkened by oil and both hands spread over the keys. She had opened the band less than an hour earlier. The cabinet under her station stood open, its lock drilled through, and three bypass leads ran from the raw head to the outbound bank. None belonged there. Red warning lamps moved across the panel in a patient row.

"How long?" Vey asked.

"Until the Redoubt's controller takes the tuning head back, or a Ledger-House instruction reaches the local stack and does it for them." Cira glanced at the clock above the paper drum. "I can keep the controller busy. I can't keep it confused forever."

On the worktable between them lay the parts of the count. Bren had carried the canvas ledger from the archive wrapped in the same tissue that once hid it among dead founding claims. Pell had brought the current Authorized Census and left without asking which door Vey meant to use. Cira had printed the recovered Anver transmission as it arrived through the reopened band, line after line of sonic marks rendered into households, weirs, births, deaths, and wards. Beside those records sat the replies gathered over two years from Yula and the other census-takers who had learned to read the margins of their local rolls.

No single book held everyone. That had always supplied the Concordance with its easiest defense. Tarn held one portion, Pellune another, Osel a third. The mesh damaged each account on the road, and the Authorized Census treated every mismatch as proof that the absent person had never belonged. Vey had built the shadow count by reversing that rule. A damaged name remained a name if two independent records carried its shape. An incomplete household stayed open rather than falling to zero. Uncertainty earned a mark in the margin, not removal from the page.

She took off her wet coat and sat before the table. "Show me the sending copy."

Cira turned a second screen toward her. "Blank. I opened the path. You fill it."

"No imported clean?"

"None that can touch this route without logging us first. We have to enter from paper and the isolated store. When you finish, I move the file into the raw head. From there it joins the open relay and repeats at every downstream beacon that still follows the old forwarding rule."

"And those that don't?"

"They'll receive the header before they decide to kill the body. That's why your header has to tell a Teller what follows and how to prove it. Give them enough to keep looking."

Vey set the Authorized Census on the left, the shadow ledger on the right, and Ossrey's recovered count between them. All her life, closing a census had meant reducing many pages to one figure. Tonight she had to do the opposite. A single figure would be easy to deny. She needed to send the arithmetic, the sources, the damaged lines, and the rule by which each person had entered.

She typed the first heading.

SPILL CENSUS, RECONCILED FROM OPEN LOCAL AND RELAY RECORDS. NO POPULATION REMOVED FOR CLASSIFICATION, CLAIM, OR FREQUENCY STATUS.

Under it she placed the date, SY 314, and Tarn's station mark. She left the authority line empty.

The human count came first because no honest correction began by pretending the sound portion of an old record had no value. Vey loaded the forty local totals carried in the latest authorized concordance. She preserved their dates and damage notes. Some had arrived within three years; others had spent almost twenty crossing the Spill and could only describe the people alive when they left. Beside each world she added a field the Authorized Census omitted: AGE OF COUNT AT RECEIPT. The oldest numbers did not become current by being printed without warning.

Tarn entered under its proper local total, one million two hundred and four thousand recorded in the last closed quarter, with the nineteen phantom entries removed from Tarn's column and held for restoration under their own wards. Vey paused over those nineteen. They had begun the work by appearing where they did not belong. The overnight clean had failed to swallow them, quarter after quarter, and their persistence had led her from the counting floor to the quarantined band. Now she moved them out of the error column and into the people who had sent them.

Ossa of the third weir went first. Pellin of the deep-household followed. Seventeen recovered names took their places beneath the Anver ward mark that Tarn had refused to recognize. Vey entered the sources beside each one: phantom roll, repeated sync, reopened frequency. Three proofs for lives once dismissed as residue.

The printer behind Cira began striking a warning onto narrow paper. CONTROLLER REVIEW PENDING. OUTBOUND PATH UNAUTHORIZED.

"It knows," Cira said.

"Does it know enough to stop us?"

"Not yet. Keep counting."

Vey returned to the human rolls. She added Yula's reconciliation where the distant census-taker had found a whole raft settlement omitted after its route tag corrupted. She restored the valid entries from Pellune's north table, including the

record of the Teller who had seen Vey's accidental fragment and asked for authority rather than cleaning it. Other replies carried smaller corrections: families filed as expired when a return packet had dropped their renewal; a shore ward recategorized as seasonal until its people lost standing; three migration rolls whose destinations survived while their persons did not.

She did not call every absence an erasure. Storms broke records. Clerks copied figures badly. The Static ate characters with no help from any Registrar. Each correction carried its source class so a receiving world could distinguish deliberate removal from damage and damage from an ordinary local error. Truth required the boundaries around knowledge as much as it required the names inside them.

Across the room, a relay clacked. Cira looked at the side screen.

"First local challenge. Redoubt controller wants the quarantine table restored."

"Can you refuse it?"

"I can make it argue with the founding forwarding rule. That rule outranks local quarantine if the packet carries standing."

Vey drew the old supplement from its envelope. The page had crossed a century in an archive because no later Concordance had repealed it. Founding peoples held access to the relay under their standing. She copied the clause beneath the census header and attached an image of the seal. Then she marked the Anver count as a filing by a founding people, not an exception from a human clerk.

Cira fed the clause into the route controller. The red warning lamps stopped moving for one breath. A green lamp appeared at the end of the row.

"It accepted the standing field," she said. "The old rule still fits the lock."

"They buried the key with the door."

"Good thing Bren reads drawers."

The controller began forwarding the header into its staging coil. Vey heard paper advance inside the outbound bank, a quick dry whisper under the hum. The route had opened. It would stay open until the body finished or the competing instruction found a way to close it.

Ossrey's count required the most care. The Anver did not arrange persons in the columns human registers expected. Their song held households as lines of pitch, wards as layered banks, and deaths as a lowering carried forward rather than a struck name. Cira's renderer had translated the structure without forcing it flat. Vey kept both forms. The original sonic marks went into the broadcast first, followed by the rendered text and a table explaining where the translation could not decide between a person, a household, and a line carried in memory for the dead.

The opening transmission contained far more than the nineteen Tarn had caught. Weirs continued across page after page. Deep-households appeared under

marks Vey recognized from the basalt-groove descriptions. Some records gave a living total. Others supplied births and deaths from an earlier count, then repeated the whole household until acknowledgment. No acknowledgment had returned for a hundred and thirty years.

Vey reconciled what could be reconciled. She did not invent a current number where the slow transmission offered none. She entered the confirmed living by household, placed dated lower bounds beside incomplete wards, and attached the Anver's own count as the governing record. The true census could admit that a people knew themselves better than the institution that had muted them.

Halfway through the fourth ward, she found Ossrey's keeper mark in the rendered lines. The name sat beside the listening stone and the long memory, source of repeated counts across several degraded arrivals. Vey entered it without decoration. One person, one record, one place in the Spill. The mark did not need her praise. It needed forwarding.

Beyond the Anver section waited the other erased. Yula's network had found them in quarantine tables and discarded concordance appendices: small human settlements written out when their claims complicated a border, remote wards that lost relay access and then vanished from the aggregate, people recorded under classifications that allowed a later clerk to call them non-continuing. Some entries had names. Others survived only as household totals with a location and date. Vey included both, but she did not pretend they carried equal certainty.

For each erased roll, she typed the last known count, the date sent, the local source, and the Concordance action that removed it. Where names survived, she entered names. Where a total alone remained, she entered a total and left the name field open. Where one source made an allegation no second record supported, she placed it in an attached list titled **REQUIRES LOCAL RECOUNT**. Nothing went to zero merely because the proof had arrived wounded.

One page from Callow named a settlement but carried no surviving household total. The Authorized Census listed the same place as vacated, while a later weather packet requested seed and medicine for people still living there. Vey could not turn that contradiction into a number. She entered the settlement under local recount, attached both records, and left its total unclosed. A blank displayed honestly asked for work. A zero claimed the work had ended.

Two damaged rolls from Thann posed the reverse problem. Their totals agreed, but the names had vanished in different sections. Vey kept the lower shared figure and added both fragments so a receiving clerk could rebuild the households from a cleaner local copy. The method felt slow because it was slow. Erasure had needed one classification. Restoration required evidence that could survive the hands waiting to call it rumor.

Cira crossed from the console with another warning slip. "A counter-instruction entered the fast local line. Kendt's seal. It orders the outbound bank isolated."

"How long before it executes?"

"The bank rejected it because the standing claim is active. It'll ask him to certify an emergency override. He can do that from the registrar's console if he reaches it."

"He knows we're here."

"Everyone with a Redoubt alarm knows we're here."

Vey looked at the remaining pages. "How much route time?"

"Maybe twenty minutes. Maybe two."

A census closed at the point where delay stopped improving it. Vey knew the rule from squall nights, when clerks waited for outer rafts to report while the filing bell approached. Wait too little and people fell out. Wait too long and no count left the platform at all. She checked the index against the source pages once more. Human local counts, retained. Anver records, restored. Other erased rolls, restored where evidence held and marked for recount where it did not. The standing clause and provenance tables followed. At the end she placed instructions for reconstruction after packet loss: repeat each section separately, preserve source marks, compare damaged copies, never clean an unmatched person without a local inquiry.

One field remained empty.

AUTHORITY FOR INCLUSION.

The question had come from Pellune years after the accidental leak. Kendt would fill the field with a seal if inclusion served the Authorized Census. Drase would fill it with consequence. Vey had no office above Tarn's counting floor and no authority to bind forty worlds.

She typed: LIVING RECORDS, ATTESTED BY THE PEOPLE AND LOCAL COUNTERS NAMED IN THE SOURCES.

Cira read over her shoulder. "No signature?"

"Mine goes on the preparation line. Not the authority."

"They'll call that a defect."

"Let them explain why a living person needs permission from an empty field."

Vey signed her name as compiler. Under it she added Bren as keeper of the paper source, Cira as Teller of the opened route, Yula and the distant counters by their surviving station marks, and Ossrey under the mark the Anver transmission used for keeper of long memory. The list of witnesses reached farther than any office.

At the foot of the file, the reconciliation produced a full count with dated bounds rather than one false current total. Vey read every subtotal aloud while Cira checked the packet measure. Forty human world rolls. The Anver wards recovered through the reopened band. Every other erased record their network could substantiate. Missing replies remained named as missing. Damaged lines remained visible. No quiet classification subtracted a person.

She saved the sending copy to the isolated store.

"This is the true census," Vey said. "Move it."

Cira returned to the console and keyed the transfer. The packet measure rose, stopped, and rose again as the outbound bank divided the file into pieces small enough for the mesh. Each piece received the same header and reconstruction table. If the Static ate half, the half that survived would teach a receiving Teller how to ask for the rest.

A hard knock struck the outer door. Someone tested the latch, then struck it again.

"Emergency override," Cira said, watching the controller. "Kendt certified. It reaches the bank in ninety seconds."

The first packet moved from staging to the raw head. On the side screen its route mark changed from LOCAL to FORWARD. A second followed. The old iron relays took up the work in sequence, cabinets closing contacts from left to right until the sound crossed the room like a measured line of falling counters.

Vey kept her eyes on the packet index. Header. Human rolls, first block. Human rolls, second. Standing clause. Anver source marks. Anver render. Erased appendices. Reconstruction rule. Witness list. The sending order placed proof beside every claim, so corruption could not easily leave an accusation without its record.

Outside, the pounding stopped. A key entered the lock.

"Forty seconds," Cira said.

The outbound measure held at sixty-three percent. Vey could do nothing to make the relay faster. She had spent two years repairing what speed and fear had damaged, and now the count had to submit to the old machinery, contact by contact, spool by spool. The mesh offered no clean leap across the Spill. It offered a chain of beacons, each one capable of carrying, losing, or refusing what had been sent.

The door opened against the chair Cira had wedged under its handle. Grey cloth showed in the gap. A shoulder pushed once, shifting the chair a finger's width across the floor.

Eighty-one percent.

Cira held the bypass leads down with one hand. "Override is in the controller."

"The bank?"

"Still forwarding. The command has to finish the current standing packet before isolation."

Ninety-four.

Vey thought of the nineteen names appearing in Tarn's wrong column as if the

count itself had refused the clean. She thought of the canvas ledger among dead deeds, the fragment that reached a distant Teller, Ossrey repeating a household count into a century without acknowledgment. None of those acts had moved quickly. They had persisted.

The measure reached one hundred.

For a moment nothing changed. Then the raw head stamped the final block FORWARD, and the first repeater beyond the Redoubt returned an automatic receipt. Not a world. Not an answer. One beacon on the long chain had taken the file and begun to carry it toward the next.

"It's sent," Cira said.

The emergency override closed the local outbound path. Red lamps filled the panel. Kendt's people forced the door wide, and the chair went over with a crack against the floorboards.

Across the side screen, beyond the closed path, the forwarding marks continued to advance. The first repeater passed the header. A second accepted it. Then a third route woke farther down the chain, old and slow and outside Tarn's reach. Each acknowledgment arrived with a little less of the original station mark, but the census header held.

Vey stood beside the printer while it struck the receipts onto paper. She did not ask when Osel or Pellune or Yula's world would receive the count. Years would pass. Packets would drop. Some stations would obey a new quarantine, while others would see the standing clause and forward before an order could arrive. The broadcast needed no instant audience. It needed copies beyond recall.

Kendt entered behind the grey escorts. His gaze went first to the dark outbound bank, then to the moving receipts, and Vey watched him understand the limit of the override. He could close Tarn. He could not reach into a beacon that had already repeated.

The Anver frequency remained open on the raw side of the controller. Its green line moved beneath the red warnings, crowded now with the outgoing count and the older song arriving through it. For the first time in a hundred and thirty years, the two records occupied the same band.

A fresh strip came out of the printer. FIRST HOP COMPLETE, it read. FORWARD CHAIN ACTIVE. Cira tore it free before the escorts reached the console and handed it to Vey.

Behind them, the Static carried the next block away from Tarn. On the strip in Vey's hand, under a route mark already losing its edges, the nineteen names had gone out with everyone else.

Part III

Interlude III — The Registrar's Memo

CONCORDANCE INTERNAL CIRCULATION

From: Senior Registrar Ollan Drase

To: Concordant Authorities; World Registrars; Teller Superintendents

Subject: Receipt and handling of the Tarn reconciliation

Classification: Operational review, not for deletion

This memo replaces the hold instruction issued under my seal in SY 314. Stations should preserve that instruction in sequence with this one. Removing the earlier order would conceal the change in policy and invite the same error now under review.

The broadcast originating at Tarn Redoubt has passed beyond practical recall. The Ledger-House can close a local transmitter, revoke a station seal, or direct an obedient Teller to discard a packet. It cannot withdraw copies already repeated onto separate routes. Attempts at suppression now increase circulation by creating disputes that require local copying. This office therefore directs registrars to cease treating possession of the Tarn reconciliation as relay interference.

Confirmed receipt stands as follows.

Osel received seven partial copies over two routes. Its counting office matched two hundred and eleven omitted persons against local ward books. Clerks have opened an Anver heading pending further testimony.

Kess received human correction tables, a damaged translation key, and Anver household marks in separate districts. Nine copies have been compared. The central council has not certified the result, but ward offices are using a revised table.

Pellune received nine copies over eleven months. Its council has recognized the transmission as evidence, acknowledged Anver founding standing, and preserved related water claims for review. No transfer of possession has occurred.

Vrey received sufficient human records to reopen forty-three kin-status corrections. Hospital offices are applying those corrections provisionally. The Anver portion remains under registrar examination.

Thann received a ward sign for a port settlement omitted from the Authorized Census. Local tax books and household witnesses support the settlement's continued existence. A recount has begun.

Callow received at least three independently printed copies. One provincial office destroyed a paper set; agricultural station logs retained the same tables. The erase order issued there has been withdrawn.

Further receipt remains probable on five outbound chains. Machine acknowledgments do not prove that a world has read the body, and silence does not prove refusal. Report only what local evidence supports. Do not improve a

damaged figure to make this summary cleaner.

The material varies in completeness. No receiving office possesses an untouched copy. Agreement among independently damaged versions nonetheless establishes that the broadcast carries deliberate records rather than random relay noise. Local archives have already confirmed enough human corrections to defeat a general allegation of fabrication. The Anver tables include household structures, source marks, repeated ward sequences, and founding clauses also found in sealed local instruments. Each item remains open to examination. Their combined presence cannot responsibly be classified as degradation.

Accordingly, the silence is broken.

That sentence requires precision. A broken silence does not settle every name, validate every claim, or compel immediate transfer of a human home. It means the Concordance can no longer defend exclusion by asserting that no people spoke on the quarantined frequency. They spoke. Our stations received them. Our procedures carried their signals dark, and our census treated the resulting absence as evidence.

I renewed those procedures. Responsibility should not be distributed so widely that no hand can be found inside it. The standing quarantine bears signatures from dead registrars, retired committees, and my own office. Mine remains legible. Preserve it.

The first institutional impulse will favor a narrower quarantine, followed by a corrected explanation of why the new packet should not count. I advise against both. Tarn attached reconstruction rules to the transmission. Different worlds can replace one another's losses, while every fresh prohibition supplies another document for comparison. Suppression has ceased to offer quiet. It now offers proof of intent.

A managed Reckoning carries grave risk, but management remains possible if we separate standing from remedy. Recognition answers who may speak and file. Remedy answers what follows from a proven claim. We hid the first question because we feared the second. That choice purchased a century of calm by transferring every unresolved consequence to the present.

Effective on receipt of this memorandum, registrars should take the following measures.

First, preserve every version of the Tarn reconciliation, including corrupt copies, local annotations, and prior orders to destroy or quarantine it. Provenance must remain visible.

Second, establish provisional census headings for Anver households and other supported omissions. A provisional entry grants access to review and relay without deciding property. Do not reduce an uncertain living count to zero.

Third, suspend evictions, seizures, water closures, or retaliatory changes of status founded solely on newly surfaced claims. The same suspension applies to

actions against Anver standing. No party gains safety from racing ahead of evidence.

Fourth, require local comparison. Ward books, founding deeds, tax rolls, mortality files, and raw Teller logs should be examined where they exist. The Ledger-House will publish damage tables rather than a single corrected master copy.

Fifth, open a claims register divided into acknowledgment, access, reparation, shared use, and possession. Combining those remedies under one heading invites the public to hear every filing as an order to abandon a city.

Sixth, reserve relay capacity for Anver testimony and for answers from affected worlds. A right to file without a route to speak would repeat the exclusion in a cleaner form.

No local authority should promise a final settlement before testimony can cross the Static. Years will pass between claim and answer. Interim agreements must therefore protect residents, preserve disputed records, and keep essential water systems operating. Delay cannot serve again as a disguised denial, but neither can distance be wished away by decree.

I expect objections from both directions. Some registrars will say these measures reward an unlawful broadcast. Others will say the Concordance has forfeited authority to supervise any remedy. Both objections carry force. Authority cannot be repaired by insisting it was never damaged. It may be earned in smaller units: preserving a page, admitting a signature, preventing one frightened council from turning an old claim into a present expulsion.

Thirty years ago, a duplicate inlet claim between Thann and Vrey remained open while messages crossed. Fishers cut markers. Crews answered with oars. Nine men died before our correction reached either shore. I built later policy around those nine because their names could be read and their deaths could be numbered. The people excluded by quarantine offered no casualty sheet to place beside them. We had arranged matters so that they could not.

This memorandum does not withdraw concern about conflict. Pellune's water instruments touch every household in its valleys. Tarn's platforms stand over founding waters. Other files will uncover claims no present council expects. Panic, opportunism, and refusal should be assumed. Preparations for mediation, food continuity, and protection of local archives should begin before formal petitions arrive.

Yet the feared conflict no longer lies on the far side of a choice to publish. Publication occurred. Our choice concerns whether forty isolated worlds meet the evidence through a common procedure or through contradictory rumors and hurried defenses. Managed reckoning offers no innocence. It offers sequence.

I have ordered the original quarantine file moved from restricted storage to the review room. The translation sheets archived as noise will follow it. Teller stations

are to retain the opened frequency under disputed standing until a concordant rule replaces quarantine with accountable routing. Any Registrar who disagrees should append reasons under a personal seal. Committee attribution will not suffice.

Before signing, I compared the latest receipt tally with the old Authorized Census. Six worlds have acted on records they were instructed not to possess. More will do so before this memo reaches them. The relay yards continue to print acknowledgments from chains our hold orders cannot overtake.

At the bottom of the quarantine renewal, my signature appears steady. I once took that steadiness for discipline. It now reads as duration.

Ollan Drase

Senior Registrar, Ledger-House

The memo entered the outbound queue beside the earlier hold order. On the paper drum, the hold departed first. Drase watched its route mark fade into the Static, then fed the new instruction after it, carrying the correction along the same slow road.

Chapter 20 — The Spill Recomputes

The census left Tarn as a long sequence of names, household marks, ward records, transmission fragments, and proofs of alteration. No world received all of it in the order Vey Corwin had sent it. The Static separated tables from headings, dropped dates, repeated pages, and put half a founding clause inside a mortality roll. Yet every relay copied what survived and sent it onward. A damaged count entered the mesh. A second damaged count followed another route. Where the copies met, missing parts returned.

For a hundred and thirty years, the Concordance had relied on loss. An isolated fragment could be called noise. A vanished name could be blamed on distance. The true census defeated that habit by arriving broken in different places. Osel received the names before the proofs. Kess received the proofs before the names. Pellune received an Anver household sequence three times, each version bitten through at a different point. Clerks who had spent their lives correcting Static damage knew how to lay such copies together.

They did what the work required. They recomputed.

Osel heard Tarn four years after the transmission entered the mesh.

The world's relay house stood among low fields of black stone, where heat collected during the day and bled upward after dark. Its night staff kept the windows open to protect the paper feeds from the cooling fans' dry breath. Three Tellers listened to the incoming band while a census clerk sorted the print into trays: trade, weather, deaths, claims, unusable.

At first the Tarn sequence went into unusable. Its header lacked a source seal, its first population table started at line forty-three, and the authorized routing marks had been overwritten by a repeating ward sign no Osel register recognized. The clerk placed both hands on the pages to stop the night wind from lifting them. Then another copy arrived from a northern relay chain. It began at line twelve and carried the same ward sign.

By morning, seven people had missed the end of their shifts. They covered the sorting table with paper and pinned the corners under tool boxes. One Teller read the numbers aloud while another marked agreements in blue. The census clerk used red for disagreement. Almost every red mark aligned with visible corruption. Almost every blue mark restored a line that one of the copies had lost.

The senior registrar came down after sunrise. She wore the gray collar of the Concordance and brought two orderlies with a document case. She did not ask what had kept the staff.

“Close the band,” she said.

A Teller kept his pencil on the page. “On what fault?”

“False provenance. No Ledger-House seal.”

“It has forty-one local seals.”

“Copied marks prove forwarding, not truth.”

The census clerk turned over the next sheet. Osel's own table filled it. The authorized total appeared first. Under it ran a second total, larger by two hundred and eleven. Each additional person had a district, a household, and a correction date. Some dates reached back eighty years.

The registrar read the first six names. Her orderlies watched her collar rather than the page.

Osel kept duplicate ward books in stone vaults because summer fires had once crossed the fields and taken a generation of records. The clerk requested the oldest volumes. The registrar denied the request. A vault keeper brought them anyway, pushing a handcart whose iron wheels struck every seam in the relay-house floor.

They checked the first added name against a ward book from SY 237. The person had lived. A marriage mark connected her to two households still present on Osel. A later hand had crossed through the entry and written TRANSFER ERROR, though no transfer destination followed. The second name held the same pattern. So did the third.

At noon, the registrar moved the document case onto the disputed pages.

“Possessing an unauthorized census creates no standing,” she said. “Copying one may constitute relay interference.”

Across the table, the vault keeper opened another old book. “Does living create standing?”

"That question exceeds your office."

"It exceeded theirs too, by the look of this."

The first citizens arrived before the relay house closed its doors. Someone on night staff had sent a local message to the ward halls. Same-world wires carried it in minutes. Families came with household certificates. Two brought death notices for people whose names appeared in the Tarn count. One man carried a photograph plate wrapped in cloth and set it beside the entry for his grandmother's sister. He had known the story of her. He had never known that Osel's census once held her and later chose not to.

Officials sealed the outer desk. Citizens waited on the black-stone steps through the heat of afternoon. The registrar drafted a warning, withdrew it, then drafted a narrower one that prohibited destruction or public reading until review. By then copies had reached four ward halls.

Osel's counting office met that evening without the gray collars. It did not declare the Tarn transmission lawful. It did not need to. The staff opened the local total, restored the two hundred and eleven documented people to the historical register, and created a new heading for the unfamiliar households carried after them.

ANVER, the heading read.

Beneath it, clerks entered the first surviving names exactly as the broken pages gave them. Blank spaces remained where every copy had failed. They did not fill those spaces with guesses. For the first time in a hundred and thirty years, Osel marked the blanks as records awaiting testimony rather than errors awaiting deletion.

Kess received the count in winter.

Snow had narrowed the roads to brown tracks between white fields. Census duty came after harvest there, when people had time to stand at a ward desk and account for births, deaths, departures, and changes of roof. Cess went to the same room where, years earlier, she had watched a neighbor corrected off the list. The clerk then had spoken of routine. Cess had accepted the word because routine passed for explanation when everyone in line wanted to go home.

This year the line reached outside.

A printed notice had been nailed beside the ward door. It announced a delay in certification due to contradictory material received through the Static. Someone had written names around its edges. More names continued onto the wall, first in pencil, then chalk, then the purple ink used for seed orders. The neighbor's name stood near the hinge.

Inside, three desks had become six. Clerks drew files from cabinets that had not been opened during ordinary duty. At the back of the room, a local official read a

statement saying Kess had not accepted the validity of the so-called true census. Each time he reached "so-called," the sorting machine behind him struck another stack of paper into its tray.

Cess brought her household card to the nearest desk.

"Any births?" the clerk asked.

"No."

"Deaths?"

"No."

"Unresolved corrections?"

She looked toward the door. "Since when do you ask that?"

"Since this morning."

Cess gave the neighbor's name. The clerk found it before she finished spelling. A thin file contained the yearly entries that should have carried him forward through the census. Every page showed the same house, occupation, and kin. The final sheet carried a correction code with no cause attached.

"He died three winters ago," Cess said.

"Do you have a witness?"

"I saw him planted."

The clerk added a death date, then restored the missing years between correction and burial. No bell sounded. No officer came to approve the change. A person absent from the Authorized Census returned to Kess's history through one line of dark ink.

Around her, the room performed the same repair. Citizens who had come to satisfy duty stayed to name people dropped in earlier years. They remembered a field worker transferred nowhere, an infant recorded without a household, an old woman whose roof had changed wards while her body had not moved. The clerks asked for certificates when certificates existed and witnesses when paper had failed. They left disputed lines open.

The official at the back raised his voice. "This office has authorized no public recomputation."

A woman in a wet farm coat answered without turning from her desk. "Then authorize more chairs."

People carried in benches from the meeting hall.

By the third day, the Tarn pages had reached every district office on Kess. Damage differed from copy to copy. One district lacked the human amendments but held the Anver founding records. Another received household counts from the deeps with no translation key. A school copy included the key and none of the counts. Couriers moved bundles over the winter roads because local wires could carry a summary but not thousands of degraded marks without adding fresh

errors.

Kess's central council ordered ward clerks to suspend the pages. Half obeyed. The others filed the order behind the new witness forms and continued. No crowd broke the council doors. No one set fire to a registrar's collar. Farmers went home to feed animals; mill workers took the late shift; children pressed wet gloves against stove pipes. Then they returned on the next duty day with family papers tied in string.

Cess returned too. She had spent years knowing nothing about the Anver. Now the ward wall held a careful public explanation: non-human people of settled waters, present in founding records, excluded by successive corrections, still living in their own deeps. The notice included a household pattern rendered in raised dots and long bars. Human voices could not produce its source tones, but a hand could follow the marks.

A boy beside Cess traced one bar without touching the paper.

"How many?" he asked.

The clerk did not offer an invented total. "Enough that they counted themselves. Fewer than the old records. More than zero."

Kess's Authorized Census remained posted above the sorting machine. For six days, a second sheet hung beside it under the plain label RECEIVED COUNT. On the seventh, the head clerk took both down. She returned with one revised table. Its total included the restored people of Kess and a separate acknowledged count for the Anver, with ranges wherever the Static had damaged a figure.

The council had not approved the table. It sent two officers to remove it. They found a room full of citizens holding numbered places in line, each waiting to correct a record. One officer read the Anver heading twice. The other asked the head clerk whether the founding entries could be verified.

"Not from one copy," she said. "From nine, yes."

The officers left the table on the wall.

Pellune received nine copies over eleven months.

Its cities occupied the sheltered sides of steep valleys, linked by rail lines and cable lifts. The relay station stood above the highest terminus, where ice formed on the receiving frames even in summer. Static damage often reached Pellune as long white absences in the print. Its Tellers had become skilled at reading around a gap without pretending to read through it.

The first copy of Tarn's transmission contained a list of water claims and almost no names. Pellune's claim office classified it as a legal hazard and locked it in a steel drawer. The second carried names without the clause that explained them. A junior clerk noticed that their household marks matched symbols cut into the oldest reservoir deeds.

Pellune had no open sea. It held water in mountain basins, tunnels, cisterns, and deep public tanks. The founding deeds treated those waters as leased rather than possessed. No living official could say from whom the first settlers had leased them. Standard copies left the grantor line blank.

The Tarn pages supplied an answer.

Senior officials gathered in the valley council chamber. They brought claim lawyers, water engineers, census supervisors, and two Concordance representatives. Citizens filled the upper gallery after a reservoir worker released the first copied deed on a local bulletin line. The council president called the release irresponsible. The worker, seated between two guards, asked whether the original blank had shown greater care.

A claim lawyer laid the surviving copies across the central table. He did not argue that each mark deserved trust. Instead, he showed where independent relay routes agreed. The founding date survived in seven copies. An Anver household seal survived in five. Language granting shared use of the basin waters appeared in four, with no two copies missing the same words. Pellune's archived deed supplied every gap except the name of the grantor, erased from the standard record by a clean rectangular scrape.

One Concordance representative urged delay until the Ledger-House issued a certified response. A Teller explained that any such response would take years to reach Pellune and might cross the same relay chains now under dispute.

"Then we wait," the representative said.

"For permission to read paper already here?" asked the council president.

The representative had no procedural answer.

Outside the chamber, the cable lifts kept moving. Reservoir crews measured winter reserves. Households filled kettles from pipes laid through stone generations before anyone alive had learned the word Anver. News of the claim did not empty the streets. It changed the questions asked at the public taps.

Some citizens feared eviction from the valleys. Others demanded that every old agreement be voided before distant claimants could use it. A group of reservoir workers answered by publishing the whole surviving deed, including the shared-use language. Students marked its gaps against all nine copies. Lawyers who had first warned of dispossession found clauses requiring access, maintenance, and accounting rather than abandonment. Nothing in the recovered text ordered humans out. Nothing allowed them to pretend they had arrived first.

Pellune's council sat for two days. On the first, it recognized the transmission as evidence. On the second, it amended the local census instructions. The amendment named the Anver as a counted people with founding standing and directed the water office to preserve every related claim until contact became possible.

The vote did not settle ownership. It opened records that had been closed before

any council member's birth.

At the high relay station, a Teller added Pellune's amended table to the outbound band. She knew years would pass before the nearest world received it. She also knew copied truth traveled better than guarded truth. Three routes carried the table away, each with the source papers attached.

Elsewhere, receipt took other forms.

Vrey's hospital registrars found forty-three patients whose grandparents had lost kin status through a correction series. Thann's port clerks restored a settlement that existed in tax books but not in the Authorized Census. On Callow, an official burned one incoming copy in a furnace and discovered that two agricultural stations had already printed it. The Ledger-House sent hold orders down relay routes that now carried more copies than orders.

In Vrey's main hospital, restored kin status changed who could sign a treatment paper, collect a body, or inherit a room. The chief registrar warned that the Tarn count lacked legal certification. A nurse placed three local birth books on his desk, each showing the same deleted family line. Certification had not removed those people from the world. It had removed their grandchildren from the chairs beside sickbeds. Before the chief registrar decided, hospital clerks began accepting the old kin marks provisionally. Families brought food and blankets to relations whom the authorized forms had treated as strangers.

Along Thann's port, the missing settlement occupied six streets behind a breakwater. Its residents had paid harbor levies for seventy years while census maps colored their district as storage ground. The received count gave the place a ward sign and linked that sign to hundreds of names. Port officials arrived to inventory the supposed warehouses. They found kitchens, roof gardens, school slates, and a line of residents holding levy receipts. By evening, the officials had replaced their inventory forms with household sheets. The district chose two witnesses for every roof and counted itself before the tide turned.

Callow's agricultural stations compared their copies over local wire. The furnace had taken paper, not the repeated tables stored in operator logs. When a provincial office ordered the stations to erase those logs, one operator read the order aloud during the daily crop report. Farmers who had never entered a relay room asked why a census required burning. The provincial official withdrew the erase order and called it a drafting mistake. Twelve stations printed the disputed pages before night, then put one set in seed vaults built to survive fire.

Not every world accepted the count. Some sealed it. Some called its Anver tables a Tarn invention designed to weaken old claims. A few published human corrections while hiding non-human names. In each place, however, the argument had changed. Concordance officials could no longer point to an empty frequency and call it absence. Citizens could ask for the received pages. Tellers could

compare routes. Census workers could place a deleted line beside the old book from which it had been deleted.

The true census did not arrive as one commanding voice. It came as stacks on floors, scraps pinned under tools, copied tables carried over winter roads, and bars of household song rendered in ink. People disputed it line by line. That dispute kept the record in motion. Every objection required another reading, every denial produced another local copy, and every attempt to isolate a page sent citizens looking for the rest.

Across the Spill, official totals changed at different speeds. Osel appended names before its registrar conceded. Kess posted a revised table while its council still debated jurisdiction. Pellune acknowledged standing before it knew what claims would follow. Other worlds waited, refused, restored, or copied. None could return to the earlier blank without leaving the act visible.

The receipt of the true census did not arrive as a single moment. It arrived as a hundred small corrections, each one landing on a different world in a different year, each one reshaping a local count that had been quiet about the Anver for a century. On Osel a council clerk stared at the new heading and went looking for the old ledgers, and found them altered in a hand she did not recognize. On Pellune a child learning the count asked why the Anver had not been named before, and was told a story that had not been true. The Spill recomputed itself in pieces, the way a tide rearranges a shore one stone at a time, and the shore did not notice the change until the map no longer matched the ground. Vey would not live to see all of it. She had sent the sequence knowing that the sending was the only part she could own, and that the receiving would belong to strangers she would never meet, on worlds she would never stand on, counting people she had decided to give back their names. The reckoning she had been warned against had come, and it looked not like a war but like a thousand quiet corrections, each one a name restored to a count that had pretended the name was never spoken.

Years after Tarn sent the sequence, the outer relay chains still carried partial copies. A Teller at an unnamed station received one page containing no human figures at all. Only the Anver heading survived, followed by six household marks and a damaged line from the founding count. She checked the Authorized Census beside her console. It held no matching heading.

She did not discard the page. She opened the station's public register, entered the six marks, and left space beneath them for the next copy. When morning staff arrived, fresh paper had already begun to feed from the receiver. The first line printed cleanly. It carried a seventh name.

Chapter 21 — The Reckoning Begins

By the time the council called Vey Corwin to give evidence, three versions of the Anver claim had already crossed Halversand. One said they meant to empty every

human platform into the sea. Another said they had waived the northern basins in exchange for a private relay band. The third had them arriving in ships, though no ship had crossed between worlds since before Vey's grandparents were born.

None had come from an Anver.

Vey carried the founding supplement under her coat and the true census in a canvas case. She left the Counting House before the second bell, crossed two raft bridges, and joined the line moving toward the council platform. Wind worried the notices tied to the railings. Some bore the new total for Tarn with the restored households included. Others had been pasted over them during the night: OUR WATER, OUR HOMES. A clerk in a blue ward coat scraped at one with a shell knife and managed to remove only the word HOMES.

The council platform rode lower than the counting floor because a crowd had gathered along all four approaches. Oyster crews stood beside household petitioners, relay hands, market sellers, and people who seemed to have come to see whether a legal clause could tip a city. Grey-coated Concordance staff occupied a strip beside the eastern rail. They carried no seals. Since the true census had entered Tarn's register, a seal could close a cabinet but could not close the number inside it.

Pell waited at the foot of the chamber stair. He wore his Counting House coat and held a sheaf of ward totals against the wind.

"They're asking whether the count changes ownership by itself," he said.

"It doesn't."

"I told them that. They preferred the rumor."

Vey looked past him to the people packed along the rail. A woman from the north raft line had brought two children and a deed in an oilskin sleeve. A basin farmer held a board painted with the map of his weirs. Neither looked eager for an argument about ancient standing. They wanted to know whether they would sleep in the same rooms after the vote.

"Then we tell them again," Vey said.

Pell gave her the tired look he reserved for work that could not be finished by the bell. "Today they may hear it."

Inside, the chamber smelled of wet wool and lamp oil. Tarn's seven councillors sat behind a curved table built from the ribs of a retired counting raft. The public benches had filled before dawn. Cira stood near the relay clerk's desk with a spool case at her feet and ink across two fingers. Bren occupied the back row, holding the archive box that contained the original supplement. He had wrapped it against spray as if old paper, rather than law, faced the greater danger.

Vey took the witness chair. It had been fixed to the floor with four bolts, a sensible choice on a tidal world. Before her lay three documents: Tarn's revised local census, the recovered founding index, and the council motion granting the

restored Anver households standing before Tarn's public offices. The motion did not transfer a basin. It did not settle damages. It admitted that a claimant existed and could be heard.

That narrow distinction had drawn half the city to the rails.

The council speaker struck the table once. "We are not deciding ownership today. We are deciding whether the persons entered in the true census may appear before this council as persons with standing. Census-taker Corwin, you will explain the basis for their entry."

Vey opened the canvas case. The first page carried nineteen names, the phantoms that had returned to Tarn's roll quarter after quarter. Later pages carried households recovered from the quiet frequency, then reconciled counts from the network beyond Tarn. The figures remained low. Corruption had taken more names than any census-taker could restore. She stated the limits before anyone else could use them against the whole.

"The count includes only entries supported by two independent records," she said. "A relay fragment and an old roll. Two fragments with separate route marks. A household transmission and an archived index. Where we had one source, we marked the entry unconfirmed. Where we had none, we made no entry. This count understates the living. It does not invent them."

A councillor from the northern platforms lifted the first page. "Nineteen names began this. You now ask us to recognize thousands across the Spill."

"The nineteen names exposed the omission. They did not measure its size."

"And Tarn's portion?"

"We have three hundred twelve supported living entries tied to the northern basins, with more unresolved. The broader Anver count came from transmissions released when Tarn Redoubt opened the quarantined frequency. Some records began their journey years ago. They did not answer our broadcast overnight. We stopped preventing their old messages from arriving."

Cira bent over the relay clerk's table and set a route sheet beneath the council lamp. The dates ran back six years. Every packet bore a forwarding mark, a quarantine diversion, and, after the breach, a delivery mark. Nothing in the sequence moved faster than the Static allowed. Tarn had heard old words because the locked drawer had finally opened.

The northern councillor read the dates without comment. Beside him, the council's water assessor turned the founding supplement with gloved fingers.

"This index says the Anver held the basins before Tarn's settlement," the assessor said. "It also says founding standing was never repealed. Yet no Anver household has appeared before a Tarn office in a hundred and thirty years. How does an office hear someone who cannot come here?"

"The same way Tarn asks another world to correct a count," Vey said. "Through

the relay, slowly and in writing. A delay does not make the sender absent."

Murmurs passed across the benches. The woman with the deed held it closer to her chest. Somewhere outside, a board struck a railing in a steady rhythm until a council guard asked the holder to stop.

The speaker turned to Vey. "If we pass this motion, what happens before sunset?"

"The Anver entries remain in Tarn's local census. Their filings receive docket numbers instead of rejection marks. The relay clerk accepts their traffic under the same loss rules as any distant claimant. No deed changes hands today. No platform moves."

"And after sunset?"

"People argue over what the filings require."

A short laugh came from the public benches. It held no humor, but it loosened the room enough for several people to breathe.

The northern councillor did not laugh. "You make that sound small. A founding claim reaches under every charter in my district. Families bought those charters in good faith. Crews built their weirs where Tarn told them to build. We can recognize a wrong and still refuse to make another one."

Vey looked at the oilskin deeds along the benches. "Standing does not decide which remedy follows. It decides whether the first wrong can be spoken in the room where remedies are decided. If you deny standing because the remedy may be difficult, you repeat the method that hid the count."

"Method is a clerk's word. My district calls it a home."

"Then their homes belong in the hearing too. So does the people counted out of it for a century."

Pell shifted beside the witness rail, but he did not interrupt. He had once warned Vey that restoring the Anver would start a thing no one on Tarn could close. The room had proved him right. It had not proved the work wrong.

Bren brought the archive box forward when called. He removed the split-spined supplement and placed it on a felt pad. The old seal had cracked along one edge, yet its mark remained readable. He explained where the volume had rested, how the live census stopped binding the index after the first erasures, and why the order to omit it carried no repeal.

"Archives hold dead claims," the water assessor said.

"They hold closed claims," Bren replied. "This one never closed. Someone stopped opening the book."

That answer stirred the chamber more than Vey's figures had. A legal silence could be mistaken for a settlement until an archivist put the unsettled paper beneath a lamp.

The speaker called a recess before the vote. Doors opened, and the crowd spilled onto the council platform in a wet press of coats. Vey stayed near the wall while ward officers tried to keep the approaches clear. Across the western bridge, basin crews had tied their workboats three deep. Their painted boards named leases, mortgages, and generations on the water. On the eastern side, students from the relay school held copies of the true census above their heads, each page protected in waxed cloth.

Between them stood people who had not chosen a side. They read both sets of boards and asked clerks what standing meant.

A fish seller recognized Vey and caught her sleeve. "My stall sits on North Seven. My mother's charter says perpetual. Does their first paper cancel ours?"

"Not today," Vey said.

"Tomorrow?"

"A claim has to state what it asks. Then the council answers. Then both sides can contest the answer."

The seller frowned toward the chamber. "That's not no."

"No."

"I liked no better."

She released Vey's sleeve and went to stand beside the woman with the oilskin deed. Vey could not offer calm by lying about the process. The old count had purchased calm that way, one omission at a time, until peace required an entire people to remain unheard.

Near the eastern rail, Cira had opened her spool case on a dry crate. "Redoubt found another held packet," she said when Vey approached. "Route date is four years before the breach. It carries the founding index mark and a structured petition header. Most of the body survived because the quarantine stored it instead of forwarding it."

"A petition for Tarn?"

"Address block names the northern basins. The sender line carries Ossrey's household mark and six other marks. Translation desk is checking the water terms. If council grants standing, the clerk can accept it. If they don't, procedure sends it back into exception storage."

Four years before the breach, the Anver had prepared an answer to a question Tarn had not admitted it could hear. The message had crossed part of the Spill, reached the quarantine, and waited inside the Redoubt while Vey copied phantom names from a margin. Their first filing did not depend on a quick miracle from the Static. It had arrived early and been made late by policy.

"How much do they ask?" Vey said.

"Not enough of the body is certified yet. I saw three headings. Recognition of founding water. Access to their frequency. Accounting for use since the erasure."

Cira closed the spool case as a drop of rain struck the lid. "No order to throw Halversand into the sea, if that's what you're asking."

"I wasn't."

"Everyone else is."

The rain thickened. Council guards drew canvas over the public entry, and the two groups on the bridges pressed closer without mixing. One basin crew began a chant about human water. A relay student answered with the names from the first restored page. Neither side advanced. Their voices struck the chamber walls and broke apart in the wind.

When the bell recalled them, the councillors returned with rain on their shoulders. The speaker read the motion in full. Its language admitted every person and household restored by the true census to the protections of Tarn's counting law. It recognized the founding index as evidence eligible for hearing. It ordered public dockets for claims carried on the opened Anver frequency. A final provision barred seizure or eviction until a claim had been heard and a remedy entered.

The northern councillor had added that last line. Vey saw his hand beside it in the margin.

Public comment ran for an hour. A weir owner said his family had made a life where the first census marked open water. A Teller read the route history of the held packets. The woman with the oilskin deed asked whether Anver families possessed deeds of their own, and Bren held up the founding index. A dock worker asked who would pay reparations if the council granted them. No one answered him. A school clerk asked why children had learned forty human worlds and no water people. No one answered her either.

Pell spoke last. He did not take the witness chair. He stood beside the public rail with his hands on the ward totals.

"I supervised the count that rejected these entries," he said. "I called them residue when I knew they came from a held frequency. I believed silence would spare Tarn an argument like this one. It did. It spared us the argument and kept the debt. Those are the figures I can certify."

He set the ward totals on the clerk's table and returned to his place.

The vote proceeded by name. Four councillors favored the motion. Two opposed it. The northern councillor waited while rain ticked against the shutters. He looked toward the deeds on one side of the chamber and the true census on the other.

"For standing," he said. "Against any remedy entered without the present households heard."

The clerk marked the seventh vote.

Outside, the result moved through the crowd before the speaker finished reading it. A cheer rose from the eastern bridge. The basin crews answered with shouts, and one workboat cast off so hard its stern struck the next boat in line. A

mooring post split. People stumbled as the platform took the strain. Guards cleared the gap while two deckhands caught the loose line with hooks. No one went into the water.

Within the chamber, the motion became an order through ordinary acts. The speaker signed. The clerk sanded the ink. A copy went to the Counting House. Another went by local line to Tarn Redoubt. Vey watched Cira receive the delivery mark on a portable printer, tear off the strip, and carry it to the relay desk.

The council had acknowledged the Anver. The room remained standing. So did Halversand.

At the fourth hour after the vote, Vey returned to the Counting House to enter the order. The floor had not closed. Clerks remained at their desks, though little counting got done. Petitioners crowded the stair, asking for copies of the motion or forms to protect their current charters. Pell moved between desks assigning extra hands to the public counter. His caution had found a new use. Instead of warning Vey away from a line, he kept frightened people from being pushed out of it.

The local register accepted the standing code on its second attempt. On the first, an old Concordance rule rejected the Anver household marks as unauthorized. Vey opened the rule table, attached the council order, and ran the entry again. The machine clicked for nearly a minute. Then the first restored household acquired the same hearing field every Tarn household carried.

Cira's petition arrived on the fast line from the Redoubt before dusk. The transmission itself had taken years to reach Tarn. Its movement from one Tarn office to another took less than an hour. The packet came with gaps marked rather than guessed, seven sender marks, and the certification of two translation hands. At its head stood the old founding index number Vey had copied from the split-spined supplement.

She read the surviving requests. The Anver asserted prior holding of Tarn's northern basins. They asked Tarn to recognize that holding in every future water charter, restore permanent relay access, provide an accounting of harvest and settlement use during the erasure, and begin negotiation over repair. One damaged line might have concerned physical return of water. The translators left it open.

There was no demand for the platforms to empty by morning. There was no waiver either.

The public counter clerk brought Vey the new docket book. Its pages had been ruled for local household disputes, with narrow columns for claimant, respondent, property, and remedy. The Anver petition did not fit. Seven household marks filled the claimant line. The property description continued onto a second page. Under respondent, Vey wrote Council of Tarn and present charter holders, notice pending. Under remedy, she copied only what the transmission supported and marked the

missing portion unresolved.

A crowd watched from the other side of the counter. The fish seller from the council platform stood in front, with the north-line woman and her two children behind. Cira leaned against the stair post, exhausted and alert. Bren held the founding supplement under one arm. Pell had stopped moving long enough to see the entry made.

Vey placed the council order beside the petition and checked the route dates once more. Count, standing, founding record, requested remedy. The sequence closed. She lowered the stamp.

The first claim entered Tarn's docket with a sound no louder than a book shutting.

For a moment nobody spoke. Then the counter clerk pulled the next form toward him. A basin cooperative wanted notice rights in the hearing. The relay school sought a rule protecting the opened frequency. Two northern households filed to preserve occupancy while ownership remained disputed. At the back of the line, a man argued that the council lacked authority to recognize a nonhuman claimant. A woman beside him asked for a copy of the Anver count before deciding whether she agreed.

Vey blotted the first docket page and turned it so the ink would not transfer. Through the open shutters came the noise of Halversand taking positions: boat horns, ward bells, arguments crossing the gangways, clerks calling numbers from one office to another. No platform had sunk. No debt had vanished. The old order had promised peace by keeping the docket empty, and the new one offered no such promise.

On the page, beneath the seven household marks, the filing clerk wrote HEARING REQUIRED in fresh black ink. He opened the book to the next line while the queue bent down the stair and out into the rain.

Chapter 22 — What the Counted Owe

The doors of the Counting House opened before the second-hour bell, and no clerk stood in them to ask a visitor's business. Someone had taken down the narrow board that divided the public room from the counting floor. Its brass hooks remained in the posts, pale circles marking where the wood had kept citizens on one side and the books on the other. Vey watched two dock workers step through the gap. Both slowed as if a rule might still catch at their coats.

On the central wall, a fresh notice carried the order of Tarn's council. LOCAL CENSUS OPEN FOR INSPECTION. ALL ENTRIES AND CORRECTIONS TO SHOW SOURCE, DATE, AND RESPONSIBLE HAND. OBJECTIONS HEARD DAILY AT THE NINTH HOUR. Beneath those lines, in smaller type, the order admitted the Anver to standing and directed every Tarn office to preserve claims filed under the true

census until they could be heard. The first claim had arrived the day before. It asked for no platform to be abandoned and no family put off the water. It asked Tarn to produce the founding maps it had spent a century treating as dead paper.

The request had frightened the council more than a demand might have. A demand could be refused. A map could be opened.

Vey crossed the floor carrying a tray of blank objection forms. She set it beside the public copy of the register, where anyone could read it without a clerk leaning over a shoulder. Yesterday the volume had sat behind the senior desks. This morning its stand faced the doors.

Nothing in the room looked changed enough for what had happened. The same slanted desks held the same ink pots. Salt had worked white lines into the shutters. The bell rope hung beside the supervisor's office, dark from years of hands. Yet the overnight clean had been disconnected from Tarn's register, and each alteration now remained visible beneath the line it changed. No mark could vanish into a corrected total. A clerk could strike an entry, but the struck name would stay legible, along with the clerk's reason and the evidence offered.

That rule had taken Vey six days to write and the council three hours to weaken. She had put the missing clauses back in during the public reading. Pell had sat behind her without speaking while two councilors argued that an open book would invite false claims. When the vote came, he had raised his hand for her wording.

Now his upper office stood empty.

The bell rang. Clerks took their places, but the old flat chant did not begin. Instead, the senior at the first desk read the new procedure aloud to the people gathered inside the hooks. Every household could inspect its entry. Every person could ask what source supported a change. No objection would be cleaned away at the close of a quarter. Where the record disagreed with the person, both versions would remain until evidence settled the matter.

A fish seller in a waxed coat lifted her hand. "Who decides what counts as evidence?"

"The clerk receiving it makes a finding," the senior said. "The finding carries a name. You may appeal it at the ninth hour."

"To the same House?"

Vey answered from the register stand. "To three readers. One clerk, one archive keeper, and one citizen drawn from the daily roll. Their reasons go in the book too."

The fish seller considered this. "So if you tell me no, I get to read why."

"Yes."

"And who told you yes?"

Vey pointed to the council order. "Their names are at the bottom."

The woman went to read them.

For years the Counting House had made authority look like tidiness. A closed column suggested a settled world. A printed total concealed every crossed line that produced it. The new procedure offered no such comfort. Beside the register lay a corrections volume thick enough for decades, though it held six days. People had come with misspelled household names, births filed to the wrong platform, deaths entered twice, and one child whom a moving raft had carried between wards while both wards assumed the other had counted him. None of those mistakes approached the erasure carried in the Authorized Census. Each had still altered a life.

At the third desk, the child's two ward clerks sat together and entered him once. They left both earlier errors visible. His mother watched the ink dry before she thanked them.

Vey had expected anger on the first open morning. What came instead required more work. People brought folded notices, family books, old ration chits, salt-stiff letters from lost crews. They had lived with small disagreements between themselves and the register because they had believed the register could not listen. Once it listened, they spoke all at once.

By the fourth hour, the objection tray stood empty. A junior clerk tore paper into halves to keep the line moving. Bren arrived from the archive with a handcart of household rolls and stopped where the board had been.

"You took down my best shelf," he said.

"It kept people out."

"It held twenty years of closed quarters."

"Then find them another wall."

Bren looked at the line winding between the desks. "The archive has spent a hundred years finding room for what this floor calls closed. I suppose the floor can learn."

He pushed his cart through the pale hook marks. On top lay the first founding maps requested under the Anver claim, each wrapped in tissue and tied against the wet. He had not hidden them or sent copies with convenient gaps. The council's receiving clerk signed for the whole bundle in front of the public register.

A murmur followed the maps across the room. No one ran. No platform broke loose from its chains. The claim remained a claim, unanswered and alive.

Vey marked the time of transfer in the open log. When she looked up, Pell stood in the doorway with a long ledger under one arm.

He wore no supervisor's cord. He had removed it after the council hearing, though no order required him to. Without the braided grey at his shoulder, he looked less like a man relieved of office than one who had left part of his coat in another room. He waited beside the hooks until the line gave him space.

"Corwin," he said.

"Pell."

His gaze moved over the public register, the objection line, and the founding maps disappearing toward the council table. "You opened early."

"People were waiting."

"They used to wait until the ninth hour, and then we sent half of them home."

"I remember."

He shifted the ledger in his arms. Its leather had gone soft at the corners, and a faded band on the spine read NORTH CURRENT CASUALTIES, SY 300-304. Vey knew the hand that had lettered it. She had carried that book from desk to desk for a year after Brenn failed to come home.

For a moment the room contracted around the volume. The public voices continued, chairs scraped, and the sea pressed against the platform piles below. Vey heard each sound separately. Her brother's absence had always entered that way, not as grief arriving fresh, but as a familiar room narrowing without warning.

"Where did you get that?" she asked.

"Bren brought it up from the sealed run." Pell glanced toward the archive keeper, who had found a stack to sort at the far desk and had turned his back with care. "I asked him for it."

"Why?"

"Because you wrote a procedure for correcting old closures." Pell put the casualty ledger on the stand beside the open register. "And because there is a line in here I should have lifted ten years ago."

Vey did not touch the cover. "You told me you weren't the one who crossed him."

"I wasn't."

"You also told me you didn't lift the pen."

"I didn't." His careful voice offered no shelter now. "The senior closed the north-current list at forty-three. Your brother should have made forty-four. His crew mark reached the floor after certification because the recovery launch stayed out through two tides. I knew the late notice existed. I knew you had asked for the list to be reopened. I let the senior tell you a closed quarter could not be changed."

The account matched what Vey remembered, but Pell's possession of it changed the shape. Ten years ago she had thought him one more supervisor who had heard a junior census-taker asking after a family matter and forgotten by the next bell. Later, when he admitted knowing about Brenn, she had understood that he had witnessed the closure. She had not known he had seen the late crew notice itself.

"You could have corrected it," she said.

"Yes."

No warning followed. He did not tell her which senior he would have crossed or

what such a correction might have cost his place. The single answer left him nowhere to stand except beside the omission.

Around them, Tarn brought its errors to the desks. A rope maker argued over a daughter placed in the wrong household. Two raft wardens compared storm lists. At the public copy, the fish seller traced the councilors' names with one blunt finger.

Pell opened the casualty book. Forty-three entries filled the quarter, each carrying a crew, a last known position, and a finding. Beneath them, a ruled space had been scraped and inked over. The erasure had roughened the paper. Against the light, Vey could see the beginning of a B and the long downstroke she had once tried to prove belonged to her family name.

Tucked inside the back cover lay a separate notice on recovery-launch stock. NORTH CURRENT CREW N-17. ONE UNRETURNED: BRENN CORWIN. The launch master's mark remained sharp. A receiving clerk had dated it two days after the quarter closed.

"This sat with the ledger?" Vey asked.

"In the same archive box. Filed as late material, no action."

"For ten full years."

"It stayed there for ten years."

She read the notice twice. It gave her nothing she had not known in her body. Brenn had gone north. His crew had returned without him. The sea had kept him. Yet the old anger did not arrive with the force she expected. The paper proved no mystery. It proved a choice made small enough for an office to live with.

Pell rested both hands on the edge of the stand. "I thought keeping the books closed kept larger harms from coming through them. I made the same argument over your brother that I made over the Anver, though I did not have the courage to say so then. One late name against the authority of a closed quarter. One people against the peace of the Spill. I called both omissions regrettable and treated the closure as sacred."

Vey looked at him. "And now?"

"Now the first claim asks us to open a map. The platforms are still under us. The people in this room are not tearing the pages apart because they can see them." His eyes went to the line of citizens. "There will be costs. Some claims will take from people who did not make the old wrong. You were never foolish about that, though I spoke as if you were. You were right that hiding the account did not spare us the debt. It spared us from knowing whom we made pay it."

The words did not undo his silence. Vey had no use for an apology that tried to reach backward and alter the hand that received it. But Pell had spent his life turning warnings into walls. Hearing him name the door mattered.

"I was right about the name," she said. "Not about everything that comes after

it."

"You were right about where the count had to start. I was wrong about what closing it protected." He drew a breath. "I was wrong about Brenn."

Vey placed her palm on the casualty ledger. The scraped place rasped under the page. "Then help me correct him."

They took the book to the correction table at the front of the floor.

Under the old rules, Vey would have carried it upstairs to a supervisor and waited outside while he decided whether the past could bear another line. Under the new order, she opened the volume where anyone could watch. Pell fetched the accession stamp. Bren brought the archive box and set the late notice beside the ledger. The citizen reader drawn for the morning happened to be the fish seller, whose name Vey learned from the daily roll only when she signed the panel: Aro Den.

"Family correction?" Aro asked.

"Casualty omission," Vey said. "The unreturned crew member was left off after the quarter closed."

Aro read the launch notice, then turned the casualty book toward the shutters. Daylight brought the scraped letters up through the old ink. "Somebody started his name."

"A receiving clerk did," Pell said. "A senior ordered the line removed. I supervised the floor and allowed the order to stand."

The room had grown quieter. Vey had not called for silence, but the people nearest the table stopped speaking, and attention moved outward until even the clerks at the rear desks waited.

Pell could have given his evidence without confessing his part. The open procedure required a responsible hand for the new correction, not a list of hands that had failed the first one. He put his statement into the public log anyway. His writing had the narrow, patient shape Vey knew from years of bell rosters. At the bottom he signed PELL ARON, FORMER SUPERVISOR, WITNESS TO CLOSURE.

Bren added the archive reference. Aro signed that the physical notice and scraped entry agreed. Last came Vey's finding.

She paused with the stylus above the page. All her life since the north current had bent around this small space. She had imagined restoration as a hand reaching into the water, though she knew no ink could do that. Brenn would not step onto the gangway because a clerk admitted his name. Their mother, dead three years now, would not see the amended family roll. Nothing in the living world changed except the record and those who agreed to answer for it.

That had to be enough, but it did not have to be small.

Vey wrote in the corrections volume: Brenn Corwin, crew N-17, unreturned north current, SY 302. Omitted from certified casualty roll by improper closure. Entry restored on evidence of recovery-launch notice and surviving original mark.

Then she entered his name as forty-four.

The figure at the foot of the old list no longer balanced. She struck forty-three with one line, left it readable, and wrote forty-four beside it. Her initials, the date, and the three readers' names followed. No clean would swallow the earlier number. No later clerk would have to choose between believing a perfect book and believing the scrape beneath the ink.

Aro leaned over the page. "That's all?"

"That's the correction," Vey said.

"I meant after ten years. It takes that little room."

"Most people do."

The fish seller nodded as if this answer had confirmed something unpleasant. She returned to the public register and took an objection form for herself.

Pell remained at the table. "What happens to me?"

"The council kept you on the staff."

"That wasn't what I asked."

Vey cleaned the stylus on a square of rag. She could send him away. Part of her wanted the old upper office empty, its warnings gone with the board and the overnight clean. Another part remembered the cell at the Redoubt, three days bounded because Pell had refused to sign the finding Kendt wanted. Reconciliation could not turn either fact into the whole of him.

"You know where the old corrections were buried," she said. "You know which closures came from the floor and which arrived under Concordance order. We need every one reviewed."

"You want me to find my own omissions."

"I want you to put your name beside what you find."

Pell looked toward the supervisor's office. "Not from up there."

"No. Take the desk beside the public copy."

He accepted this with a tired nod. Bren brought him the first box from the closed-quarter run, and Pell sat where any citizen could see his page. He opened a fresh corrections ledger and began with the oldest index.

At the ninth hour, the bell rang for objections. It no longer closed the count. The clerks stayed at their desks while the three-reader panels formed, citizens sitting beside counters and archive staff beneath the council notice. Outside, a line continued along the gangway in the salt wind. Dock workers held household books under their coats. A mother carried a sleeping child and a birth notice blurred by rain. From the lower landing came another cart of archive boxes.

Vey returned the casualty ledger to Bren. Before he wrapped it, she looked once more at line forty-four. Brenn's name sat in dark ink below the other lost crew, neither larger nor given any decoration. Beside it, the source mark led to the notice in the archive. The first failed entry remained underneath, visible through the scrape.

Across the floor, Pell read an old correction aloud to the person waiting beside him. He gave the source, the date, and the hand that had authorized it. When the person asked why, he did not say the quarter had closed. He turned the book so they could read the reason together.

Bren tied the casualty volume into its wrapper, leaving the corrected page marked with a clean strip of paper. He placed it on the handcart among the founding maps and the day's open objections. At the doorway he pushed through the space where the board had stood. This time no one slowed behind him.

Chapter 23 — The New Tellers

Cira Vell removed the quarantine card from Tarn Redoubt with a screwdriver and laid it on the comparison desk. It looked too small to have hidden a people. Four brass contacts, a strip of black resin, two stamped numbers. When a frequency entered through the tuning head, the card compared its tag against the standing-order table. A match sent the packet to a clearing line. No alarm sounded. No operator touched a key. At the next sync, the curated log recorded degradation where the packet had been.

She had bypassed that card for the breach. She could bypass it again. That no longer counted as repair.

Around her, six Tellers worked with the front panels open and the power reduced to the local bands. Three belonged to Tarn's regular shifts. Two had resigned during Kendt's review and returned after the true census reached the council. The sixth came from the northern platforms, where she maintained a tide relay whose raw spool had preserved one of Vey's early fragments. None wore a Concordance seal on the collar. All had brought their own tools.

The console room held more paper than it had before the broadcast. Replies and exceptions had arrived in degraded blocks, some copied from stations years away, some sent by Tellers who had found old quarantine instructions in their local mirrors. Cira had pinned every readable piece to the cable racks. Dates disagreed. Route marks had fallen out. The same complaint survived in different hands: a standing order could enter a station without leaving a public trace, and a clean could remove the evidence that it had acted.

That mechanism had to go before another order found another band.

"Pull it," said the northern Teller.

Cira kept the screwdriver against the card. "Pulling one card changes one

Redoubt. There are forty worlds and more relay hops than we have names for. Someone seats another card after us, and we're back where we started."

"Then we break the slot."

"Same problem with a hammer added."

She turned the card over. The standing-order contacts sat on the underside, bright where the slot had held them for decades. Nothing in the part distinguished a quarantine of a dangerous carrier fault from a quarantine of a population. The console accepted a number and obeyed. It did not ask what the number removed.

Across the desk, the oldest of the returning Tellers opened the procedure book. Kendt's people had taken the grey manual after the Hold and left the local copy because it carried no classified orders. Its binding had swollen with salt. Its pages still described reconciliation, clearing, and correction as if those actions preserved a record rather than narrowed one.

"We need a procedure a loyal Teller can't misuse quietly," Cira said. "Not one that depends on us staying brave."

No one answered at first. The Redoubt hummed through its reduced load. Fast local traffic passed over the live rack: a platform brace report, two household changes for the Counting House, a storm warning from the western rafts. Far traffic waited in the receiver buffer until the long-range heads came back online. Every silent minute lengthened the queue.

A day-shift Teller tapped the swollen manual. "If we stop clearing, the buffer fills with corrupt packets. If it fills, local notices get delayed behind years of noise. Open every band and the station stops serving Tarn."

"I didn't say stop sorting. I said stop hiding the sort."

Cira drew three boxes on cable-note paper. RECEIVE. RECORD. ROUTE. The old procedure put the standing-order check between receive and record. Packets marked for quarantine disappeared before any ordinary operator could see them. She moved the check to the last box.

"Everything the head detects gets a receipt first," she said. "Time, band, signal length, raw hash. The receipt goes into a ledger the routing controls can't alter. After that, sort what you need. Mark corruption. Delay a flooded band. Quarantine a carrier fault if it can damage the head. But every action appends a second entry to the receipt. Nothing replaces the first one."

The northern Teller leaned over the drawing. "Who reads this ledger?"

"Anyone who reads the relay. We attach its digest to the public service band and to every census packet leaving Tarn. Full copy at the Redoubt, the Counting House, and the northern relay. Paper roll at each shift close."

"A digest won't carry the raw signal."

"It carries proof that a signal arrived and proof of what we did to it. If our full copy changes, the other two no longer match. If all three local copies change, the

digest already moving outward won't match when it reaches another station. Distance makes correction slow. It also makes recall impossible."

One of the resigned Tellers gave a short laugh. "You want to use the Static's worst property as a lock."

"It has been used as an excuse for a hundred years. It can do one useful thing."

They worked from the boxes outward. No one voted on principles. Cira distrusted principles that had not survived contact with a wiring plan. She assigned the tuning-head split to two Tellers, the local mirror line to another, and kept the receipt sequence for herself. The oldest returner began crossing out sections of the manual in pencil. Every deletion had to be followed by replacement text on a fresh page. Even here, in a book six people could see, Cira would not let a correction erase its source.

By second bell, the receiver had two outputs. One ran to the old routing rack. The other ran to a narrow printer that stamped a sequence number before the standing-order table could act. Cira fed it a test carrier tagged with the designation from the removed quarantine card.

The printer struck once.

TARN-RD 000001. BAND RECEIVED. RAW LENGTH 184. HASH 71-4C-09.

Then the routing rack cleared the packet according to the old instruction. A second line appeared beneath the first.

ACTION: QUARANTINE. ORDER: LH-18-441. OPERATOR: AUTOMATIC.

The room went quiet enough that Cira heard the printer ribbon advance.

That pair of lines exposed the old machinery better than any speech could. Under prior procedure, the first line never existed and the second remained buried in a private maintenance table. A person reading the public log would have seen degradation. Now the record showed a signal, an action, and the authority claimed for that action.

"Again," Cira said.

They ran the carrier through with three altered characters. The raw hash changed. The sequence advanced. The same standing order acted, and the ledger appended its number without touching the earlier entry. Cira unplugged the quarantine card and repeated the test. Receipt three appeared. No action followed it.

The day-shift Teller studied all three lines. "An operator can leave the action blank."

"Blank means routed. We add a route receipt at the next hop."

"A dishonest operator can cut power to the ledger printer."

Cira pointed to the split. "Then routing loses power too. Both outputs share the

same feed before they divide. No record, no forward."

"She can falsify the band tag."

"Not without changing the raw hash."

"She can replace both copies before shift close."

"Not the copy sent live to the Counting House."

The objections continued. Cira wanted them. A procedure built among friends often failed when an obedient stranger sat at the desk. They tested cut wires, false times, duplicate sequence numbers, missing paper, a jammed printer, and a clean command issued while the mirror line lagged. Each failure needed a visible state. A red lamp for loss of mirror. A mechanical counter that advanced at detection rather than routing. A rule that closed the long-range head whenever the sequence ledger could not write. The station could fail noisy or fail closed. It could no longer fail invisible.

At midday, a messenger brought the council's authorization for the work. Cira read it once and put it under the tool tray. The council permitted Tarn Redoubt to revise local relay practice pending a Spill-wide concordance. Permission mattered for keeping the doors open. It did not solve the system. A later council could withdraw permission as neatly as the Ledger-House had renewed a standing order.

The oldest returner understood without being told. "We don't put council approval in the receipt path."

"No," Cira said. "They can authorize access. They don't get an eraser."

She drafted the first rule in the new procedure book:

1. A received carrier shall be recorded before classification, correction, delay, quarantine, or forwarding.

The northern Teller added the second:

2. Every action on a received carrier shall append its authority, reason, duration, and responsible shift to that carrier's receipt.

A third followed after an argument about emergencies:

3. A quarantine may interrupt routing at one station. It may not remove the receipt, raw hash, or notice of quarantine from any station record.

Cira wrote the fourth herself:

4. No standing order renews without a new public entry.

That sentence ended the oldest trick. The Anver order had persisted because renewal left no decision in front of the Tellers who obeyed it. Under the rewritten procedure, expiration would open the route unless someone acted in public to close it again. A name, reason, and duration would travel beside the notice. Silence would require maintenance. Maintenance would leave a trail.

The day-shift Teller read the four rules and rubbed relay oil from his thumb. "Ledger-House can reject all of this."

"It can reject Tarn's procedure," Cira said. "It can't pull back the digest once we send it."

That answer troubled him, which meant he understood.

The first outside contribution had started its journey before the true census. It arrived after dark, nested in an exception block from a station whose world mark had lost two characters. Most of the message had degraded into gaps. A Teller's procedure patch remained readable in the middle.

DO NOT TRUST LOCAL CLOCK. SEQUENCE BY RECEIPT. INCLUDE PREVIOUS HASH.

Cira pinned the strip above the desk. Their design used a mechanical sequence, but the sender had identified a weakness they had missed. A station could reset its counter and begin a clean ledger that concealed everything before it. Including the previous entry's hash in the next receipt linked each line to the one before. Resetting the record would expose the break.

She changed the printer plate. Each receipt now carried its own raw hash and the hash of the prior receipt. The ledger became a chain of evidence without pretending the chain could not break. A break would show.

Other patches came from closer stations by Tarn's local network. Tide relays copied the procedure, tested it against weather-band floods, and returned practical failures within hours. One mirror line saturated when storm telemetry arrived in bursts. Another printer tore damp paper at the feed. A platform Teller proposed stamping daily digests onto thin metal foil, then abandoned it when salt made the impression unreadable. Paper, duplicated and sent to separate rooms, worked better.

Farther answers could not help them tonight. Cira knew that. Worlds receiving the open procedure would answer years from now, after Tarn had made mistakes no current ally could foresee. The new rules therefore included a correction method: never overwrite a faulty rule, append a numbered replacement and preserve the rule it changed. Procedure would remain an argument anyone could inspect, not a clean book pretending no one had erred.

Near midnight, they reached the question the room had avoided.

"Who can issue a quarantine now?" asked the northern Teller.

The old answer had been the Ledger-House. Cira could replace that office with a local council, a Teller majority, or a census committee. Every choice put a quieter form of the same power into someone's hands.

She looked at the open panels. "Any shift can interrupt a carrier that threatens equipment or blocks emergency traffic. One station, one stated duration, one local reason. The notice broadcasts on a service band the quarantine cannot touch. Continuing it past one shift takes three signatures from separate relay rooms."

"Three loyal signatures can still bury a band."

"They can stop its route here. They cannot bury its arrival. The receipt and notice remain open. Other stations decide for themselves."

"That breaks the common table."

"Good."

The word came out sharper than Cira intended. She let it stand. A common table had allowed one office to turn a classification into absence across the Spill. The relay mesh had no central server, yet its procedure had created central obedience at every hop. Separate judgment would produce disagreement, duplicated traffic, and ugly records. It would also deny any single station the power to define what all others had heard.

Cira added two more rules. Quarantines could not propagate as commands. They traveled as notices. Receiving stations had to record the notice and choose their own action. Every choice appended locally and returned outward when bandwidth allowed.

The procedure no longer promised one clean record. It promised visible records that could disagree.

Before they closed the manual, Cira brought out six months of pre-breach raw spools. Kendt's review had missed them because she had filed them with tuning calibrations instead of census traffic. The group passed each receipt through a hand comparison against the curated station log. Missing weather packets went in one column. Damaged carriers went in another. Deliberate clearances went onto a separate sheet with their standing-order numbers.

Seventeen bands had been quietly quarantined. The Anver designation accounted for most of the traffic, but not all. One band carried nothing they could render except regular timing marks. Another had transmitted three short census blocks before the clear removed it. A third appeared once, too damaged to classify, under an order renewed nine times without a stated reason. Cira knew better than to turn every unknown signal into a hidden people. The record supported a narrower conclusion: the station had received them, an authority had stopped them, and no public log had admitted either fact.

They entered those old actions into the new ledger as historical receipts. Estimates took the place of lost raw hashes and carried an ESTIMATED stamp. Gaps stayed gaps. The oldest returner objected that an incomplete reconstruction would make Tarn look careless.

"We were careless," Cira said. "A clean reconstruction would repeat the problem."

The historical page forced another addition to procedure. Every station adopting the rules had to publish its active standing-order table, including orders for bands it could no longer identify. A Teller could challenge an entry by appending evidence. No one could remove it after an order expired. Old obedience would

remain available for inspection beside new judgment.

At the bottom of the page, Cira recorded the removed card as physical evidence. She included its two stamped numbers, the contact layout, and the drawer where it would remain. A later operator could compare the object with the entries and test their account. Procedure did not ask anyone to trust Cira's memory.

Only after that audit did they close the manual. Six signatures ran down the amendment leaf. Beside them sat seventeen bands that had returned to the record, not recovered and not explained, but no longer quiet.

On the second morning, Cira restored the long-range heads. The receiver buffer opened into the new split. Paper began moving through the receipt printer in uneven taps.

Most entries held noise. The open ledger did not make corruption meaningful. It showed what had arrived before a person decided meaning. Weather hiss took six lines. A broken census packet took three. An old marriage notice appeared for a world whose route tag had vanished. Operators classified each one, and every classification followed its receipt rather than replacing it.

Then the Anver band reached the head.

Cira recognized its structure before the renderer found a readable mark. Repeating intervals held inside the damaged carrier, patient under years of loss. The mechanical counter advanced. The printer struck a new receipt with the old designation in full.

No card diverted it. No automatic action appeared below it.

The renderer stacked the signal against prior arrivals. A household mark surfaced, then a weir number, then four characters from a name. Cira had spent years seeing those pieces survive only in margins. Now they occupied the ordinary route like weather, census, and local repair traffic. Not privileged. Not cleared. Received.

She waited for the routing receipt. The printer advanced and stamped FORWARDED, followed by Tarn's time and the next-hop table. A mirror copy reached the Counting House on the fast local line. Another moved north. The daily digest joined the service band, carrying the Anver receipt and every action before and after it.

The northern Teller watched the paper curl into the tray. "That's one station."

"Yes," Cira said.

Years would pass before the whole mesh adopted anything. Some stations would keep their old cards. Some Tellers would obey private tables and call Tarn reckless. A few would receive the procedure after their governments had already learned to fear the claims attached to the true census. No design could make them

honest. Cira had given honest work a form that could survive dishonest hands, and dishonest work a mark it had not carried before.

At third bell, she opened the public access door beside the Redoubt's main entrance. It had once admitted auditors and senior Tellers. The council had removed the seal after the broadcast. Inside, Cira mounted the first completed roll behind glass and placed a crank at reading height. Any clerk, fisher, household counter, or council runner could turn through the day's receipts. Raw signals remained protected from damage in the station copy, but their hashes, routes, classifications, delays, and quarantines belonged to the public record.

A young counting clerk arrived with the morning packet and stopped at the case. He read receipt one, the test quarantine with its standing-order number. Then he turned forward until he found the live Anver band. Cira did not explain either entry. The procedure had to survive without her beside it.

Back in the console room, the Tellers signed the shift page. Not as witnesses to a finished reform. Their names identified who had handled the relay and what each had changed. The oldest returner signed beside the crossed-out cleaning rule. The northern Teller signed beside the mirror test. Cira signed beneath the receipt split, then added the raw hash of the page to the outbound digest.

She replaced the front panel but left the quarantine slot empty. The removed card went into the evidence drawer with its order number facing up. Destroying it would have made a satisfying mistake. Keeping it gave the next Teller proof of how little machinery a quiet erasure had required.

Outside the room, the public crank clicked one tooth at a time as the clerk moved through the roll. Inside, the printer received another far carrier and struck its sequence onto paper before anyone could classify it. The routing rack followed. Two records moved apart through the Redoubt, one toward the mesh and one toward the open case by the door, each carrying the same number.

Chapter 24 — The Inheritance of the Counted

At the ninth-hour bell, a woman from South Trawl disputed her own existence.

She stood before the three-reader panel with a household book tucked under one arm and salt dried to the knees of her trousers. Tarn's new register listed her among the living, assigned her a platform, gave her a birth year, and carried three source marks beside her name. The woman agreed with none of them except the name.

"I left South Trawl six years ago," she said. "Platform broke in the spring surge. I live on Gannet Chain now. That birth year belonged to my sister, who died before the move. Your book has made one person out of two."

The receiving clerk turned the public copy toward her. Under the old procedure, a correction would have replaced the row and left a clean result. Now he drew one

line through the platform and birth fields. He did not touch the name. The archive reader fetched the South Trawl loss roll, while the citizen reader asked the woman to spell her sister's name.

Vey watched from the end of the table. She had come to supervise the first full-quarter objection session, though the panels no longer needed a supervisor's permission to hear anyone. Forty-seven people waited along the counting floor. Their papers made soft, uneven sounds as the platform shifted under them.

Nothing about the woman's complaint threatened the peace of the Spill. No founding water depended on her proper ward. No Registrar would send an auditor to defend the wrong birth year. Yet the two errors had taken something practical. Gannet Chain had received too little storm allotment because its count missed a worker. South Trawl had drawn rations for a person who no longer lived there. A dead sister had lent her age to the living because two damaged lines fitted neatly when joined.

By the time the archive roll arrived, the woman had found her sister's death notice folded into the back of the household book. The panel compared paper, signatures, and dates. It restored the sister under her own name among the dead and moved the living woman to Gannet Chain. Both prior fields stayed readable below the corrections.

"Do I have to come back next quarter?" she asked.

"You should inspect the entry," the clerk said.

"That wasn't my question."

The clerk looked toward Vey.

She could have promised the correction would hold. The sources supported it. Three readers had signed. A person who spent half a day carrying proof across Halversand deserved more than an invitation to repeat the work. But the old Counting House had offered permanence by placing its errors beyond appeal. Vey would not sell that promise in kinder words.

"If no one changes the entry, it carries forward," she said. "If another source disagrees, both records remain until you can answer. If we make another error, come back."

The woman frowned. "So you might be wrong again."

"Yes."

That answer satisfied her less than a seal would have. She read the new line anyway, pressed one salt-rough thumb beside her name, and took a copy home.

Across the floor, objections moved from hand to hand. A storm widow challenged the date that ended her partner's ration standing. Two cousins each claimed the same boat-house after a badly copied inheritance. A north-platform cooperative demanded that an Anver founding map carry the present mooring lines beside the old basin names. At another table, a relay clerk entered notice that

three packets supporting a distant household count had arrived with conflicting dates.

The day's work did not converge on one clean total. It produced a total with reasons attached, objections pending, and several lines no honest clerk could close. The number on the wall had gained twelve people since morning, lost four duplicates, and moved thirty-one between wards. Beneath it, in type large enough to read from the doorway, appeared the date of computation and the number of unresolved challenges.

Vey had once believed a count earned trust by balancing. She still wanted the columns to meet. Arithmetic caught careless hands and false additions. It could not decide whose paper deserved to become a person, or whether a damaged transmission carried a household or a memory of one. Those judgments entered through people. Pretending otherwise had allowed judgment to hide inside a total.

At the final table, Pell read an old closure notice aloud to a rope maker whose father had vanished from a labor roll. He occupied the desk beside the public register now. Archive boxes stood around his chair in low walls, each one opened and indexed. His former supervisor's cord had not returned to his coat.

When he finished the notice, the rope maker said, "I don't agree."

Pell dipped his pen. "Then we enter that first."

He wrote the objection before asking the man to prove it.

The ninth-hour bell had once ended public business. This time it marked the beginning of another session. Vey listened until its last vibration left the rafters, then took her coat from the peg. Bren had sent a note from the archive asking her to inspect a transferred volume before he moved it into the open run. She knew which volume he meant.

Rain had darkened the boards between the Counting House and the archive, though the west sky had begun to clear. Halversand rode a long tide. Gangway hinges rose and lowered under Vey's feet, keeping the joined platforms level enough for carts.

Council notices covered the railings. One announced the Anver claim hearings. Another listed present charter holders whose northern-water filings required review. A third gave the public hours for the Redoubt's relay ledger. Someone had written NOT YOUR WATER across the first notice. Another hand had added WHOSE beneath it. A clerk had resisted the old habit of scraping both away. He had dated the marks and pinned a clean copy beside them.

People argued at every landing, but the arguments had become more specific. Oyster crews asked how a century of harvest would be valued. Council readers debated whether founding use meant ownership, passage, or stewardship under the oldest translation. Tellers wanted guaranteed access for every recorded band. Families on the northern platforms demanded that occupancy survive any

settlement. The Reckoning had not arrived as one bill. It had opened drawers throughout the city.

Vey passed the council platform without entering. She had given evidence there twice in eight days and had begun to recognize the benches by the splinters in their rails. Today's hearing concerned maps, not counts. That distinction mattered. A census could admit a claimant. It could not decide what a claimant received.

At the archive door, Bren had propped a stone beneath the hinge to admit the damp wind. Handcarts filled the entry passage. The old closed-quarter boxes were moving from the sealed run into a room where readers could request them by source mark. Each box carried two labels: the office's former description and the new public index. LATE MATERIAL, NO ACTION had become CASUALTY AND HOUSEHOLD NOTICES REQUIRING REVIEW. UNSETTLED APPENDICES had become RECORDS EXCLUDED FROM AUTHORIZED COUNT.

"You renamed half my archive," Bren said from behind a cart.

"You said names mattered."

"They matter so much that every council clerk wants a different one. Come in before I give this room a number and refuse all language."

He led her past the public tables into the casualty aisle. No lock guarded the shelves. A reader still had to sign for a volume, and Bren inspected every hand for oil, wet, or loose ink. Openness had not made him careless with paper.

The north-current ledger rested on a sloped stand under a shaded lamp. Its wrapper lay folded beside it. Bren had opened the book to the SY 302 casualty roll and placed the late recovery notice beneath a clear holding strip.

Line forty-four carried Brenn Corwin.

Vey approached without touching the page. She had entered the correction herself. Her own initials followed the finding, with Pell's witness mark, Bren's archive reference, and Aro Den's citizen signature. The old total of forty-three remained under a single stroke. Beside it stood forty-four in darker ink.

Seeing the restored entry in the counting room had felt like an act. Here, among the years it would outlast, the line looked smaller. Brenn occupied less width than the notice that explained his omission. The book did not carry his laugh, the scar on his knuckle, or the way he rowed too hard at the start of a long current. It did not say he teased Vey for checking a net by counting knots. It recorded that crew N-17 returned without him and that an office had failed to name the loss.

Being counted had never meant being contained. The line could not hold a life. It could hold the place from which law, ration, inheritance, mourning, and memory had no right to push that life aside.

Bren waited at the next shelf, close enough to answer and far enough not to witness for her. He had put on his archive gloves, though he handled no paper.

"Why did you need me to inspect it?" Vey asked.

"Transfer rule requires the correcting hand to confirm the source links. I can do it with another census reader if you prefer."

"No. I'll confirm them."

She checked each mark. The late notice matched the accession number. The scraped first attempt at Brenn's name had its own image plate. Pell's statement pointed to the closure log. A reader following the chain would not have to believe Vey because grief had made her certain. The record gave that reader evidence.

One field on the transfer form asked whether the correction settled the entry.

Vey held her pen above the two boxes, YES and CONTESTED. The second term had been added for property disputes and uncertain household merges. Brenn's record faced no competing claim. No one argued that crew N-17 had returned whole. Marking it contested seemed to weaken a correction that had taken ten years.

Still, the source date might be wrong. Another launch roll could surface. A witness might identify where the crew separated or show that Brenn reached a raft not entered in Tarn's books. Even the finding UNRETURNED described the edge of what the Counting House knew, not the end of him.

She marked CONTESTED and wrote beneath it: RESTORATION SUPPORTED; DETAILS REMAIN OPEN TO FURTHER RECORD.

Bren came to read the line. "You expect an objection?"

"No."

"Then why leave it open?"

"Because no finding should depend on no one having reached the shelf yet."

The archivist considered the words, then added the transfer date. He did not ask whether she felt restored herself. Vey valued him for that.

Together they moved the volume onto the open casualty run. Bren placed it between two years of storm and current losses. He left a marker at line forty-four, not to elevate Brenn over the others but to guide readers from the public correction index to its source.

Vey slid the ledger into place. For ten years, her brother's absence from a list had taught her to treat inclusion as the finish of the work. His name now showed the harder truth. Inclusion opened obligations. Someone had to preserve the source, hear a challenge, correct the correction, and refuse the comfort of a final hand.

Before she left, Bren gave her a thin bundle tied with blue thread. "First-quarter objections," he said. "Copies for the rules committee. Pell sent his recommendations too."

"How many?"

"Two hundred nine formal challenges. More notes than anyone counted."

"Those count too."

"Then you can count them. I have shelves to rename."

The committee met after dusk at the public table rather than in the supervisor's office. Vey sat with Pell, Aro Den, two ward clerks, a council reader, and a Teller from the Redoubt. Cira had sent the Teller with a copy of the new relay procedure and a message in her direct hand: DO NOT LET THEM MAKE THE PUBLIC LEDGER OPTIONAL.

No one at the table proposed that. They found other ways to narrow it.

The council reader wanted objections removed from the headline total after a panel ruled. One ward clerk wanted a time limit, arguing that no office could answer claims carried forward without end. The Teller asked whether damaged offworld counts should enter Tarn's public volume before local confirmation. Aro wanted every citizen reader paid the same as a clerk. Pell had marked seven old correction codes that still allowed an entry to disappear when two categories merged.

Vey spread the bundle from Bren between them. Each objection represented friction the former system had concealed. Some lacked evidence. Several contradicted one another. Nine appeared to be attempts to draw double storm allotments. An open census did not turn every claim true. It made the decision to refuse one visible.

"We need a closed figure for allocations," said the southern ward clerk. "Food, berths, school places. We cannot distribute a provisional loaf."

"Use the best supported figure on the date of allocation," Vey said. "Publish what remains disputed beside it."

"People will read the larger number when it benefits them and the smaller one when it does not."

"They did that when the disagreement stayed hidden too."

The council reader tapped the objection stack. "If nothing settles, authority moves from the count to whoever can keep arguing."

Pell looked at Vey but left the answer to her.

She understood the fear. The Authorized Census had gained force because worlds needed a shared figure across years of distance. A number that arrived with every question still attached might fail to coordinate anything. Forty worlds could not reopen the same household entry together. The Static would deliver an objection long after the count it challenged had shaped law.

"A ruling can settle what an office does today," Vey said. "It cannot settle what may be shown tomorrow. We date the ruling. We name its sources. We carry the objection after the decision, not as a veto, but as part of the record."

"For how long?"

"As long as the entry survives."

Several hands stopped moving.

Aro untied another bundle. "That will make a large book."

"Then we make more books."

The southern clerk shook his head. "You trust paper more than labor. Someone has to maintain every dead argument."

"The archive can classify repeated objections without copying every word into the working roll," Vey said. "But the source remains reachable. A person reading the figure must be able to find what challenged it."

"And the Spill census?" asked the Teller. "Our open ledger can send receipts. It cannot send every local dispute on every hop."

Vey took Cira's procedure and found the rule for digesting actions. The relay preserved a raw receipt, then sent a smaller proof outward. Census objections could travel in the same layered form. A local book kept the whole claim. The shared count carried its source mark, disposition, and a route by which later packets could request the body. Loss would damage the argument, as it damaged everything, but no clean total would pretend an argument had never existed.

They drafted until the lamps needed oil. Clause by clause, the committee separated current use from permanent truth. A certified figure could govern until the next computation. A panel decision could bind a Tarn office unless appealed. Neither act erased the challenge or barred new evidence. Every edition of the Spill count would state its date, age, sources, exclusions, and unresolved objections. The word AUTHORIZED came out of the heading. RECONCILED remained.

Pell read the last provision twice. "You know what this means."

"More archive carts," Bren called from the doorway. He had arrived with the second bundle and heard enough.

Pell ignored him. "It means your true census can be challenged by the same people who challenged the old one."

"It should be."

"Even the Anver entries?"

"Especially entries restored by people who believe they acted rightly."

The sentence hurt, though not because she doubted the Anver lived. Vey had built the true census against an institution that called its own judgment necessary. If she protected her work from challenge, necessity would return under her signature.

She drew the final sheet toward her and wrote a title above the provisions: RULES FOR A CONTESTED CENSUS. Beneath it, she added the condition no earlier ledger had carried. Every count would close for use and remain open for

correction.

One by one, the committee members signed as drafters, not authorities. The rules would go to public reading in the morning. Citizens could object before the council adopted them. Vey's name appeared first because her hand had prepared the sheet. It gave her no power to make the words final.

Near midnight, she returned alone to the counting floor. The public register remained on its stand facing the doors. Lamps had been lowered, and the room shifted with the tide around the steady mass of desks.

Vey entered the day's revised total in the quarter book. She attached the two hundred nine challenge marks, the panel dispositions completed so far, and the source route to the rest. In the certification field she wrote VALID FOR CURRENT ALLOCATION. Under final status, she did not choose SETTLED.

A local line printer clicked beside the wall. Tarn Redoubt sent its nightly digest, each received carrier listed before classification. The Anver band occupied one row. Weather hiss occupied the next. Farther down, a damaged census packet had arrived with a world mark missing and no total anyone could use. Cira's procedure kept its receipt anyway.

From the open shutters came the knock of a counting skiff against the lower landing. A young clerk stepped into the room carrying the Gannet Chain lantern roll. One household had moved after the objection session, and the raft counter had sent the change before sleep. Vey checked the mark, appended the move, and gave the clerk a receipt.

He crossed to the wall total and replaced its final digit on the hinged number board. Then he hung the superseded digit from a hook below, beside the date and the objection count, rather than returning it to the type drawer.

The board now showed what Tarn would use in the morning. Underneath, the earlier figure remained in view. Through the shutters, lanterns along Gannet Chain rose and dipped with their platforms, each light held on a separate hook above the water. The clerk opened the public register to the new line and left it there beneath the lamp.

Epilogue — The Full Static

By SY 320, the relay at Tarn Redoubt carried more paper than the old station had ever been built to hold. Receipt rolls filled the public cases and continued into the former auditors' room, where cabinets stood open to anyone willing to turn a crank. Each morning the printer struck out the latest arrivals: household totals, corrections, claims, weather losses, route failures, births sent years ago from worlds that had not yet received Tarn's answer.

Vey Corwin came on the first counting day of the year with a school group from

Halversand. She no longer worked every bell at the Counting House. Her hair had begun to grey above the ears, and the fingers of her writing hand stiffened in wet weather. She still carried a small book in her coat, though most days she used it for questions rather than missing names.

Through the open console-room door, the long-range heads gave off their steady hum. The Static had not become clear. Messages still crossed the Spill slowly, shedding characters and pages at every hop. The new Tellers had learned to send counts in overlapping parts, with receipts from separate routes and enough repetition for distant clerks to rebuild what loss removed. No office promised a perfect copy. Every station showed its gaps.

Even so, the complete count had reached Tarn that morning.

It occupied twenty-three rolls and drew from thirty-eight reporting worlds, six relay communities without settled worlds, the Anver Deeps, and four populations restored since Vey's broadcast. Some entries had arrived seven years late. One column carried three disputed totals beside one another. Another listed a people whose own name had survived on one route and vanished on two. Nothing had been cleaned into agreement. The full census held the differences and named who had supplied each figure.

A teacher led the children to the wall chart. It showed the Spill as points connected by thin route lines. Older charts had marked human settlements in black and left the water claims blank. This one used no separate color for standing. Beside Tarn's point, a blue set of lines showed the founding waters under review.

A child near the front raised her hand. "Are those Tarn?"

"They overlap Tarn," the teacher said.

"Who lives there?"

"People have lived on the platforms for generations. The older claims belong to the Anver."

The child studied the chart. "Are they another world?"

"They are part of the Spill. They were here before the human settlement, and for a long time our shared count left them out."

This answer required no lowered voice. No adult looked toward the door before the word Anver could be spoken. The children accepted it with the practical seriousness they gave to tide boundaries and household wards. One asked whether Anver children had census duty. Another wanted to know how a count traveled through water. The teacher admitted that the lesson packet did not say.

Vey wrote the question in her book.

The first claims had not ended cleanly. Tarn had returned some waters, opened others to shared use, and paid relay allotments from three generations of public budgets. Hearings continued over maps whose coastlines no longer matched the sea. Two councils had fallen. On Osel, a restored population had rejected the first

settlement and filed again. Drase had died before the largest concordance convened, leaving behind a final memorandum that argued for managed admission and no renewed silence.

None of that resembled peace as Pell had once described it. It resembled work, public and unfinished.

Near the receipt case, a boy had reached the latest Anver roll. The renderer had recovered a household sequence, a weir mark, and nine names. Six lines ended in blanks where the relay had eaten the rest. He traced one gap with his finger.

"Does this person still count if the name is broken?" he asked.

Vey looked at the source marks. Three stations had received portions of the line. A fourth copy remained in transit, if its route held. Years earlier, nineteen such entries had appeared in Tarn's register as phantoms, and every rule of the office had told her to clear them.

"Yes," she said. "The break tells us what we still have to find. It doesn't remove the person."

The boy nodded and copied the surviving marks onto his lesson slate. He left room for the missing letters.

At the far desk, Cira's receipt procedure had reached its sixth revision. Each earlier rule remained bound beneath the current one, crossed but readable. Vey's own first shadow ledger rested in a glass cabinet nearby. The leather had warped, and Bren's archive tags crowded its spine. Visitors sometimes paused over it because the card called it the beginning of the true census. Vey knew better. The work had begun in every household count that refused an easy closure. Her book had supplied one route among many.

The printer sounded again. A fresh strip advanced beneath the glass, carrying an Anver route mark followed by a correction from Kess. The machine stamped both before any Teller judged them.

Vey stood with the children and listened to the relay hum. She no longer heard a hidden frequency inside it. She heard weather, damage, argument, and names arriving out of order. The sound offered no promise that the count would remain honest. It only showed that enough hands now kept the record open for dishonesty to leave a mark.

The grey in her hair caught in the case glass when she leaned closer. Beside her reflection, the boy added the Anver household to his slate under the same heading as Tarn, Kess, and Osel. He checked the copied marks against the roll, found one error, and corrected it without rubbing the first attempt away.